

West of Ireland Planting Guide

Soil, sun, and species notes for gardening on the
Atlantic coast

DRAINAGE: YOUR MOST IMPORTANT RULE

West of Ireland clay soil is typically heavy, poorly draining, and mildly acidic to neutral (pH ~6.0–7.0). The Atlantic climate brings very high rainfall year-round. **The single most important thing you can do for the majority of these plants is improve drainage before planting.**

General clay soil recipe for most non-ericaceous plants:

- Dig each planting hole at least twice the width and depth of the rootball
- Mix the excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost
- Add 20–30% horticultural grit by volume to that mix
- After planting, mulch with horticultural bark (5–7cm), keeping mulch away from stems/crowns
- Test your soil pH before planting — west of Ireland soils vary considerably

HOW TO USE YOUR MATERIALS

Material	Best Use
Clay soil	Base for all in-ground plantings
Multipurpose compost	Soil amendment for most plants (50/50 with clay)
Ericaceous compost	Blueberry · Heather · Lingonberry · Cranberry · Japanese Maple (partial) · Star Magnolia (partial) · Deer Fern · Hydrangea macrophylla (for blue flowers) · Japanese Skimmia · Dicksonia antarctica (partial) · Japanese Camellia · Prickly Heath
Horticultural bark	Surface mulch for all in-ground plants (5–7cm), keep away from stems
Horticultural grit	Drainage improver mixed into clay (20–30%); vital for rosemary, lavender, roses, peonies, pasqueflower, fritillaria, creeping juniper, dianthus, phlox subulata, bearded iris, dwarf iris, alliums, freesia, ixia, sempervivum, saxifrage, campanula saxifraga, edelweiss, auricula, siberian statice
Small pebbles	Base drainage layer in pots; decorative surface mulch for Mediterranean herbs and rock plants
Vermiculite	Seed-starting; mix into potting compost for moisture retention
Perlite	Drainage improver in pots (10–20%); especially for rosemary, lavender, blueberry, acidanthera, herbs

THE PLANTS

Groups: A = Annual Flowers | B = Bulbs | C = Climbers & Wall Plants | F = Fruit Trees & Shrubs | G = Groundcover & Creeping Plants | H = Kitchen Herbs & Vegetables | P = Ornamental Perennials | S = Shade & Woodland Plants | T = Ornamental Trees & Shrubs | W = Pond & Water Plants

GROUP A: ANNUAL FLOWERS

A2. Cornflower (*Centaurea cyanus*)

Russian: Василёк синий

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit; avoid over-rich ground, which produces weak, floppy stems.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1–2cm deep, spring (or autumn for earlier flowers).

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

Fertiliser: Little required.

Companions: Poppies, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima — classic hardy-annual cutting garden mix, and good for pollinators.

West of Ireland: Easy, reliable, and long-flowering through summer if deadheaded regularly. Self-seeds freely; the classic bright blue form is most traditional, though pink and white forms are also available.

A3. Greater Quaking Grass (*Briza maxima*)

Russian: Трясунка большая

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: Sow seed 5mm deep in spring, direct or in trays.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

Fertiliser: Little required; over-feeding produces floppy growth.

Companions: Cornflower, poppies, love-in-a-mist — classic annual cutting-garden/cottage border mix; the papery seed heads are excellent for dried arrangements.

West of Ireland: An easy hardy annual ornamental grass with distinctive nodding, oat-like seed heads that rustle in the breeze — self-seeds readily, so allow some heads to drop if you want it to return next year, or deadhead if not.

A4. Lacy Phacelia (*Phacelia tanacetifolia*)

Russian: Фацелия пижмолистная

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Very unfussy.

Soil prep: Minimal — often used as a green manure/cover crop precisely because it grows so easily on poor or heavy ground.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, spring through summer for successional flowering.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; annual, sow successionally

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Excellent sown alongside or near vegetable beds and fruit — one of the very best plants for attracting bees and other pollinators, and can be dug in as a green manure to improve soil structure.

West of Ireland: Fast, easy, and highly valuable for pollinators, with fuzzy purple-blue flower heads. Sow a patch near the vegetable garden or fruit trees to boost pollination, or use as a soil-improving green manure between crops.

A5. Love-in-a-Mist (*Nigella damascena*)

Irish / Russian: Nigéal · Чернушка дамасская (девица в зелени, нигелла)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, spring or autumn, direct where it is to flower (dislikes root disturbance from transplanting).

Spacing: 20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed if soil is poor; otherwise little required.

Companions: Cornflower, poppies, briza maxima — classic hardy annual cutting garden mix; the inflated seed pods are attractive dried.

West of Ireland: Airy, feathery foliage surrounds delicate blue, white or pink flowers in summer, followed by ornamental seed pods. Self-seeds very readily — thin seedlings if too dense, or deadhead before seed pods form if self-seeding isn't wanted.

A6. Poppies (*Papaver* spp., e.g. *P. rhoeas*, Shirley poppies)

Irish / Russian: *Cailleach dhearg* · *Мак самолейка*

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit; avoid over-rich ground.

Planting depth: Sow seed on the surface or just barely covered (needs light to germinate), spring or autumn, direct where it is to flower.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely

Fertiliser: Little required.

Companions: Cornflower, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima — classic hardy annual meadow/cutting garden mix.

West of Ireland: The classic annual field/Shirley poppy self-seeds very freely and is one of the easiest hardy annuals to naturalise in a sunny border or wildflower patch. (Note: perennial Oriental poppies, *Papaver orientale*, are a different, longer-lived border plant with similar sun/drainage needs if a non-annual poppy is wanted instead.)

A7. Sweet Peas (*Lathyrus odoratus*)

Russian: *Душистый горошек*

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig in plenty of compost — sweet peas are hungrier and thirstier than most annuals. Improve drainage with grit if the site is very wet.

Planting depth: Sow seed 2cm deep, spring (or autumn under cover for earlier, stronger plants).

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants against support

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed weekly once flowering begins; a high-potash feed (tomato feed) encourages more blooms.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis — grow up the same wall/trellis for a long season of colour; also a classic vegetable-garden companion, attracting pollinators.

West of Ireland: Fragrant, prolific climbing annual for a sunny wall, trellis or wigwam of canes — regular picking (rather than letting pods form) is the key to a long flowering season. Needs support to climb by tendrils and consistent moisture at the roots.

GROUP B: BULBS

B1. Acidanthera (*Gladiolus murielae*)

Russian: *Шпажник Мюриэл*

Light: ☀ Full sun — essential. Plant in the warmest, sunniest spot available.

Soil needs: Fertile, well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Plant on sharp sand base.

Planting depth: 10–16cm deep on a bed of sharp sand. Plant April–May. Lift after first frosts; dry and store frost-free.

Spacing: 15–20cm between corms

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser or tomato feed fortnightly from when shoots appear until flowering in August–September. Feed until foliage begins to die down.

Companions: Salvias, dahlias, gladioli, ornamental grasses, white agapanthus. Elegant near deep purple salvias or against dark evergreen hedging.

B2. Anemone (spring: *A. blanda*, *A. nemorosa*; Japanese/autumn: *A. × hybrida*)

Irish / Russian: Lus na gaoithe · Ветреница нежная

Spring anemones: **Light:** ☁ Partial shade (woodland conditions). *A. nemorosa* is native Irish.

Spacing: Spring Anemone: 10cm between corms. Japanese/Autumn Anemone: 45–60cm between plants; can spread. **Planting depth:** 5–8cm deep, in autumn (September–October). Soak de Caen corms 24 hours before planting. Fully hardy — never needs lifting. **Fertiliser:** Not heavy feeders. Light balanced fertiliser in spring. Allow foliage to die back naturally. **Companions:** Snowdrops, bluebells, foxgloves in woodland-edge bed.

Japanese/Autumn anemones: **Light:** 🌤 Partial shade to full sun. Excellent in semi-shaded spots. **Planting depth:** At pot level; plant potted rhizomes in spring. Fully hardy — never needs lifting. **Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser in spring and compost mulch. Low-maintenance.

Companions: Hostas, astilbe, hellebores (all share moisture and partial-shade requirements). Can spread — be aware in small borders.

B4. Corn Lily (*Ixia* spp.)

Russian: Иксия

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Light, very free-draining soil; pH 6.0–7.0. Corms rot in wet, heavy clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with grit, or grow in containers of free-draining compost for best results.

Planting depth: 8–10cm deep, pointed end up, in spring (March–April) once frost risk has passed.

Spacing: 5–8cm between corms

Fertiliser: Low-nitrogen bulb/liquid feed while in leaf; avoid feeding once foliage dies back.

Companions: Freesia and other South African corms with similar sun and drainage needs.

West of Ireland: Borderline hardy (RHS H3) — in most of the west of Ireland best grown in pots that can be given a sheltered, dry position over winter, or lifted after the foliage dies down in autumn and stored dry and frost-free like gladioli, replanting the following spring. Wiry stems of star-shaped flowers in early summer.

B5. Crocus (*Crocus* spp.)

Russian: Крокус

Light: ☀ Full sun preferred for most types. *C. speciosus* 'Albus' tolerates light shade under deciduous shrubs. Spring crocuses: sunny border, lawn or pot. Autumn crocuses: as for spring types.

Soil needs: Well-drained to gritty, poor to moderately fertile, pH 6.0–7.5. On heavy clay, add a handful of horticultural grit beneath each corm to prevent waterlogging. Spring types tolerate summer moisture if drainage is right; specialist alpine types prefer dry summers and are best grown in pots.

Soil prep: Add 20–25% grit to clay planting areas. In lawns, use a bulb auger or trowel to make individual holes; place a little grit beneath each corm.

Planting depth: To naturalise *C. tommasinianus* and *C. chrysanthus* plant 7–10cm deep in small groups. In garden lawns, Dutch hybrids have bigger corms and can go deeper at 12cm. Space individually about 9cm apart. Plant with pointed tip facing upward in September–November (autumn-flowering species such as *C. speciosus* are planted a little earlier, in August). A 20cm pot holds 15–20 corms comfortably — layer them 5–8cm deep, almost touching, for a dense display. Use a mix of multipurpose compost and horticultural grit (roughly 3:1) for sharp drainage. Fully hardy — corms are left in the ground permanently and never need lifting.

Spacing: 8–9cm between corms

Fertiliser: Feed after flowering when leaves are still in active growth. Very little feeding required otherwise. A light balanced bulb fertiliser while foliage is green is sufficient. Allow foliage to yellow before removing — this feeds the corm for the following year.

Companions: For a layered spring display in grass, combine crocus with snowdrops (January–February) and daffodils (March–April). The three together give nearly four months of colour before the grass needs cutting. Muscari, squill, and winter aconites are also superb companions. Excellent beneath deciduous shrubs. Do not mow for at least 6 weeks after flowering in lawns. ⚠ Squirrels and mice dig up freshly planted corms — cover with chicken wire for the first season.

Pot size: Use pots at least 15cm deep with drainage holes. A 20cm pot holds 15–20 corms comfortably.

West of Ireland: Crocuses naturalise magnificently in Irish gardens. *C. tommasinianus* (the 'Tommie' — early February, pale lilac) self-seeds prolifically and forms spreading carpets within a few years. Autumn-flowering types (*C. speciosus*, *C. sativus* — saffron crocus) extend interest into October–November.

B7. Daffodils (*Narcissus* spp.)

Irish / Russian: *Lus an chromchinn* · Нарцисс

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Naturalise under deciduous trees.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Add grit at base of each planting hole.

Planting depth: 15cm (3× bulb height). Plant September–October. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

Spacing: 10–15cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser after flowering while foliage still green. Allow foliage to yellow for at least 6 weeks before removing. Autumn compost mulch on naturalised drifts.

Companions: Snowdrops (succession), tulips (follow on), Pulmonaria and muscari for ground cover. Naturalise magnificently under apple trees.

B8. Dwarf Iris (*Iris reticulata*)

Russian: Ирис сетчатый

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil essential; pH 6.0–7.5. Bulbs rot in wet, heavy clay over winter.

Soil prep: Improve clay generously with 30–40% horticultural grit; excellent drainage is the key requirement. Raised beds, troughs or pots are often more reliable than open clay ground.

Planting depth: 8–10cm deep, pointed end up, in autumn. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

Spacing: 5–8cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Bonemeal or bulb fertiliser at planting (autumn). Low-nitrogen liquid feed while in leaf after flowering, to build next year's bulb.

Companions: Snowdrops, crocus and dwarf daffodils for a very early, low-growing spring display; also excellent at the front of a border or in rockeries.

West of Ireland: One of the earliest bulbs to flower, often in February. Best in a very free-draining spot such as a raised bed, trough or pot given typical clay drainage; can struggle to persist in heavy wet ground.

B9. Freesia (*Freesia* spp.)

Russian: Фрезия

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Light, free-draining soil; pH 6.0–7.0. Corms are tender/half-hardy and dislike cold, wet clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay with grit and compost, or grow entirely in containers of multipurpose/free-draining compost for reliability.

Planting depth: 5–8cm deep, pointed end up, in spring (March–April) once frost risk has passed.

Spacing: 5–8cm between corms

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed fortnightly once in growth, until foliage yellows after flowering.

Companions: Ixia, other South African corms with similar needs; good in mixed pots with other tender bulbs.

West of Ireland: Not reliably frost-hardy (RHS H2–H3) — in most west of Ireland gardens best grown in containers that can be moved under cover, or lifted and stored dry over winter like gladioli. Fragrant, long-lasting cut flowers.

B3. Fritillaria (*Fritillaria* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Checkered Lily (Snake's Head Fritillary)	<i>F. meleagris</i>	20–30cm	April–May	10cm deep	Checkered purple-and-white nodding bells; tolerates damp clay far better than the rest — the easiest to naturalise
Crown Imperial	<i>F. imperialis</i>	80cm–1.2m	April–May	20–30cm deep, on its side	Tall crown-topped spike of orange, red or yellow bells; needs alkaline, sharply drained soil
Fox's Grape Fritillary	<i>F. uva-vulpis</i>	15–30cm	April	10cm deep	Small plum-brown bells with a grey bloom; needs a dry winter position
<i>F. michailovskyi</i>	<i>F. michailovskyi</i>	10–20cm	April–May	8–10cm deep	Small maroon bells tipped bright yellow; the most demanding of the group for drainage
Persian Fritillary	<i>F. persica</i>	60cm+	May	15–20cm deep, on its side	Tall spike of small plum-purple bells; needs alkaline, sharply drained soil like Crown Imperial

Light: ☀ Full sun for all — *F. meleagris* also tolerates partial shade.

Soil needs: pH 6.0–8.0 depending on species. *F. meleagris*: moist but reasonably drained, tolerates damp clay. All others (*imperialis*, *uva-vulpis*, *michailovskyi*, *persica*): free-draining soil essential, and *imperialis/persica* need it neutral to alkaline; none tolerate waterlogging.

Soil prep: *F. meleagris*: improve clay with compost; heavy grit is less critical given its preference for damper ground. The rest: improve clay generously with 25–40% horticultural grit (30% for *imperialis* and *persica*, worked in over a 35–40cm depth with grit at the base of the hole); a raised bed, trough or pot gives the most reliable results for *uva-vulpis* and *michailovskyi* on heavy west of Ireland clay.

Planting depth: Plant all in autumn. *F. meleagris*: 10cm deep. *F. uva-vulpis*: 10cm deep. *F. michailovskyi*: 8–10cm deep. *F. imperialis*: 20–30cm deep, on its side. *F. persica*: 15–20cm deep, on its side. All pointed end up except where planted on their side to stop water pooling in the hollow crown top. Fully hardy — none need lifting in the west of Ireland climate, though small bulbs of *meleagris*, *uva-vulpis* and *michailovskyi* dry out quickly out of the ground, so plant promptly after purchase, and *imperialis/persica* resent disturbance once settled.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs for the smaller species; 20–25cm for Persian Fritillary; 25cm for Crown Imperial.

Fertiliser: Light bonemeal at planting for all. Crown Imperial and Persian Fritillary are hungrier: balanced bulb fertiliser as shoots emerge, plus a high-potash liquid feed once or twice before flowering. The rest need very little beyond the initial bonemeal.

Companions: *F. meleagris*: snowdrops, daffodils, damp border or pond-margin planting. *F. uva-vulpis*, *F. michailovskyi*: other species fritillaries, dwarf iris, crocus in a sharply drained rockery. *F. imperialis*, *F. persica*: tulips, alliums, euphorbia, wallflowers.

West of Ireland: *F. meleagris* is one of the easiest bulbs to naturalise here, thriving in the moist climate. The rest are trickier: *F. imperialis* and *F. persica* are ⚠ challenging on wet clay and are most reliable in a raised bed or large gritty container, while *F. uva-vulpis* and *F. michailovskyi* need a raised bed, trough or pot rather than open clay ground to survive winter wet.

B12. Iron Cross (*Oxalis tetraphylla* 'Iron Cross')

Russian: Кислица

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: 5cm deep, growing point up, in spring (April–May) once frost risk has passed.

Spacing: 10–15cm between tubers; lift over winter

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season.

Companions: Front-of-border and container planting with other low, colourful summer bulbs such as ixia or dwarf dahlias.

West of Ireland: Grown for its distinctive four-lobed leaves marked with a dark maroon "iron cross" pattern and pink summer flowers. Tuber is not reliably frost-hardy — lift and store dry over winter like a dahlia, or grow in containers that can be moved under cover.

B13. Lilies (*Lilium* spp.)

Russian: Лилия

Light: ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. Most prefer heads in sun, roots shaded by low plants.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Drainage essential.

Soil prep: Compost and 20–25% grit. Place 5cm grit at base of each hole.

Planting depth: 15cm (3× bulb height) on a bed of grit, in autumn (September–October) or early spring. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

Spacing: 15–30cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser as shoots emerge. Tomato feed fortnightly from bud formation until flowering. Continue feeding until foliage yellows. Do not remove foliage until it dies back naturally.

Companions: Hostas, geraniums, low salvias (shade the soil around bulbs). Roses (lilies fill the midsummer gap). Alliums in the same border.

B14. Martagon Lily (*Lilium martagon*)

Russian: Лилия кудреватая

Light: 🌤️ Partial shade to sun; happier in dappled woodland-edge light than full baking sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained, humus-rich soil, tolerant of neutral to slightly alkaline conditions; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Compost and 20% grit at planting; unlike many lilies it tolerates heavier soil reasonably well once drainage is adequate.

Planting depth: 15cm deep (3× bulb height), on a bed of grit, in autumn (September–October) or early spring. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

Spacing: 20–30cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser as shoots emerge; otherwise undemanding once established. Do not remove foliage until it dies back naturally.

Companions: Naturalises well among shrubs, in light woodland or a shady border with hostas, ferns and hellebores — unlike many lilies, martagon lily is happy in part shade.

West of Ireland: More shade-tolerant and better suited to naturalising under trees/shrubs than most garden lilies, with distinctive nodding, "turk's cap" recurved flowers in early-mid summer. Slow to establish — settle for two to three years before flowering well, but long-lived once happy.

B15. Native Bluebells (*Hyacinthoides non-scripta*)

Irish / Russian: Coinnle corra · Гиацинтоидес неописанный

Light: 🌤️ Partial shade preferred; ideal under deciduous trees where it flowers before the canopy closes. Tolerates full sun to full shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; slightly acid, pH 6.0–6.8. Tolerates clay reasonably well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leaf mould or compost; heavy grit amendment is not essential.

Planting depth: 8cm deep, pointed end up, in autumn.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Little required. Bonemeal at planting is sufficient; leave foliage to die back naturally each year to feed the bulb.

Companions: Ferns, hostas, primroses, wood anemones — classic native woodland-floor planting under deciduous trees and shrubs such as hawthorn, rowan or Japanese maple.

West of Ireland: Ireland's native bluebell, distinguished from the non-native Spanish bluebell by its narrower, more strongly recurved deep violet-blue flowers borne on one side of a nodding stem, its sweet scent, and creamy-white (not blue) pollen. Naturalises readily in a woodland-style planting and is excellent for pollinators. Spreads by both offsets and self-seeding, forming drifts over time, but is less aggressive and better behaved in a garden setting than Spanish bluebell.

⚠️ Harmful if eaten; wear gloves when handling bulbs, as the sap can irritate skin.

B16. Ornamental Onion (*Allium* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Flower colour	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Giant Onion	<i>A. giganteum</i>	Purple	1.2–1.5m	Late spring–early summer	20cm deep	Huge globes to 15cm across; RHS AGM; the classic tall border allium
Golden Garlic	<i>A. moly</i>	Bright yellow	25–30cm	Late spring	8–10cm deep	Star-shaped flowers in loose clusters; spreads readily, almost naturalising
Ostrowsky's Onion	<i>A. oreophilum</i>	Rose-pink	15–20cm	Late spring	8–10cm deep	Loose clusters on short stems; good rockery/front-of-border allium
Naples Garlic	<i>A. cowanii</i> (syn. <i>A. neapolitanum</i>)	White	20–30cm	Early–mid spring	8–10cm deep	Fragrant star flowers; flowers earlier than the rest; slightly less reliably hardy — see note below
<i>Allium</i> 'Nigrum'	<i>A. multibulbosum</i> 'Nigrum' (= <i>A. nigrum</i>)	White, dark centre	60–90cm	Late spring–early summer	15cm deep	Unusual open, spike-like flower head rather than a tight ball
Purple-flowered Onion	<i>A. atropurpureum</i>	Deep maroon–purple	80cm–1m	Late spring–early summer	20cm deep	Smaller, darker blooms than Giant Onion; a strong eye-catcher

Light: ☀ Full sun for all.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil; pH any, but bulbs rot in waterlogged clay, so drainage is essential. All tolerate loam, sand, clay and stony ground provided it drains.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 25–30% horticultural grit before planting; raised beds or mounded planting help on heavy soil.

Planting depth: Plant all in autumn (mid to late autumn is ideal). Roughly 2–3× the bulb's own depth, pointed end up (about 20cm for Giant Onion's large bulbs, 8–10cm for the smaller species). Space bulbs about twice the bulb's diameter apart. All are fully hardy and, once planted, are left in the ground permanently — none need lifting in the west of Ireland climate. *A. cowanii* is the one partial exception: as a Mediterranean species it is slightly less robustly hardy than the others, so in colder inland gardens (rather than the milder coastal west) it benefits from a sheltered spot or a winter mulch, though it is not usually necessary to lift it.

Spacing: 10–20cm between bulbs for the smaller species; 25–30cm for Giant Onion and *A. 'Nigrum'*/*atropurpureum*.

Fertiliser: Bonemeal or bulb fertiliser at planting. Balanced liquid feed as foliage emerges in spring, stopped once flowering finishes.

Companions: Roses (alliums are classic rose-border companions and can help deter some pests), peonies, irises, ornamental grasses. The smaller species (moly, oreophilum, cowanii) suit rockeries and gravel gardens; the taller ones (giganteum, 'Nigrum', atropurpureum) suit borders and cut-flower beds.

West of Ireland: All flower in late spring—for *A. cowanii* it's notably earlier, into March–April. Excellent in pots for good drainage on wet clay sites; leave foliage to die back naturally to feed next year's bulb.

B33. Pineapple Lily (*Eucomis* spp.)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential.

Soil needs: Fertile, moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging, especially in winter while dormant.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit for drainage; a raised bed or large container gives the most reliable results.

Planting depth: Plant the bulb with its neck/tip at or just below the soil surface, roughly 10–15cm deep, in spring once frost risk has passed.

Spacing: 25–30cm between bulbs.

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed fortnightly through the growing season; high-potash feed as flower spikes develop.

Companions: Alliums, crocosmia, dahlias — bold, late-summer border companions with similar sun and drainage needs.

Pot/container: ☒ Grows very well in a large container, which makes lifting for winter storage in colder areas straightforward.

West of Ireland: A dramatic, exotic-looking bulb from South Africa with rosettes of strap-shaped leaves and tall, densely packed flower spikes topped with a tuft of leafy bracts (resembling a pineapple, hence the name), in white, green, pink or maroon depending on species/cultivar, from mid-to-late summer. Borderline hardy (RHS H3–H4 depending on species) — in most of the west of Ireland, mulch the dormant bulb thickly over winter if left in the ground, or lift and store dry and frost-free, similar to a dahlia tuber; a large container that can be moved to a sheltered spot for winter is the most reliable approach on wet clay.

B18. Ranunculus (*Ranunculus asiaticus*)

Russian: Лютик азиатский

Light: ☀️ Full sun to partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. Tubers rot in wet clay.

Soil prep: Compost and 20–30% grit. Plant on a bed of grit.

Planting depth: 5–8cm deep, claws pointing downward. Soak tubers 2–4 hours before planting. Plant in spring (February–April). Not reliably hardy — lift after flowering, dry, and store frost-free over winter, or treat as a seasonal pot plant.

Spacing: 15–20cm between tubers

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid fertiliser every 2 weeks once shoots appear. Liquid tomato feed from bud formation until flowering. Container: monthly balanced liquid feed.

Companions: Pansies and violas in cool-season containers. Muscari, fritillaria, spring anemones flower simultaneously.

West of Ireland: ⚠️ Treat as seasonal pot plant — lift after flowering, dry, and store frost-free.

B19. Snowdrops (*Galanthus nivalis*)

Irish / Russian: Plúirín sneachta · Подснежник белоснежный

Light: 🌤️ to 🌑 Partial to full shade. Under deciduous trees is ideal — winter/spring light before canopy forms.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs

Soil needs: Humus-rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained, pH 5.5–7.0. Best planted "in the green."

Planting depth (dry bulbs): 10cm deep, 8–10cm apart, in autumn (September–October). **Planting depth (in the green):** At same depth as growing; plant in spring, just after flowering, while leaves are still on. Fully hardy either way — never needs lifting.

Fertiliser: Light balanced fertiliser in early spring while foliage is still green. Annual leaf mould or compost mulch. Allow foliage to die back completely before removing.

Companions: Hellebores (classic January–March winter combination). Aconites, early narcissus, cyclamen coum in February–March. Underplant shrubs (forsythia, lilac) with snowdrops for colour before the shrubs flower.

B20. Snowflake (*Leucojum aestivum* — Summer Snowflake; *L. vernum* — Spring Snowflake)

Irish / Russian: Plúirín samhraidh · Белоцветник летний

Note on naming: Despite its common name, the Summer Snowflake, *Leucojum aestivum*, flowers in mid-spring and goes dormant during summer, not in summer itself. It features nodding, bell-shaped white flowers with green-tipped tepals, and is softly chocolate-scented.

Light: ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. They prefer soil that stays cool and damp, making them ideal for borders, woodland edges, or near water.

Soil needs: Organically rich, medium moisture, well-drained soils in full sun to part shade. Adapts to clay soils. Plants need consistent moisture during the spring period of growth and bloom. pH 5.5–7.0. They are notably tolerant of wet and clay soils.

Soil prep: Add generous compost. Plants will naturalize well by bulb offsets. Bulbs are best left undisturbed once set in the ground. Mulch to retain summer moisture.

Planting depth: Plant dry bulbs 8–10cm deep in autumn in moist, humus-rich soil. Plant bulbs in autumn about 10cm deep and 8–10cm apart. Water well after planting and keep the soil evenly moist, especially during dry spells in spring. Allow the foliage to die back completely after flowering to feed the bulbs for next year's growth.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Light balanced bulb fertiliser in spring while foliage is green, or annual compost top-dressing around the planting area. Low-maintenance once established.

Companions: Mixes beautifully with other spring flowering bulbs. Tolerates boggy spots and will do well on the edges of natural ponds. Spectacular in large sweeping drifts. Excellent with daffodils, snowdrops, hellebores, and moisture-loving plants. Plant at pond edges where it will naturalise freely.

Pot size: 30–40cm diameter, 25cm+ deep; multipurpose compost.

West of Ireland: This attractive bulb is ideal for naturalising in areas of grass or planting in generous clumps throughout the front of borders and rockeries. The moist Irish conditions and winter-spring wet suit it perfectly. An excellent naturalistic bulb for damp areas that can be challenging for other bulbs.

B21. Spring Sowbread (*Cyclamen coum*)

Russian: Цикламен косский (дряква косская)

Light: ☀️ Partial to full shade; ideal under deciduous trees and shrubs.

Soil needs: Well-drained, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging around the tuber.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leaf mould/compost and grit.

Planting depth: Tuber just below the soil surface (2–3cm), flattest side down, planted in late summer to early autumn (August–September) while dormant. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

Spacing: 10–15cm between tubers

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed as leaves emerge in autumn/winter. Top-dress with leaf mould annually.

Companions: Snowdrops, winter aconite, hellebores — classic winter/early-spring woodland-floor planting.

West of Ireland: Flowers from midwinter into early spring, often alongside snowdrops, with attractively marbled leaves persisting after flowering. Once settled it self-seeds gently to form a carpet under trees and shrubs — avoid disturbing the tubers once established.

B22. Tulip (*Tulipa* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Tulip (garden hybrids)	<i>Tulipa</i> spp.	30–60cm	April–May	20cm deep (3× bulb height)	The familiar large-flowered garden tulip; rots readily in wet clay
Turkestan Tulip	<i>T. turkestanica</i>	10–15cm	February–March	10cm deep	Up to a dozen small white, yellow-centred star flowers per bulb; one of the earliest tulips
Whittall's Tulip	<i>T. orphanidea</i>	15–20cm	Mid-spring	10–15cm deep	Copper-orange star flowers, one to four per stem; reliably perennial
Wild Tulip	<i>T. sylvestris</i>	20–30cm	Mid-spring	10–15cm deep	Fragrant, nodding, buttercup-yellow; more shade- and damp-tolerant than the rest, spreads by stolons

Light: ☀️ Full sun essential for all — except Wild Tulip, which tolerates partial shade as a woodland-edge species.

Soil needs: pH 6.0–7.5. Well-drained soil essential for garden hybrids, Turkestan Tulip and Whittall's Tulip, all of which rot in wet winter clay. Wild Tulip is the exception, tolerating damper, more clay-rich conditions than the others.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and 20–30% horticultural grit for garden hybrids, Turkestan Tulip and Whittall's Tulip; raised beds or pots give the most reliable results on heavy west of Ireland ground. For Wild Tulip, heavy grit amendment is less critical.

Planting depth: Plant all in autumn (November is ideal for garden hybrids, to reduce tulip fire disease risk; the species tulips can go in a little earlier). Garden hybrids: 20cm deep (3× bulb height). Turkestan Tulip: 10cm deep. Whittall's Tulip: 10–15cm deep. Wild Tulip: 10–15cm deep. All pointed end up. The three species tulips are fully hardy and never need lifting. Garden hybrid tulips are also hardy, but in Ireland's cool, wet climate many gardeners lift the bulbs after the foliage dies back in early summer, dry them off and replant in autumn, as this improves the reliability of repeat flowering more than leaving them in permanently damp ground; treating hybrids as annuals and replanting fresh bulbs each year is also common practice here.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs for the three species tulips; 10–15cm for garden hybrids.

Fertiliser: Light bonemeal at planting for the species tulips; otherwise little required. Garden hybrids benefit from a high-potash bulb fertiliser in early spring as shoots emerge, and a balanced feed after flowering while the foliage is still green if being kept for a second year.

Companions: Garden hybrids: forget-me-nots, wallflowers, daffodils, alliums, stocks. Turkestan Tulip: crocus, dwarf iris and other very early bulbs. Whittall's Tulip: crocus, grape hyacinth and other species tulips. Wild Tulip: naturalises well in grass or light woodland with daffodils.

West of Ireland: The three species tulips (Turkestan, Whittall's and Wild) naturalise far more reliably here than showier garden hybrids, which are best treated as a shorter-lived display unless lifted and dried each summer.

B26. Yellow Star-of-Bethlehem (*Gagea lutea*)

Russian: Гусиный лук жёлтый

Light: ☀️ Partial shade to sun; naturally a woodland-floor plant, flowering before the canopy closes.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, base-rich (near-neutral to slightly alkaline) soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Never allow it to dry out during the growing season.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost/leaf mould; avoid heavy grit amendment, since this species prefers more moisture-retentive ground than most bulbs.

Planting depth: 5–8cm deep, pointed end up, in autumn. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

Spacing: 5–8cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Light bonemeal at planting. Otherwise little required; allow foliage to die back naturally.

Companions: Snowdrops, wood anemones and other early woodland-floor bulbs.

West of Ireland: A delicate, early-flowering native British woodland bulb; note that it is genuinely rare across Britain and Ireland and its status as a wild Irish native is uncertain — most sources describe it as a rare/scattered Great Britain species rather than confirmed native to Ireland, so plants sold for gardens are nursery-propagated stock rather than "native Irish" in origin. Grow in a shaded, undisturbed woodland-style corner.

GROUP C: CLIMBERS & WALL PLANTS

C1. Blue Passion Flower (*Passiflora caerulea*)

Irish / Russian: Lus na páise · Страстоцвет голубой

Light: ☀️ Full sun, sheltered from cold wind — a south- or west-facing wall is ideal.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Good drainage is essential — this is the hardiest passion flower but still dislikes waterlogged roots in winter.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width against the wall base. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark, 30–45cm from the wall, angled towards support.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants against wall/fence

Fertiliser: Balanced general or high-potash liquid feed monthly through the growing season. Avoid excess nitrogen, which favours leaf growth over flowers.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis and honeysuckle on the same wall/structure for a long season of colour.

West of Ireland: RHS hardiness H4 (hardy to about –5 to –10°C) — reliably hardy in most west of Ireland gardens with wall shelter, though may be cut back by hard frost and regrow from the base. Needs a sturdy support (trellis or wires) to climb by tendrils.

C2. Clematis (*Clematis* spp.)

Irish / Russian: Gabhrán · Клематис

Light: ☀️ Roots prefer shade (cover with stone or tile), stems flower best in sun or dappled light. Evergreen types prefer sheltered, sunny, south-facing wall.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile, neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost plus 20% grit. Shade the root zone.

Planting depth: Groups 2 & 3 large-flowered: 10–15cm DEEPER than pot; *C. montana* (Group 1): 8–10cm; Evergreen types: at pot level only.

Spacing: 60–90cm between; cool roots essential

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring. From April: high-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) fortnightly until August. Feed regularly — clematis are hungry. Do not feed after August.

Companions: Climbing roses on the same wall (classic combination). Clematis through other shrubs. Late-flowering Group 3 through roses for second flush of colour.

Species for the west of Ireland: All of the following are hardy and well suited to the Atlantic climate; pruning group is noted for each.

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
<i>C. montana</i>	<i>C. montana</i>	8–10m	Late spring	8–10cm deep (Group 1)	The most vigorous of the six, covering itself in single, four-petalled white or pink flowers; best given a large wall, tree or shed to scramble over
<i>C. alpina</i>	<i>C. alpina</i>	2–3m	April	8–10cm deep (Group 1)	Compact, with nodding, lantern-shaped single flowers (four narrow sepals) in blue, purple, pink or white; good for a windy or north-facing spot
<i>C. macropetala</i>	<i>C. macropetala</i>	2–3m	Mid-late spring	8–10cm deep (Group 1)	Very similar to <i>C. alpina</i> in size and season, but the flowers look "double": extra narrow petal-like staminodes fill the centre
<i>C. viticella</i>	<i>C. viticella</i>	3–4m	Midsummer–autumn	10–15cm deeper than pot (Group 3)	Small, nodding, open bell-shaped flowers in purple, red or pink; naturally resistant to clematis wilt, a reliable choice on damp Irish sites
<i>C. tangutica</i>	<i>C. tangutica</i>	3.5–4.5m	Late summer–early autumn	10–15cm deeper than pot (Group 3)	Bright yellow, nodding lantern-shaped flowers followed by large, silvery, fluffy seedheads that persist into winter
<i>C. terniflora</i>	<i>C. terniflora</i>	3–6m	Late summer–autumn	10–15cm deeper than pot (Group 3)	The latest to flower, with small, star-shaped, fragrant white flowers in large sprays; extremely vigorous, so give it plenty of room
<i>C. 'Winter Beauty'</i>	<i>C. urophylla</i> 'Winter Beauty'	About 3m	Early–late winter	At pot level (evergreen type)	Evergreen; nodding, urn-shaped, creamy-white flowers to 4cm across from pale green buds, produced right through winter; ⚠️ sap is a skin irritant

C3. Climbing Honeysuckle (*Lonicera periclymenum*)

Irish / Russian: Féithleann · Жимолость вьющаяся

Light: ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. Woodland-edge habit: roots shaded, stems growing into light.

Soil needs: Most soils; prefers moist, humus-rich.

Soil prep: Hole the same size as rootball. Mix in compost. Firm in and mulch.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in spring (Growmore) or manure mulch. Liquid tomato feed fortnightly in summer encourages flowering. Avoid excessive nitrogen.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis (classic combination). Plant near windows or doorways for evening fragrance. Native woodbine is a superb wildlife plant.

C4. Climbing Hydrangea (*Hydrangea anomala* subsp. *petiolaris*)

Russian: Гортензия черешковая

Light: 🌑 to ☀️ North or east-facing walls are ideal — will grow and flower in shade that defeats most climbers. Full sun tolerated if soil stays consistently moist. Self-clinging via aerial roots; slow to start but ultimately vigorous (can reach 10–15m). RHS hardiness rating: H5 (to -15°C).

Soil needs: Fertile, moist but well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Tolerates clay, loamy and sandy soils. Dislikes waterlogged or excessively dry conditions.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice as wide and the same depth as the rootball. Mix in compost. If against a wall or fence, allow a 45cm gap between plant and wall (rain shadow). Mulch well. Space 60cm+ between plants.

Planting depth: At pot level. Can tolerate slightly deeper planting as it forms shoot-like roots on buried stem.

Spacing: 45cm from wall; 60cm+ between plants

Fertiliser: Needs little feeding for the first three years — do not feed during establishment. After year three: balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring if leaves appear yellow; otherwise a single spring application of balanced granular feed is sufficient. Annual mulch with compost in late summer. Low-maintenance overall.

Companions: Grows beautifully with ivy on north-facing walls for year-round coverage. Ferns at its base (same moisture preference). Shade-tolerant hostas and hellebores beneath. Invaluable for dark walls where most climbers fail.

West of Ireland: Exceptional plant for the Irish climate. One of the very few climbers that genuinely thrives on cold, north-facing or shaded walls. The moist Atlantic climate suits it perfectly. Slow in the first 2–3 years but can ultimately cover an entire house wall.

C5. Climbing Roses (*Rosa*, climbing cultivars)

Russian: Плетистая роза

Light: ☀ Full sun preferred — at least 6 hours.

Soil needs: Fertile, well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Never plant where a rose previously grew.

Soil prep: Double-dig (50–60cm deep). Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. Position at least 45cm from wall.

Planting depth: Graft union just below soil level.

Spacing: 45cm from wall; 2–3m between plants

Fertiliser: Specialist rose fertiliser in late March and again in early June. Liquid high-potash feed fortnightly May–August. Stop feeding by late August. Annual bark or manure mulch.

Companions: Clematis (trained together on the same wall). Lavender at base. Alliums, salvia, hardy geraniums as foreground.

C16. Common Jasmine (*Jasminum officinale*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade, ideally against a warm, sheltered wall.

Soil needs: Fertile, moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit; provide a sturdy trellis or wires for its twining stems.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark, 30–45cm out from the wall or fence base.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants against a wall or pergola.

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in spring; high-potash liquid feed through summer to encourage flowering.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis and honeysuckle on the same wall or pergola for a long season of scent and colour.

Pruning: Prune immediately after flowering, thinning out crowded and dead growth; flowers on the current year's growth, so avoid hard pruning in late winter/spring, which removes the coming season's flowers.

West of Ireland: A vigorous, twining deciduous-to-semi-evergreen climber grown above all for its powerfully fragrant white summer flowers, beloved for training over an archway, pergola or seating area where its scent can be appreciated. Fully hardy in the mild, moist west of Ireland climate, though a sheltered spot gives the healthiest growth and the best flowering.

C6. Hardy Grapes (*Vitis vinifera*)

Irish / Russian: Fionchaora · Виноград культурный

Light: ☀ Full sun — south-facing wall essential. Without maximum sun, fruit will not ripen.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.0–6.5. Neutral to slightly alkaline preferred; mulch to keep soil moist.

Soil prep: Clay/compost/grit plus coarse gravel at base. At least 20cm from wall.

Planting depth: At pot depth; graft above soil.

Spacing: 1.2–1.5m between vines; 20cm from wall

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser with potassium in early spring. High-potash liquid feed fortnightly through summer. Do not overfeed with nitrogen. Grapevines on somewhat lean soil often fruit better.

Companions: Lavender, rosemary, garlic, hyssop at base. Good air circulation is critical in Irish conditions to reduce fungal disease risk.

Your varieties:

'Phoenix' — A mid-season white dessert and wine grape with large bunches of pale green fruits. Bred in Germany; its most important attribute for west of Ireland growing is its excellent built-in resistance to both powdery mildew and downy mildew, making it one of the most reliable outdoor grapes in the UK and Ireland. Hardy and very productive. Harvest: mid-September. One of the very best choices for Irish conditions (source: RHS outdoor cultivation guide; Pomona Fruits; Roots Plants).

'Regent' — A vigorous, disease-resistant red/blue-black dual-purpose grape for wine-making, juice or dessert eating. Originally bred in Germany (Chambourcin × Müller-Thurgau parentage). Bunches of large, dark red grapes mature to blue-black in early autumn; foliage turns red and purple in autumn. Excellent resistance to fungal diseases including downy mildew; slightly less resistant to mildew in unusually humid seasons. Hardy to northern European conditions. Harvest: September–October depending on season. RHS recommends growing in full sun in well-drained, humus-rich, neutral to slightly alkaline soil (RHS plant profile, *Vitis* 'Regent').

'Boskoop Glory' (also sold as 'Gloire of Boskoop') — A very popular and reliable outdoor dessert and wine grape developed in the Netherlands in the 1950s; a hybrid between *V. vinifera* and *V. labrusca*. Vigorous, disease-resistant and very cold-tolerant — one of the hardiest outdoor grape varieties available, RHS Award of Garden Merit holder. Large bunches of sweet, blue-black, seedless grapes ripen in early autumn (typically late August–September). Suitable for outdoor cultivation almost anywhere in the UK and Ireland. Leaves turn shades of red and purple in autumn. Can grow to an impressive 10m high and 4m wide. ⚠ Harmful to dogs if eaten. (Source: RHS plant profile *Vitis* 'Boskoop Glory'; Wikipedia; Roots Plants; Marshalls Garden.)

C7. Hops (*Humulus lupulus*)

Irish / Russian: *Lus an leanna* · Хмель обыкновенный

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Full sun produces more vigorous growth and larger cones.

Soil needs: Rich, moist, well-drained, pH 6.0–8.0. Tolerates clay well.

Soil prep: Dig and enrich generously with compost. Heavy feeders.

Planting depth: Rhizome 5–8cm deep; pot-grown plants at pot level.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: High-nitrogen fertiliser in spring, then balanced fertiliser with potassium once flowering begins. Thick compost or manure mulch each spring. Container: balanced liquid feed monthly throughout the growing season.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis, ornamental grasses. Golden hop ('Aureus') looks spectacular against dark-foliaged plants (yew, holly).

C8. Ivy (*Hedera helix* / *H. hibernica* — native Irish ivy)

Irish / Russian: *Eidhneán* · Плющ обыкновенный

Light: 🌑 Full shade to ☀ full sun. One of the most light-tolerant plants. In deep shade variegated forms lose markings; green forms thrive.

Soil needs: Almost any soil including heavy clay, pH 5.0–8.0.

Soil prep: Minimal — basic compost addition to planting hole.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–50cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required. Balanced slow-release in spring if plant appears weak. Annual bark mulch. Container: balanced liquid fertiliser monthly during the growing season.

Companions: Native *H. hibernica* is one of Ireland's most important wildlife plants — nesting habitat, late nectar, winter berries. Grows beautifully under trees alongside ferns, snowdrops, and bluebells. With Virginia creeper on walls for year-round interest.

C9. Kiwi (*Actinidia deliciosa* 'Jenny')

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Best fruiting in full sun; a south- or west-facing wall gives the most reliable cropping in Ireland.

Soil needs: Fertile, moist but well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Sandy loam is ideal; dislikes waterlogging, so on clay, drainage improvement is essential.

Soil prep: Dig a generous hole at least 60cm wide and 45cm deep, 45cm out from the wall or fence. Mix the excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost and 20–25% horticultural grit to guarantee free drainage at the root zone. Install a strong permanent support (trellis, wires or pergola) at planting time — the vine is vigorous and support is far harder to add later. Mulch generously with bark after planting to retain moisture and suppress weeds.

Planting depth: At pot level; do not bury the crown. Plant in spring once frost risk has passed (April–May).

Spacing: 3–5m between plants, trained against a wall or over a sturdy pergola.

Fertiliser: Balanced granular fertiliser (e.g. Growmore) in early spring as buds swell, then a high-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) fortnightly from May to August. Do not feed after August. Mulch annually with well-rotted compost each spring.

Companions: Climbing roses, wisteria or clematis on adjacent structures. Lavender and rosemary at the base suit its preference for a warm, sheltered spot; garlic or chives nearby help deter aphids.

Pruning: Prune in late winter to establish a framework, then again in summer to control vigorous growth. Fruit forms on the current season's lateral shoots — shorten these to 4–6 leaves beyond the last fruit cluster each summer.

Hardiness & pot growing: Hardy to about -10°C to -15°C once established; young plants need frost protection over their first winter. ⚠️ Can be grown in a large container (60–80L minimum) but fruits far less freely than in the ground.

West of Ireland: 'Jenny' is self-fertile, removing the need for a second pollinator plant, which makes it the practical choice for most gardens here. Kiwi is at the northern edge of its reliable fruiting range in Ireland, so a sheltered, sun-warmed wall is essential and a modest crop is realistic rather than a heavy one.

C17. Necklace Vine (Maidenhair Vine) (*Muehlenbeckia complexa*)

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils, including poor or dry ground; pH 5.5–7.5. Very adaptable.

Soil prep: Minimal — tolerant of poor soil; improve heavy waterlogged clay with grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants against a support, or as ground-covering mounds if left unsupported.

Fertiliser: Little needed once established.

Companions: Works well trained over a wire frame or topiary form, or left to scramble as groundcover among rocks; combines with ornamental grasses and other textural foliage plants.

Warnings ⚠️: Can self-seed and spread vigorously in mild, sheltered gardens — monitor and control if this is unwanted, particularly near hedgerows or wild areas.

West of Ireland: A wiry-stemmed, small-leaved evergreen (semi-evergreen in colder spots) climber or scrambling groundcover from New Zealand, useful for softening fences, trained over topiary frames, or as dense low cover on a bank. Tolerates coastal exposure and salt-laden wind well, making it a useful, tough choice for an exposed west of Ireland garden, though its spreading habit needs occasional control.

C13. Schisandra (*Schisandra* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Five-Flavour Berry (Magnolia Vine)	<i>S. chinensis</i>	6–9m	Late spring (April–May)	At nursery soil mark	Fragrant cream to pale-pink flowers; hanging clusters of red "five-flavour" berries on female plants; RHS-confirmed hardy
Red-Flowered Magnolia Vine	<i>S. rubriflora</i>	6–9m	Late spring–early summer	At nursery soil mark	Deep crimson, waxy, cup-shaped flowers — showier than <i>S. chinensis</i> ; pea-sized red berries on dangling spikes; hardy to about -15°C

Light: 🌤️ Partial or dappled shade is preferred by both, though *S. chinensis* also tolerates full sun provided the soil stays consistently moist. *S. rubriflora* is the more shade-loving of the two and does well against a shady wall or trained up through a tree.

Soil needs: Fertile, humus-rich, moist but well-drained soil for both; pH 6.0–7.5, tolerant of light, medium and heavy soils including clay.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with well-rotted compost; mulch well after planting to help retain the consistent moisture both species need — they resent drying out.

Planting depth: At the same depth as in the nursery pot for both. Plant climbers 30–60cm out from a wall or fence base to avoid the driest soil directly beneath, angling the young plant towards its support.

Spacing: Allow at least 2–3m for a mature plant of either species against a wall, trellis or through a large shrub or tree.

Fertiliser: Feed lightly in spring with a balanced fertiliser to support healthy growth and flowering; an annual mulch of garden compost is otherwise sufficient.

Companions: Both are well suited to growing through a large, sturdy shrub or small tree, or trained on a shady wall alongside climbing hydrangea or ivy.

Pruning: Tie in young shoots to their support until established. Both flower and fruit on the current season's growth, so prune lightly immediately after flowering to control shape; avoid hard pruning, and remove only damaged, weak or overcrowded stems.

Warnings ⚠️: Both species are dioecious (separate male and female plants) — for berries, plant at least one of each sex reasonably close together, since a single plant grown alone will flower but will not fruit.

West of Ireland: Both are genuinely hardy woody twining climbers native to the forests of China and neighbouring parts of Asia, well suited to a sheltered spot in an Irish garden. *S. chinensis* ("wu wei zi", the five-flavour berry, so called because its fruit combines sweet, sour, salty, bitter and pungent tastes) is the more commonly available and more sun-tolerant of the two, while *S. rubriflora* has showier, richer crimson flowers and prefers more shade — ideal for a north- or east-facing wall or growing up through an established tree where little else will flower well. Both give attractive yellow autumn colour before leaf fall.

C10. Tufted Vetch (*Vicia cracca*)

Irish / Russian: *Peasair na luch* · Горошек мышиный

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

Soil needs: Most soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant and unfussy, as a nitrogen-fixing legume.

Soil prep: Minimal — very adaptable. Improve heaviest clay with compost if desired.

Planting depth: At pot level, or sow seed directly 1–2cm deep in spring.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; scrambles via tendrils

Fertiliser: None required — like other vetches, it fixes its own nitrogen. Avoid rich feeding, which encourages excess soft growth.

Companions: Grasses, other wildflower meadow and hedgerow species; scrambles happily through shrubs or a wildlife-friendly fence/trellis via tendrils.

West of Ireland: A native climbing/scrambling wildflower with clusters of blue-purple pea flowers, valuable for bees and other pollinators. Best suited to a wildflower area, informal hedge or meadow planting rather than a formal border, as it can spread and scramble vigorously.

C11. Virginia Creeper (*Parthenocissus quinquefolia*)

Russian: Виноград девичий пятилисточковый

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade. Autumn colour more vivid in sunnier positions.

Soil needs: Wide range including clay, pH 5.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig twice the rootball, backfill with clay/compost mix.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1.5–3m between plants

Fertiliser: Low-maintenance. Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual bark mulch. In poor soils, slow-release granular fertiliser provides sufficient nutrition for the season.

Companions: Ivy on same wall for year-round coverage. Late-flowering clematis. Good companion for climbing roses (extends season of interest).

C12. Wisteria (*Wisteria sinensis* / *W. floribunda*)

Russian: Глициния китайская

Light: ☀️ Full sun — south- or west-facing wall essential. Flowers very poorly in shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: 60cm wide, 40cm deep, at least 45cm from wall base. Clay/compost/grit blend over a wide area.

Planting depth: At pot level; graft union above soil. Buy grafted plants — seed-grown can take 15–20 years to flower.

Spacing: 45cm from wall; 3m between plants

Fertiliser: High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) from spring through early summer — avoid nitrogen (produces leaves, not flowers). Light dressing of bonemeal in spring. Do not feed after midsummer.

Companions: Climbing roses on adjacent wall, alliums and irises at its feet, spring bulbs at the base. Do not plant near drains or gutters.

GROUP F: FRUIT TREES & SHRUBS

F22. Almond (*Prunus dulcis*)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential, in the warmest, most sheltered spot available.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging.

Soil prep: Dig a hole twice the rootball width. Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark; graft union above soil level.

Spacing: 4–6m between plants if free-standing; fan-trained against a wall needs 4–5m of wall space.

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser each February; potash-rich feed as nuts develop.

Companions: Chives and garlic nearby to deter aphids; spring bulbs beneath, timed with the very early blossom.

Pruning: Prune in summer only, to reduce the risk of silver leaf and bacterial canker common to *Prunus* species.

Warnings ⚠: Flowers extremely early (often February), so blossom is highly vulnerable to frost damage — this is the single biggest obstacle to a reliable nut crop in a cool climate.

West of Ireland: Grown more for its beautiful very early pink-white blossom than for a reliable nut harvest in this climate — most self-fertile ornamental almonds flower before pollinating insects are reliably active, and the region's damp, cool spring rarely gives the sustained summer warmth almonds need to ripen a worthwhile crop of nuts. Best treated as a beautiful, hardy flowering tree in a warm, sheltered, south-facing spot, with any nuts a welcome bonus rather than the main reason to grow it. Self-fertile cultivars remove the need for a pollination partner, but a sheltered site is essential regardless.

Fi. Apple (*Malus domestica*)

Popular garden varieties — UK/Ireland:

Variety	Season	Notes
'Baya Marisa'	September–October	Compact, disease-resistant modern variety bred specifically for pots and small gardens; usually sold on P22 rootstock
Cox's Orange Pippin	October	The classic English dessert apple; complex, aromatic flavour; needs a warm, sheltered site and a pollination partner
'Granny Smith'	Late season	Crisp, tart, green-skinned; needs a long, warm growing season to ripen fully, so cropping is less reliable in a cool Irish summer than the varieties above

Popular garden varieties — Russia:

Variety	Season	Notes
White Transparent (Белый налив, Bely/Beliy Naliv)	Mid-late summer	One of the most famous and widely grown Russian apples; very early ripening, extremely hardy, sharp/tart flavour best suited to cooking; also grown across Poland and the Baltic states
Antonovka (Антоновка)	Autumn/keeper	"The people's apple" — Russia's classic dacha-garden variety; strongly acidic, aromatic; exceptionally cold-hardy and long-storing; also widely used as a cold-hardy seedling rootstock
Grushovka Moskovskaya (Грушовка московская)	Mid-summer	An old, very early-ripening Russian variety, sweet-sour flavour, extremely frost-tolerant (to about -30°C); needs a pollination partner

Apple rootstocks:

Rootstock	Vigour	Approx. height	Notes
M27	Extremely dwarfing	1.2–1.8m	For a container or the very smallest garden; needs permanent staking and good soil
M9	Dwarfing	1.8–2.4m	The most popular rootstock for a garden bush tree; needs permanent staking
P22	Very dwarfing	1.2–1.8m	Polish rootstock (M.9 × Common Antonovka cross); good winter hardiness and good resistance to root rots, a real advantage on wet Irish clay; needs permanent staking for life
M26	Dwarfing	2.4–3m	A popular choice for a slightly larger bush; usually needs staking for its first years
MM106	Semi-vigorous	3–4m	A good general-purpose choice for a free-standing garden tree; does not usually need permanent staking once established
M25	Vigorous	Over 4.5m	For a full-sized standard tree; not suitable for a small garden

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily.

Soil needs: Well-drained, moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Break up clay beneath. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost over a broad area. Keep a 60cm weed-free circle around the base permanently.

Planting depth: Graft union (bulge near stem base) at or just above soil level. Plant to the nursery soil mark.

Spacing: Depends entirely on rootstock — see table above.

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed) each February. Liquid high-potash feed (tomato feed) fortnightly from late spring to midsummer. Do not feed after July. Bonemeal in the planting hole at planting.

Companions: Chives and garlic deter aphids (dwarfing rootstocks like P22 are particularly susceptible to woolly apple aphid). Nasturtiums attract beneficial insects. Most apples need a compatible pollination partner flowering at the same time — plant two or more varieties, or rely on neighbouring gardens/wild crab apple, for a reliable crop.

West of Ireland: Permanent staking is essential on any of the dwarfing rootstocks (M27, M9, P22, M26) given Atlantic winds. 'Baya Marisa' on P22 is a good, compact, disease-resistant choice for a small garden or large pot; Cox's Orange Pippin rewards a warm, sheltered spot with real flavour but is fussier about site than the others; the Russian varieties (White Transparent, Antonovka, Grushovka Moskovskaya) are all exceptionally cold-hardy and were bred for climates considerably harsher than Ireland's, so they generally thrive here with no special protection needed, though most need a pollination partner. 'Granny Smith' is the least reliable cropper of the group in a cool Irish summer, since it evolved for a warmer climate with a longer ripening season.

F2. Blackberries (*Rubus fruticosus* agg.)

Irish / Russian: Sméara dubha · Ежевика кустистая

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade for best fruiting.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.0. One of the most clay-tolerant fruiting plants.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants against wires

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser (Growmore) in spring. Annual mulch with compost.

Companions: Raspberries and other cane fruit with similar needs; avoid planting near wild bramble, which can cross-pollinate and revert vigour.

West of Ireland: Extremely easy and productive on Irish clay — thornless cultivars (e.g. 'Loch Ness', 'Oregon Thornless') are more manageable than wild bramble for a garden setting. Provide a sturdy wire support and tie in new canes each summer; cut back fruited canes after harvest.

F3. Blackcurrant (*Ribes nigrum*)

Irish / Russian: Cuiríní dubha · Смородина чёрная

Light: 🌞 Full sun to partial shade — tolerates shade better than other currants.

Soil prep: Double dig; compost generously; 15–20% grit on heavy clay.

Planting depth: 5–7cm deeper than nursery mark. Cut all stems to 10cm after planting.

Spacing: 1.2–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: High-nitrogen fertiliser in early spring. Again after harvest. Generous compost or manure mulch each winter. Potassium deficiency (brown leaf edges) common — use balanced feed with potassium.

Companions: Alliums, garlic, nasturtiums nearby; redcurrant, gooseberry in the same bed.

F4. Blueberry (*Vaccinium corymbosum*)

Russian: Голубика высокорослая

Popular garden varieties:

Variety	Season	Notes
'Bluecrop'	Mid-season	The world's most widely planted blueberry; large, sweet, powder-blue berries; very hardy; reliable all-rounder
'Duke'	Early	RHS-listed; flowers late (avoiding frost) but ripens early; firm, tangy-sweet berries
'Patriot'	Early	RHS AGM; large, sweet, firm berries; vigorous and hardy, with good tolerance of less-than-ideal soil
'Sunshine Blue'	Mid-season	Compact (to about 1m), semi-evergreen; the most reliably self-fertile variety if only growing one bush; ideal for a container

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. More berries in full sun.

Soil needs: Ericaceous, pH 4.0–5.5. Use ericaceous compost only. Rainwater preferred for watering.

Pot size: Start in 40cm diameter pot; scale up every 2–3 years. Final container: minimum 50 litres (~60cm diameter, 45–60cm deep). One blueberry per pot. Heather and lingonberry compatible at edges of a wide trough (same pH).

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1 plant per pot; 60cm between pots

Fertiliser: Use only ericaceous liquid fertiliser fortnightly April–August. Top-dress with fresh ericaceous compost in spring. Sulphur chips to maintain acidity over time.

Companions: Heather, lingonberry, cranberry, other *Vaccinium*. Dedicated ericaceous bed with rhododendrons and azaleas if naturally acidic area. Most varieties are only partially self-fertile — planting two different varieties nearby significantly improves berry size and yield, even though a single bush of 'Sunshine Blue' will crop well alone.

F6. Cranberry (*Vaccinium macrocarpon*)

Russian: Клюква крупноплодная

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Best fruiting in full sun.

Soil needs: Highly acidic, pH 4.0–5.0. Bog plant — prefers consistently moist, peaty, acidic conditions. Must be grown in ericaceous compost container or purpose-made acidic bog bed.

Pot size: 30–45cm wide, 20–30cm deep container; 100% ericaceous compost. Keep consistently moist. Do not add grit.

Planting depth: At pot level; shallow-rooting.

Spacing: 30–45cm in acidic bed

Fertiliser: Ericaceous liquid fertiliser monthly April–August. Do not use general-purpose fertilisers. Adapted to nutrient-poor conditions — do not overfeed.

Companions: Heather, lingonberry, blueberry (all share ericaceous requirements). Low carpet beneath taller blueberry bushes.

West of Ireland: The moist, mild Atlantic climate is naturally ideal for cranberry — but only if you provide or replicate acidic bog soil. Container with ericaceous compost is most practical.

F23. Fig (*Ficus carica*)

Popular hardy varieties:

Variety	Notes
'Brown Turkey'	RHS AGM; the most popular and reliable variety for outdoor UK/Ireland growing; large, sweet, red-fleshed fruit; hardy to about -10°C
'Brunswick'	Very hardy, suited to cooler areas; large fruit, pink-yellow flesh, ripens a little earlier than 'Brown Turkey'
'White Marseilles'	Compact, self-fertile; pale, very sweet fruit

Light: ☀ Full sun essential, ideally against a warm, south- or west-facing wall.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Figs actually crop best when their roots are restricted — overly rich, deep soil produces lush leaves at the expense of fruit.

Soil prep: If planting in the ground, restrict the roots using paving slabs or a buried bottomless container, packed with rubble at the base — this is essential for reliable fruiting, not optional. In a pot, use a loam-based compost such as John Innes No. 3 with added grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 3–4m if free-standing in the ground with roots restricted; large containers (35–45cm diameter) suit patio growing well.

Fertiliser: Weekly liquid tomato feed once the fruit has formed; annual mulch.

Companions: Best given its own space, since it casts fairly dense shade once mature.

Pruning: Prune in late winter/early spring to shape, and pinch out growing tips in early summer to encourage the embryonic fruit that will overwinter and ripen the following year.

Pot/container: ✅ Figs grow very well in a large pot, which naturally restricts the roots and encourages fruiting — often the easiest way to grow a productive fig in a cooler climate.

West of Ireland: In a temperate climate like Ireland's, figs typically produce two flushes of embryonic fruit a year: the young "embryo" figs that form in late summer survive winter on the bare branches and ripen the following year, while a second flush that forms in spring rarely has time to ripen outdoors and is best removed at the end of the season if larger than a pea. A warm, sheltered wall out of the worst of the Atlantic wind and rain gives the best results; all three varieties above are reliably hardy and self-fertile, needing no pollination partner (indeed no pollinating wasp, unlike wild figs).

F7. Garden Plum (*Prunus domestica*)

Irish / Russian: *Crann plumaí* · Слива домашняя

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for best fruiting — at least 6 hours daily, sheltered from wind.

Soil needs: Well-drained, moderately fertile soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Dislikes waterlogged clay — good drainage is essential.

Soil prep: Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Break up clay beneath. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit over a broad area. Keep a weed-free circle around the base.

Planting depth: Graft union (bulge near stem base) at or just above soil level. Plant to the nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 3–5m between trees depending on rootstock; permanent stake

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed) each February. Do not feed after midsummer, to allow wood to ripen before winter. Potash feed helps fruiting.

Companions: Chives and garlic to deter aphids. Comfrey or nasturtiums nearby to attract beneficial insects. Many plums (though not all) need a compatible pollination partner flowering at the same time — check the variety before buying.

Popular hardy cultivars: 'Victoria' — RHS AGM, self-fertile, the best-known English plum, dual-purpose (eating and cooking), late August–early September, though can crop unreliably some years. 'Czar' — RHS AGM, self-fertile, compact and very reliable, a traditional culinary plum that will even fruit on a north-facing wall, early August. 'Opal' — RHS AGM, self-fertile, early dessert plum with good flavour, very easy to grow, early August.

West of Ireland: Permanent staking recommended against Atlantic winds, especially on dwarfing rootstocks. Choose a sheltered, sunny spot away from frost pockets — plum blossoms early and late frosts can damage the crop. 'Czar' is a particularly good choice for a cooler, more exposed west of Ireland garden given its reliability and tolerance of less-than-ideal conditions.

F8. Gooseberry (*Ribes uva-crispa*)

Irish / Russian: *Spíonán* · Крыжовник обыкновенный

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade. Tolerates semi-shade better than most fruit.

Soil prep: Compost and grit amendment. Bonemeal at planting.

Planting depth: At nursery mark; roots covered ~5cm. Cut all stems to 30cm after planting.

Spacing: 1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Sulphate of potash in late winter/early spring. Balanced fertiliser after flowering. Annual compost mulch. Avoid excessive nitrogen.

Companions: Redcurrants, whitecurrants. Tansy nearby reportedly repels gooseberry sawfly.

F24. Hazelnut (*Corylus avellana*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Any well-drained soil, including clay and chalk; pH 6.0–7.5. Very adaptable.

Soil prep: Minimal — one of the easiest, most tolerant fruiting plants of clay in this guide.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 4–5m between plants for a full-sized bush, or 2m if grown as a managed, regularly coppiced hedge.

Fertiliser: Little needed once established; a balanced feed in spring for young plants.

Companions: Native Irish hedgerow species (blackthorn, hawthorn) if grown as informal hedging; primroses and bluebells beneath.

Pruning: Traditionally pruned in late winter ("brutting" — snapping over long sideshoots in late summer improves nut set); can be coppiced or kept as an open-centred bush.

West of Ireland: A native Irish tree/large shrub, found wild in hedgerows throughout the country, producing edible nuts in autumn. Fully hardy and thoroughly at home in the mild, moist Atlantic climate. Wind-pollinated by catkins in late winter, so plant at least two bushes (or rely on wild hazel nearby) for a reliable nut crop, since a single isolated bush often crops poorly. Squirrels are usually quicker than gardeners at harvesting the nuts.

F9. Honeyberry (*Lonicera caerulea* var. *kamtschatica*)

Russian: Жимолость камчатская

Popular garden varieties:

Variety	Taste	Height	Notes
'Altaj'	Sweet-sour, aromatic, honey-like	1.5–2m	From southern Siberia; extremely cold-hardy (to -40°C); thornless, compact habit; produces more aromatic fruit than many varieties
'Larisa'	Fresh, sweet	1.5–1.8m	Elongated berries rich in vitamins B and C; self-pollinating but crops better with a second variety nearby

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Fruits better in full sun.

Soil needs: Very flexible, pH 4.5–7.5, tolerates clay. Plant two different varieties for cross-pollination.

Soil prep: Standard clay improvement with compost and grit.

Planting depth: At pot level or slightly deeper.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch. Liquid balanced feed monthly during flowering and fruiting can improve yields.

Companions: Blueberry, lingonberry in adjacent beds. Pollinator-attracting flowers nearby (important for early February–April flowers). Needs 2+ varieties: e.g. 'Borealis' and 'Tundra', or 'Altaj' and 'Larisa'.

F10. Lingonberry (*Vaccinium vitis-idaea*)

Russian: Брусника обыкновенная

Light: ☀️ Partial shade preferred — woodland edge as recommended by the RHS. Tolerates full sun if soil stays consistently moist.

Soil needs: Acidic, moist but well-drained, pH 4.2–5.5. Same requirements as blueberry. Will not tolerate neutral or alkaline soil.

Pot size: 30cm diameter, 20cm+ deep container; 100% ericaceous compost. Or a dedicated acidic bed.

Planting depth: At pot level. Space 30cm apart.

Spacing: 30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Ericaceous liquid fertiliser monthly April–August only. Mulch with pine bark to maintain acidity.

Companions: Blueberry, heather, cranberry. Low ground cover under taller blueberry bushes. Also combines well with deer fern (same acidic conditions) in a naturalistic ericaceous bed.

West of Ireland: Produces berries twice per year (late July and late September). Self-fertile. Excellent for west of Ireland mild, moist climate.

F25. Olive (*Olea europaea*)

Light: ☀️ Full sun essential, in the warmest, most sheltered spot available.

Soil needs: Very free-draining soil, tolerant of poor, dry, alkaline ground; pH 6.0–8.5. Hates waterlogging above all else.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 40–50% horticultural grit, or grow in a large container of free-draining, loam-based compost — strongly preferable to open ground on Irish clay.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants if grown in open ground in a mild area; more commonly grown singly as a container specimen.

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in spring; avoid feeding late in the season.

Companions: Lavender, rosemary and other Mediterranean plants sharing its need for sun and sharp drainage.

Pot/container: ✅ Strongly recommended in this climate — growing in a large container allows the plant to be moved to a sheltered spot, porch or unheated glasshouse during the coldest, wettest spells of winter, which it tolerates far better than being left out in waterlogged ground.

West of Ireland: Borderline hardy (RHS H4, roughly to -5°C, though damage typically comes from wet cold rather than dry cold) — reliably surviving outdoors only in the very mildest, most sheltered coastal west of Ireland gardens, and even then rarely ripening a useful crop of fruit given the lack of sustained summer heat. Best treated as a handsome, silvery-leaved evergreen container specimen for its foliage and gnarled form, with any olives a curiosity rather than a realistic harvest. Winter wet, far more than winter cold, is what usually kills an olive in this climate — sharp drainage is essential.

F20. Peach (*Prunus persica*)

Popular varieties for Ireland/UK:

Variety	Season	Notes
'Peregrine'	Mid-August	RHS AGM; one of the most reliable croppers for a cooler climate thanks to later flowering; white flesh, excellent flavour
'Rochester'	Mid-August	RHS AGM; yellow flesh, reasonable flavour; large, juicy fruit; later flowering gives some frost protection
'Melred'	Early August	Self-fertile; compact (~2m), well suited to a large container; double deep pink-red ornamental blossom as well as fruit

Light: ☀️ Full sun essential, in a warm, sheltered spot such as against a south-facing wall.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Dig a hole twice the rootball width. Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark; keep the graft union above soil level.

Spacing: 2–3m if free-standing; fan-trained against a wall needs 3–4m of wall space.

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser each February; potash-rich feed as fruit develops. Stop feeding by midsummer.

Companions: Chives and garlic nearby to deter aphids; underplant with spring bulbs.

Pruning: Prune only in summer (never winter) to reduce the risk of silver leaf disease.

Pot/container:  'Melred' in particular stays compact, reaching only around 2m — well suited to a large container on a patio, in addition to open ground.

West of Ireland: All three varieties above are self-fertile, so a single tree crops without a pollination partner. Blossom appears March–April (protect from late frosts with horticultural fleece) followed by fruit ripening from early to mid-August depending on variety. Best grown fan-trained against a warm, sheltered wall in the cooler west of Ireland climate, which helps ripen both blossom and fruit and offers some protection from wind and rain. 'Peregrine' and 'Rochester', both later-flowering, are the more reliable choices for a genuinely cool, exposed site; 'Melred' suits a smaller garden or patio.

F26. Pear (*Pyrus communis*)

Popular varieties for Ireland/UK:

Variety	Pollination	Season	Notes
'Conference'	Self-fertile	Mid-late season	By far the most widely grown UK/Ireland pear; reliable, heavy-cropping, familiar elongated shape
'Concorde'	Partially self-fertile	Late season	RHS AGM; a 'Conference' × 'Doyenné du Comice' cross bred at East Malling; combines Conference's shape with Comice's sweetness
'Doyenné du Comice'	Needs a pollination partner	Late season	Widely regarded as the best-flavoured dessert pear, though a less reliable cropper and needs a sheltered spot

Pear rootstocks:

Rootstock	Vigour	Approx. height	Notes
Quince A	Semi-vigorous	Similar to apple M26	The standard general-purpose pear rootstock; suits bush, half-standard and most trained forms
Quince C	More dwarfing	1.8–2.4m (6–8ft)	Produces a smaller tree, roughly comparable to apple M9/Bud 9; needs staking and good soil

Light:  Full sun essential for best flowering and fruiting.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig a hole twice the rootball width. Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit for drainage.

Planting depth: Graft union at or just above soil level.

Spacing: Depends on rootstock and form — see rootstock table above; fan or espalier against a wall needs 3.5–5m of wall space.

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser each February; potash-rich feed as fruit develops.

Companions: Chives and garlic nearby to deter aphids; most pears need a compatible pollination partner flowering at the same time — check before buying.

Pruning: Prune in winter while dormant (unlike stone fruit); trained forms (espalier, cordon) are pruned in summer.

West of Ireland: Pears tolerate the mild, moist west of Ireland climate well, though blossom appears early and can be caught by late frosts — a sheltered, sunny spot away from frost pockets gives the best results. 'Conference' is the most forgiving choice for a typical Irish garden, being both self-fertile and a reliable cropper even in a cooler summer; 'Doyenné du Comice' rewards a warm, sheltered wall with genuinely superior flavour but is the least reliable of the three here.

F11. Plum Tree 'Aprimira' (*Prunus domestica* 'Aprimira')

Light:  Full sun essential — a warm, sheltered spot gives the best fruit set and ripening.

Soil needs: Fertile, well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Dislikes waterlogged clay; good drainage matters more than fertility.

Soil prep — in the ground: Dig a hole at least twice the width of the rootball. Break up the base of the hole to help roots establish. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost and 20–30% horticultural grit over a broad area, since good drainage is the single biggest factor in preventing root problems on wet Irish clay. Firm in well and stake permanently — plums often need support for their whole life on windy sites.

Soil prep — in a pot (recommended for smaller gardens): Use a container at least 25cm in diameter with drainage holes, and cover the base with a piece of broken pot or crock so water can always drain freely. Fill with a mix of one-third sharp sand, one-third multipurpose compost and one-third good topsoil or potting soil. Loosen the rootball before planting so roots spread outward rather than circling.

Planting depth: Plant so the top of the original rootball sits just below the surrounding soil or compost surface; keep the graft union above soil level.

Spacing: Sold as a standard (bush-headed) tree, ideal for a large pot or a small garden bed; allow at least 1–1.5m from other plants or structures.

Fertiliser: In pots, feed with cow manure pellets or a balanced granular feed in early spring, then a potash-rich granular feed (e.g. NPK 12-10-18) in May and again in July. In the ground, an annual balanced fruit tree feed each February is sufficient. Stop feeding by midsummer to let the wood ripen before winter.

Companions: Chives and garlic at the base help deter aphids. In a container, underplant with low, shallow-rooted plants only, to avoid competing with the tree's roots.

Pruning: Prune only in summer, during or just after flowering — never in winter, when open wounds on stone fruit are vulnerable to silver leaf disease. Prune lightly each February to maintain shape while flower buds are visible, working around them where possible.

Pot/container:  Bred and sold as a compact standard specifically for patio pots and small gardens; in winter, move container-grown plants to a cool, sheltered spot (a shed or a wall-sheltered corner) and wrap the pot in jute sacking or fleece to protect the roots from hard frost.

West of Ireland: 'Aprimira' is a self-fertile mirabelle-apricot hybrid plum, so no second pollinator tree is needed — useful in a smaller west of Ireland garden. It flowers in spring like other plums, so a sheltered, sunny spot away from frost pockets protects the blossom from late frost damage. Harvest is August–September; fruits have sweet, orange-yellow flesh with a stone that separates cleanly.

F12. Pomegranate (*Punica granatum*)

Russian: Гранат обыкновенный

Light:  Full sun essential, against a warm, sheltered south- or west-facing wall.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Dislikes waterlogged clay.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width against the wall base. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–3m against wall; borderline hardy, best in a container

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser in spring. Liquid high-potash feed through summer to encourage flowering/fruiting.

Companions: Other wall-trained sun-lovers such as passiflora or grapevine on the same warm wall.

West of Ireland: Borderline hardy (RHS H4, roughly to –5 to –10°C) — reliable fruiting in the west of Ireland's cooler, shorter summers is uncertain, and pomegranate is best treated primarily as an ornamental flowering wall shrub here, grown against a warm wall or in a large container that can be moved under cover in winter, with any fruit a bonus rather than a certainty.

F13. Raspberry (*Rubus idaeus*)

Irish / Russian: Sú craobh · Малина обыкновенная

Light:  Full sun to partial shade. Better fruiting in full sun.

Soil prep: Compost and grit essential on clay. Raised bed recommended. Plant in mounded rows or raised beds between parallel support wires.

Planting depth: Crown 5–7cm below soil. Cut canes to 25cm after planting.

Spacing: 45–60cm between canes; 1.8m between rows

Fertiliser: High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) fortnightly from spring bud break until fruit set. Or balanced granular fertiliser in early spring plus compost mulch. Avoid excessive nitrogen on wet clay.

Companions: Garlic, marigolds, tansy deter aphids. Avoid planting near potatoes (shared virus diseases) and wild brambles.

Your varieties:

Summer-fruiting (floricane — fruit on second-year canes; prune fruited canes to the ground in early to mid-autumn):

'Glen Ample' (PBR) — One of the most widely grown summer-fruiting raspberries in the UK; holds the RHS Award of Garden Merit. Bred at the James Hutton Institute (formerly Scottish Crop Research Institute), Scotland. Mid-season; harvest from late June to late July (sometimes into September). Large to very large, deep red, rich-flavoured berries — five large berries can weigh up to 30g. Almost completely thornless (spineless canes and laterals), making harvesting and pruning easy. High yields — over 2kg per plant — and excellent disease resistance. Canes grow to approximately 1.8m; tie to horizontal support wires. Best in well-drained, fertile, moisture-retentive soil; does not do well in waterlogged or very chalky conditions.

Autumn-fruiting (primocane — fruit on current year's canes; cut ALL canes to the ground in late winter/early spring):

'**Zefa Herbsterte**' (also sold as 'Zeva Herbsterte') — A primocane (autumn-fruiting) variety bred in Switzerland in 1952; one of the first commercial primocane raspberries and still widely grown. Sometimes spelled *Zefa*, sometimes *Zeva* — both refer to the same cultivar. Late-season: harvest from August to September (or until first frosts). Large, sweet-tasting, dark red berries measuring 2–3cm in length. Vigorous, upright canes to 150cm with thorns. Particularly well suited to cooler northern regions of the UK and Ireland. Good resistance to phytophthora root disease. Primocane cultivar so fruiting is best in its first year (all canes to the ground in late winter). Fruiting is best in cool summers.

'**Autumn Bliss**' — A primocane (autumn-fruiting) variety bred at East Malling Research Station, England. RHS Award of Garden Merit (1993 and 2009). One of the most widely grown autumn raspberries in the UK. Medium-large, firm, dark red berries from late July through to late October. Excellent disease resistance, particularly to aphids. Relatively short, self-supporting canes (to 150cm) that can often stand without support, though tying in is recommended in exposed west of Ireland conditions. Earlier to crop than most autumn varieties.

'**Heritage**' — An American primocane (autumn-fruiting) variety released in 1969 by Cornell University; long considered the standard against which autumn-bearing varieties are measured. Harvest from August into autumn. Medium-sized, firm, conical, deep red berries with a classic sweet-tart raspberry flavour. Excellent cold hardiness. Sturdy, often self-supporting canes. For UK and Irish growing, managed as an autumn raspberry (cut all canes to the ground in late winter). Popular commercially because fruit is firm, travels well, and the variety is reliably productive.

Patio/dwarf cultivars (suitable for containers; minimum 45–60cm wide, deep container):

'**Good as Gold**' (Lowberry® Goodasgold®) — A compact, dwarf autumn-fruiting raspberry with a final height under 100cm (usually 80cm), due to early flowering and fruiting which slows further growth. Produces medium-sized, pale yellow/golden fruits from mid-July through to autumn; sweet flavour and aroma. A few thorns present, reducing towards the tips of fruiting shoots. Bred as a patio cultivar, ideal for containers on a sunny patio or balcony. Part of the Lowberry® range of compact raspberry varieties.

'**Lucky Berry**' — A new, self-fertile, dwarf patio raspberry with a vigorous habit despite its compact size. Produces juicy, sweet-tasting red fruits over a remarkably long season of four months, from July to October, fruiting continuously until the first frosts. Part of the Lucky Berry® range of compact, long-season fruit plants selected specifically for pot cultivation. Resistant to diseases and cold. Prune back before winter. Ideal for containers on a terrace, balcony or patio.

'**Hararasp**' (Raspberry Tree) — A genuinely different growth habit: bred by Japanese breeder Toshihiko Hara, this self-supporting variety develops a thick, upright, self-standing "trunk" instead of sprawling canes, so it needs no support wires or staking. White blossom in April–May is followed by especially glossy, shiny berries from June into summer. Disease-resistant with good tolerance of heat and drought. Height varies with training and maturity, from around 75cm up to 1.5–1.75m; spread 50cm–1m. Fruits on one-year-old stems — prune out old fruited stems in early spring, keeping young growth. An excellent choice for the smallest patio, needing no cane support at all.

F14. Redcurrant (*Ribes rubrum*)

Irish / Russian: Cuirín dearg · Смородина красная

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. One of the most shade-tolerant fruiting plants — good for north-facing fences trained as a fan.

Soil prep: Compost and grit amendment. Good drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery mark; roots covered ~5cm.

Spacing: 1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Sulphate of potash in late winter. Balanced fertiliser after flowering. Annual bark or compost mulch. Do not overfeed with nitrogen.

Companions: Gooseberries, whitecurrants. North-facing fan trained redcurrant is a remarkably productive use of otherwise difficult wall space.

F15. Rhubarb (*Rheum × hybridum*)

Irish / Russian: Biabhóg · Ревень

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Tolerates partial shade better than most vegetables.

Soil needs: Fertile, moisture-retentive but well-drained. RHS advises raised beds on heavy clay.

Soil prep: Remove weeds, dig in two bucketfuls of compost per sq metre. Raised bed (30cm+) on wet clay.

Planting depth: Buds 1–2cm below soil level.

Spacing: 90cm between crowns

Fertiliser: Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. Generous well-rotted manure or compost mulch each autumn after leaves die back — this is the most beneficial treatment.

Companions: Beans and peas nearby (nitrogen-fixers). Keep away from fennel (inhibits many plants). Do not pick in the first year after planting.

F16. Serviceberry (*Amelanchier lamarckii*)

Russian: Ипра Ламарка

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 part shade. Best autumn colour in full sun.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; tolerates acid to neutral, pH 5.5–7.0. Dislikes waterlogging.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width and as deep as the rootball. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–4m between plants/structures

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost or bark mulch; little further feeding needed once established.

Companions: Underplant with hellebores, snowdrops, bluebells and ferns; works well as a woodland-edge specimen with Japanese maple and hydrangea.

West of Ireland: Multi-season interest — white spring blossom, edible summer berries (loved by birds), fiery autumn colour. Tolerates coastal wind well once established.

F21. Sour Cherry (*Prunus cerasus*)

Popular garden cultivars:

Variety	Pollination	Season	Notes
'Morello'	Self-fertile	Late summer	RHS AGM; by far the most widely grown cooking cherry; very hardy and reliable; dark red, acid-flavoured fruit; excellent on a shady north-facing wall where sweet cherries would not fruit
'Nabella'	Self-fertile	Mid-summer	Similar acid flavour to 'Morello' with slightly larger fruit; good disease resistance
'Kentish Red'	Self-fertile	Traditional/mid-season	An old, traditional English sour cherry, valued for jams and preserves

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade — the one fruit tree in this guide genuinely happy on a shady, north-facing wall.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile soil; pH 5.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig a hole wider and deeper than the rootball. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit. Dig in plenty of well-rotted manure or compost.

Planting depth: Graft union at or just above soil level.

Spacing: On Colt rootstock (the standard choice for sour cherries), up to 4m; fan-trained against a wall needs 3.5–4.5m of wall space.

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser in early spring, with a further feed after harvest.

Companions: Chives and garlic nearby to deter aphids.

Pruning: Prune in summer only, to reduce the risk of silver leaf disease. Sour cherries fruit on the previous year's wood, so after harvest cut out some of the older fruited wood to encourage new growth for next year — a different regime from sweet cherries.

West of Ireland: Genuinely useful for a shadier or north-facing spot where few other fruiting trees would crop well — sour cherries tolerate part shade far better than sweet cherries. Fully hardy in the mild, moist Irish climate. All three cultivars above are self-fertile, so a single tree is enough for a crop.

F17. Strawberry (*Fragaria × ananassa*)

Irish / Russian: Sú talún · Клубника садовая (земляника ананасная)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for maximum fruiting.

Soil needs: pH 5.5–6.8, well-drained. Raised bed on clay strongly recommended.

Soil prep: Compost and grit. Raised bed 20–25cm high.

Planting depth: Crown exactly at soil level — too deep = crown rot; too shallow = roots dry out.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants (or 45cm × 75cm rows if in open ground)

Fertiliser: High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) fortnightly from first flowers until fruiting ceases. Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. Do not use high-nitrogen fertiliser.

Companions: Borage, garlic, chives, marigolds. Avoid planting near brassicas.

Popular garden varieties:

Variety	Type	Season	Notes
'Korona'	Summer-fruiting	Early-mid-season (from mid-June)	Large, glossy, dark red, very juicy fruit; excellent resistance to verticillium wilt, botrytis and grey mould — a real advantage in the wet west of Ireland climate
'Ostara'	Perpetual (everbearing)	Early summer, then mid-July until first frosts	Conical, medium-sized, firm, juicy fruit with a flavour recalling wild strawberry; vigorous, spreading habit suits raised beds and hanging baskets
'Summer Breeze'	Perpetual (everbearing)	Throughout the growing season	Compact, ornamental patio strawberry, grown as much for its decorative flowers and habit as for its small, sweet berries; good for containers and borders

F5. Sweet Cherry (*Prunus avium*)

Popular garden cultivars (UK/Ireland):

Variety	Pollination	Season	Notes
'Athos'	Self-fertile	June–July	Compact patio bush grown on its own roots (not grafted); very winter-hardy; stays 100–250cm depending on container/ground
'Stella'	Self-fertile	Mid-July	RHS AGM; the original self-fertile sweet cherry (bred at the John Innes Institute, Norwich); tangy, dark red-black fruit; reliable in cooler areas
'Sunburst'	Self-fertile	Early-mid-July	Large, dark red-black fruit with a full, sweet flavour; considered by many the best all-round self-fertile garden cherry
'Lapins' (syn. 'Cherokee')	Self-fertile	Late July–early August	Large, dark, crack-resistant fruit; extends the season beyond 'Stella'; vigorous, upright
'Sweetheart'	Self-fertile	Very late season	Red to dark red fruit; outstanding flavour and texture; RHS AGM
'Sylvia'	Self-fertile	June–July	Exceptionally compact (125–150cm), ideal for the smallest patios and large containers

Cherry rootstocks:

Rootstock	Vigour	Approx. height	Notes
Colt	Semi-vigorous	3.5–4m (12–14ft)	Good anchorage, no permanent staking needed once established; tolerates poorer soil than Gisela 5; the traditional choice for a fan or bush in a larger garden
Gisela 5	Semi-dwarfing	2.4–3m (8–10ft)	The most popular modern choice for a manageable garden cherry; needs permanent staking and fertile, reliably moist soil
Krymsk 5	Semi-vigorous	Similar to Gisela 6, slightly larger than Gisela 5	Very cold-hardy, well anchored, does not usually need permanent staking

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily. Avoid frost pockets, since late spring frosts damage blossom.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile soil; pH 5.5–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging.

Soil prep: Dig a hole wider and deeper than the rootball. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% horticultural grit for drainage. In a pot, use a container at least 30–40cm in diameter with good drainage holes.

Planting depth: Graft union at or just above soil level (own-root types like 'Athos' have no graft union — plant at the same depth as the nursery pot).

Spacing: Depends on rootstock and form — see rootstock table above; compact patio cultivars like 'Athos' and 'Sylvia' need only 1–1.5m.

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed) in early spring, with a further feed after harvest. Avoid feeding late in the season.

Companions: Chives and garlic nearby help deter aphids. Keep a weed-free, mulched area around the base.

Pruning: Prune only in summer, ideally straight after harvest, to reduce the risk of silver leaf disease common to *Prunus* species.

Pot/container: ✅ 'Athos' and 'Sylvia' were bred specifically for pot culture and are among the most compact, patio-friendly sweet cherries available. ⚠️ Protect ripening fruit from birds with netting.

West of Ireland: Sweet cherries tolerate the mild, wet west of Ireland winters well provided drainage is adequate; the main local risk is losing blossom to a late spring frost, so a sheltered spot away from frost pockets gives the most reliable cropping. For a small garden or patio, 'Athos' or 'Sylvia' on their own compact roots are the most realistic choice; for a larger garden, any of the self-fertile cultivars above on Gisela 5 (small) or Colt (larger, more tolerant of poorer soil) will crop reliably.

Fig. Woodland Strawberry (*Fragaria vesca*)

Irish / Russian: Sú talún fíáin · Земляника лесная

Light: ☀️ Full sun to ☁️ partial shade. Tolerates full shade but fruits less freely there.

Soil needs: Fertile, moist but well-drained soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Tolerates clay and a wide pH range better than most fruit.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost. Mulch with leaf mould to mimic its natural woodland-edge habitat.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level — do not bury the crown.

Spacing: 25–30cm between plants; runners will fill gaps and can be left to spread or removed to keep a tidier clump.

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch, kept away from the crown.

Companions: Ferns, hostas, primroses — a natural, decorative groundcover under fruit trees and in a woodland-edge bed; also good as informal edging along a path.

West of Ireland: Smaller and less showy than garden strawberry, but reliably hardy, shade-tolerant and long-fruited (often June to autumn), with small, intensely flavoured berries. Spreads gently by runners to form an attractive edible groundcover under trees and shrubs — a good choice for a spot too shaded for garden strawberry.

A note on "Alpine Strawberry": This popular garden name refers to cultivated, non-running forms of this same species (*Fragaria vesca*, often listed as var. *semperflorens*), bred as compact, "runnerless" plants that stay in a tidy clump rather than spreading — useful for edging a path or bed where a spreading wild form would be unwelcome. Popular alpine strawberry cultivars include 'Mignonette' and 'Alexandria'. Growing needs are identical to the wild woodland strawberry described above; alpine types simply stay put rather than colonising by runners.

GROUP G: GROUNDCOVER & CREEPING PLANTS

G10. Bellflowers (Rockery) (*Campanula* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Adriatic Bellflower	<i>C. garganica</i>	Up to 10cm	Summer (June–September)	At pot level	Mat-forming, star-shaped lilac-blue flowers with a white centre; RHS AGM; superb for wall crevices and paving cracks
Carpathian Bellflower	<i>C. carpatica</i>	15–25cm	Early–late summer	At pot level	Neat, low, non-spreading mound; upward-facing bells; good for edging and troughs
Dalmatian Bellflower	<i>C. portenschlagiana</i>	10–15cm, spreading to 50cm+	Summer	At pot level	Vigorous mat-forming evergreen; RHS AGM; excellent in wall crevices and between paving
Trailing Rock Bellflower	<i>C. saxifraga</i>	10–15cm, trailing	Summer	At pot level	Trailing, semi-evergreen; best in a trough, rockery or wall crevice

Light: ☀️ Full sun for Trailing Rock Bellflower. Adriatic, Carpathian and Dalmatian Bellflower: full sun to partial shade, especially in the heat of late summer.

Soil needs: Trailing Rock Bellflower: free-draining, gritty soil, pH 6.5–7.5 — rots in wet, heavy clay over winter. Adriatic and Carpathian Bellflower: well-drained, moist, fertile soil, neutral to alkaline, pH 6.0–7.0 — dislikes both waterlogging and drying out. Dalmatian Bellflower: average, well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.5 — very adaptable, though it dislikes constantly wet soil and humid air more than the others.

Soil prep: Trailing Rock Bellflower: improve clay heavily with 30–40% horticultural grit; best in a raised trough, rockery or wall crevice rather than open ground. Adriatic, Carpathian and Dalmatian Bellflower: mix clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost and horticultural grit.

Planting depth: At pot level for all four.

Spacing: Trailing Rock Bellflower: 15–20cm between plants. Adriatic Bellflower: 15–20cm between plants. Carpathian Bellflower: 25–35cm between plants; low, mounding, non-invasive habit. Dalmatian Bellflower: 30–40cm between plants; spreads by rhizomes to 50cm or more but is not invasive.

Fertiliser: Trailing Rock Bellflower: very little required — a light balanced feed in spring if in a container. Adriatic, Carpathian and Dalmatian Bellflower: balanced feed in spring and again in midsummer.

Companions: Trailing Rock Bellflower: sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort and other rockery/trough plants with the same sharp-drainage needs. Adriatic, Carpathian and Dalmatian Bellflower: sempervivum, saxifrage, dianthus pinks — front-of-border and rockery companions.

West of Ireland: Trailing Rock Bellflower is one of the plants most likely to fail on flat, wet clay — best given the sharp drainage a raised trough or wall crevice provides. Adriatic Bellflower is one of the most floriferous of the group, smothering itself in starry flowers all summer, and (like Carpathian Bellflower) is distinct in habit from the taller campanulas elsewhere in this guide (Clustered, Spreading and Peach-leaved Bellflower) — all are neat, low, non-spreading mounds ideal for rock gardens, border edging or troughs. Dalmatian Bellflower is the most vigorous of the four and semi-evergreen — in colder, more exposed spots it may lose its leaves over winter, regrowing freely in spring; excellent cascading over a wall or raised bed, but best kept away from smaller, less competitive rockery plants.

G2. Creeping Phlox / Moss Phlox (*Phlox subulata*)

Russian: Флокс шиловидный

Light: ☀ Full sun preferred. Creeping Phlox thrives in full sun, but it can tolerate light shade, especially in hotter climates. More sun typically leads to a denser bloom.

Soil needs: This plant prefers well-drained soil. While it can tolerate a range of soil types, from sandy to clay, it doesn't like to sit in water. Consider amending your soil with compost or other organic matter to improve drainage, especially if your soil is heavy clay. pH 5.5–7.7.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–25% grit. On heavy clay, a raised bed or slope is ideal.

Planting depth: At pot level. Plant Phlox subulata root balls so that the root system is fully submerged in the compost, leaving any young shoots/leaves, buds or stems exposed above the soil surface. Space 30–45cm apart.

Spacing: 30–45cm for ground cover

Fertiliser: In early spring, feed Creeping Phlox with a slow-release, balanced fertilizer to support healthy growth and abundant flowering. Light feeding only — over-feeding produces lush, floppy growth. Minimal fertiliser once established.

Companions: Creeping Phlox makes a gorgeous underplanting for spring bulbs like tulips and daffodils. Excellent on slopes, in rock gardens, or cascading over walls. With thyme, sedum, dianthus, and other well-drained-soil companions in a sunny rockery. Weigela as a taller backdrop.

Pot size: 20–30cm diameter, 15cm deep; multipurpose compost with 20–25% grit. Excellent in shallow, wide terracotta bowls on sunny patios.

West of Ireland: The mild, moist Irish climate requires excellent drainage for this plant. A sunny south-facing slope, raised bed, or rock garden is ideal. Grows well in walls and between paving stones. May suffer crown rot in continuously wet conditions — drainage is the key.

G22. Evergreen Candytuft (*Iberis sempervirens*)

Light: ☀ Full sun for the best flowering; tolerates light shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor ground; pH 6.5–8.0, preferring neutral to alkaline. Intolerant of wet, poorly drained conditions.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 25–30% horticultural grit; a raised bed or rockery gives the most reliable results.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Little needed once established.

Pruning: Shear back by about a third immediately after flowering to keep the plant compact and encourage a tidy second flush of growth.

Companions: Aubretia, arabis, alyssum — classic spring rockery/wall-top trio; also good with spring bulbs.

West of Ireland: A low, spreading, woody-based evergreen sub-shrub, smothered in dense clusters of small white flowers from spring into early summer, sometimes with a lighter repeat in autumn. Widely available under various named cultivars (e.g. 'Purity', 'Snowflake', 'Little Gem'); if buying a specific named variety, check availability with a local nursery, as exact cultivars in the trade change from season to season. Fully hardy and easy given good drainage — an excellent edging or wall-top plant for the west of Ireland once its main dislike (waterlogging) is addressed.

G3. Heathers (*Calluna* / *Erica* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Common Heather / Ling	<i>Calluna vulgaris</i> (syn. <i>Erica vulgaris</i>)	20–50cm	Summer–autumn	At pot level	Native to Irish heathland; the classic garden heather; strictly acid soil only
Bell Heather	<i>Erica cinerea</i>	15–50cm	Early summer–early autumn	At pot level	Native to Ireland; vivid magenta-purple bell flowers; acid soil only
Winter Heath	<i>Erica carnea</i>	10–25cm	Late autumn–mid spring	At pot level	Also commonly sold as "Winter Heather"; the one heather reliably tolerant of neutral to mildly alkaline soil; low mat, valuable winter colour
Irish Heath	<i>Erica erigena</i>	45–75cm (some cultivars to 1.2m)	Winter–late spring	At pot level	Native to Connemara/Mayo; taller and upright; tolerates neutral to mildly alkaline soil, unusually wet-tolerant
Tree Heath	<i>Erica arborea</i>	1–2m in cultivation (to 7m in the wild)	Late winter–spring	At pot level	Much larger, upright shrub with honey-scented white flowers; needs a sheltered spot, less reliably hardy than the others
Alpine Tree Heath	<i>Erica arborea</i> var. <i>alpina</i>	1–2m	Spring (March–May)	At pot level	A hardier, more compact, RHS AGM form of tree heath; white flowers in dense cylindrical spikes; the toughest choice if tree heath's height/hardiness is wanted without the risk of the straight species
Heather 'Zilly'	<i>Calluna vulgaris</i> 'Zilly'	30cm, spread 30cm	Autumn (September–November)	At pot level	Bright pink flowers with woolly silver foliage deepening to purple-grey in winter; bushy, upright habit

Light: ☀ Full sun for all seven — flowering and foliage colour suffer in shade, though light shade from high-canopied trees is tolerated.

Soil needs: *Calluna vulgaris* and *Erica cinerea* are strict calcifuges — acid soil only, pH 6.5 or below (ideally 5.5) — and will not tolerate lime. *Erica carnea* and *Erica erigena* are the exceptions in this group: both are genuinely lime-tolerant and will grow in neutral to mildly alkaline soil, though they still perform best in humus-rich, well-drained ground. *Erica arborea* and its hardier form var. *alpina* prefer well-drained, acid to neutral soil. *Calluna vulgaris* 'Zilly' shares the same strict acid-soil requirement as the straight species.

Soil prep: For acid-loving species (*vulgaris*, *cinerea*, *arborea*) on neutral or alkaline clay: grow in containers of ericaceous compost only — do not add lime near any of them. For lime-tolerant species (*carnea*, *erigena*) in the open ground, add leafmould or composted bark to the clay; heavy grit is less important than for most plants in this guide, since good structure and moisture retention matter more than sharp drainage here.

Planting depth: At pot level for all seven.

Spacing: *Calluna vulgaris*, *E. cinerea*, *E. carnea*: 30–45cm between plants. *E. erigena*: 45–60cm, or closer if grown as a low informal hedge. *E. arborea* and var. *alpina*: 1–1.5m, since they grow much larger. *Calluna vulgaris* 'Zilly': 30–40cm.

Fertiliser: An ericaceous fertiliser annually in March/April keeps all seven flowering well, or a liquid feed such as Phostrogen between April and September; heather grown in naturally suitable soil generally needs little feeding. Annual mulch with composted pine bark or leafmould benefits all species.

Companions: Blueberry, lingonberry, cranberry (all ericaceous, sharing *Calluna*'s and *E. cinerea*'s acid-soil needs). Creeping juniper, deer fern, dwarf bulbs (species crocus, snowdrops) and Japanese maple all combine beautifully with any of the seven for year-round interest and contrasting texture.

Pot/container: ✅ All seven can be grown in containers using peat-free ericaceous compost (for *carnea/erigena*, ordinary peat-free multipurpose compost is also fine given their lime tolerance); minimum 20–25cm diameter, 20cm deep, repotted every 3 years.

West of Ireland: *Calluna vulgaris* and *Erica cinerea* are both native to Irish heathland and perfectly adapted to the moist western climate, provided the soil is genuinely acidic — check pH before planting in the ground. *Erica erigena*, the Irish Heath, is a real rarity: genuinely native to a handful of sites in Connemara and Co. Mayo, and one of the very few heathers that tolerates the region's damper, less acidic pockets of ground. *Erica carnea* is the easiest choice for a garden with neutral or slightly alkaline soil. *Erica arborea* is the most tender of the group and appreciates the mild Atlantic winters, but still wants a sheltered spot away from the harshest coastal wind; its var. *alpina*

form is a hardier, more compact alternative with the same tree-heath character. *Calluna vulgaris* 'Zilly' shares the straight species' easy, native-adapted nature, with the bonus of striking silver winter foliage. Note that "*Erica vulgaris*" is simply an old synonym for *Calluna vulgaris*, not a separate species — the two names refer to exactly the same plant.

G25. Himalayan Bistort (Fleece Flower, Lesser Knotweed) (*Persicaria affinis* 'Superba')

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌂 partial shade.

Soil needs: Most soils including clay, moist but reasonably drained; pH 5.5–7.5. Tolerant and undemanding.

Soil prep: Minimal — one of the easiest, most clay-tolerant groundcovers in this guide.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants; spreads steadily to form a dense mat.

Fertiliser: Little needed once established.

Companions: Ornamental grasses, sedum and other late-season perennials; useful for covering a bank or difficult clay area where little else thrives.

Warnings ⚠: Spreads readily and can be vigorous in good conditions (though not as aggressively invasive as its relative Japanese knotweed) — give it defined edges or space to roam, and avoid planting near a boundary with wild ground.

West of Ireland: A low, mat-forming, semi-evergreen groundcover with narrow, pointed leaves that flush red in autumn, and dense spikes of pink flowers fading to russet-red from summer into autumn. Extremely tough and reliable on the region's clay soils, tolerating both damp and reasonably dry conditions — an excellent low-maintenance choice for covering a difficult bank or slope.

G4. Houseleek (*Sempervivum* spp.)

Irish / Russian: *Lus an tóiteáin* · Молодило

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Very free-draining, poor to moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Rots quickly in wet clay, especially winter.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 40%+ grit, or grow entirely in a shallow pot/trough of gritty, free-draining compost.

Planting depth: At pot level; do not bury the rosette.

Spacing: 10–15cm between rosettes

Fertiliser: None to very little required — rich soil produces soft, less hardy growth.

Companions: Saxifrage, wall pennywort, thyme, sedum — classic gritty rockery/roof-garden planting.

West of Ireland: Extremely hardy and drought-tolerant once established, but the biggest risk on Irish clay is winter wet, not cold — a raised trough, wall top, or gritty rockery gives much better results than open ground. Spreads by offsets ("chicks") to form a mat over time.

G26. Jenny's Stonecrop (Reflexed Stonecrop) (*Petrosedum rupestre* 'Angelina')

A note on the name: Widely sold and still commonly labelled as *Sedum* 'Angelina', this popular cultivar has been reclassified by some botanical authorities into the segregate genus *Petrosedum*, as *Petrosedum rupestre* 'Angelina' — both names refer to exactly the same plant.

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for the best golden colour.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil, tolerant of poor, dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 30–40% horticultural grit; a raised bed or gritty border edge suits it best.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; spreads to form a dense, low mat.

Fertiliser: None required — thrives on poor soil; over-feeding produces lax, less colourful growth.

Companions: Sempervivum, other sedums, ornamental grasses — classic dry gravel-garden and green-roof companions; Black Mondo Grass for striking colour contrast.

West of Ireland: A low, spreading, evergreen succulent with bright golden-yellow needle-like foliage that takes on orange-red tints in cold weather, and small starry yellow flowers in summer. Fully hardy and very easy given sharp drainage — good for a gravel garden, green roof, or cascading over a wall, and a reliable source of winter colour when little else is bright.

G1. Junipers (Creeping) (*Juniperus* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Creeping Juniper	<i>J. horizontalis</i>	10–30cm, spreading	Foliage plant (no ornamental flower)	At pot level or slightly raised	Widest pH tolerance (4.5–8.5); tolerates clay, rocky and poor soils given sharp drainage
Juniper 'Repanda'	<i>J. communis</i> 'Repanda'	20–40cm, spreading	Foliage plant (no ornamental flower)	At pot level, roughly 15cm deep	Native genus in Ireland; bronze-green winter colour; well suited to exposed, coastal sites

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for both — neither will grow well in shade, and Juniper 'Repanda' needs it for dense growth and best foliage colour.

Soil needs: Creeping Juniper: pH 4.5–8.5, tolerates clay, rocky and poor soils, but requires excellent drainage and will rot in constantly wet clay. Juniper 'Repanda': free-draining soil, pH 4.5–7.5 — copes with poor soil but dislikes sitting wet in winter.

Soil prep: Creeping Juniper: mix clay with 30–40% horticultural grit; plant on a slight mound or raised bed, essential on very wet clay. Juniper 'Repanda': improve clay with 25–30% horticultural grit worked into the planting area; on the wettest sites, plant on a slightly raised mound or ridge to keep the base clear of standing water.

Planting depth: Creeping Juniper: at pot level or slightly raised above it. Juniper 'Repanda': at pot level, roughly 15cm deep, at the same level as it sat in its nursery pot.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants for both, to form a continuous carpet.

Fertiliser: Creeping Juniper: virtually no feeding required — evolved on lean soils; a light slow-release balanced fertiliser in spring only if the plant appears weak, and a grit mulch is more beneficial than fertiliser. Juniper 'Repanda': none needed for the first 6–8 weeks after planting, then an occasional light dressing of Kieserite (magnesium sulphate) or organic conifer feed in February–March.

Companions: Creeping Juniper: heather, sedum, ornamental grasses, thyme, rosemary; excellent ground cover beneath Irish yew, holly and conifers, and a good companion for fruit trees. Juniper 'Repanda': heather, sempervivum, saxifrage and other rockery or gravel-garden plants; also works as groundcover beneath the Dwarf Mountain Pine.

Pruning: Juniper 'Repanda': prune only to remove dead or damaged growth.

West of Ireland: For Creeping Juniper, ⚠ the biggest challenge is the region's high rainfall — raised beds, slopes, or very well-drained gritty ground are essential. Juniper 'Repanda' is a cultivar of common juniper, which is native to Ireland and found on rocky uplands and coastal heath, so it is naturally well suited to exposed, windy or coastal west of Ireland sites and to poor, thin soils where little else will form dense cover.

G24. Ophiopogon (Mondo Grass) (*Ophiopogon* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Dwarf Mondo Grass	<i>O. japonicus</i> 'Minor'	5–10cm	Insignificant	At pot level	Tiny, tuft-forming, grass-like evergreen; excellent between paving stones or as a lawn substitute in miniature
Black Mondo Grass	<i>O. planiscapus</i> 'Niger'	15–20cm	Summer (pale lilac, then black berries)	At pot level	Near-black, strap-shaped evergreen foliage; a dramatic foil for silver or gold foliage and pale flowers

Light: ☀ Full sun for the best black colour in 'Niger'; both tolerate 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Not a true grass (both are related to lily-of-the-valley) and prefer more moisture-retentive soil than most true ornamental grasses in this guide.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost; heavy grit is less necessary than for the sun/dry ornamental grasses elsewhere in this guide.

Planting depth: At pot level for both.

Spacing: 'Minor': 10–15cm between plants for a dense carpet. 'Niger': 20–25cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Little needed — a light balanced feed in spring is sufficient.

Companions: 'Niger' is a classic foil for golden or silver foliage (Sedum 'Angelina', golden sedges) and pale flowers; 'Minor' works well between paving or as a small-scale groundcover under other plants.

West of Ireland: Both are slow-spreading, tough, evergreen groundcovers well suited to the mild, moist Irish climate, tolerating a wider range of moisture than most true grasses. Dwarf Mondo Grass is ideal for a miniature "lawn" effect between stepping stones; Black Mondo Grass is one of the most striking near-black foliage plants available for a border edge or container, especially effective planted alongside pale gravel or silver-leaved companions.

G6. Periwinkle (*Vinca minor* and *V. major*)

Irish / Russian: *Fincín mór* · Барвинок малый

Light: 🌑 Full shade to 🌞 full sun. Grow in any but very dry soil, in full sun (for best flowering) to partial shade.

Soil needs: Grow in any but very dry soil. Tolerates heavy clay, pH 5.5–8.0. One of the most clay-tolerant ground cover plants. Remarkably adaptable.

Soil prep: Basic compost addition to planting hole. Even unamended clay is usually tolerated.

Planting depth: At pot level. Space 30–45cm apart for ground cover.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants; can spread

Fertiliser: Very low-maintenance. A balanced slow-release fertiliser in spring if the plant appears slow or pale. Annual bark mulch is more useful than feeding. In containers, monthly balanced liquid feed during the growing season.

Companions: Hellebores, snowdrops, ivy — classic trio for difficult shaded areas. Excellent under trees and shrubs where grass won't grow. Underplant forsythia, lilac, or shrub roses with periwinkle for year-round ground cover. The blue flowers of *V. minor* are a valuable early source of nectar for bees.

⚠️ *Vinca* can spread vigorously — in small or formal gardens, divide and restrict regularly.

Pot size: 25–35cm diameter container; multipurpose compost.

West of Ireland: Excellent in all Irish conditions. Tolerates coastal exposure, clay, shade, and wet winters. Very low-maintenance once established. Can self-layer (roots where stems touch soil) and spread into extensive ground cover without any effort.

G21. Pickle Plant (*Delosperma echinatum*)

Light: 🌞 Full sun essential.

Soil needs: Very free-draining, gritty soil, tolerant of poor, dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5. Rots quickly in wet winter clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 40–50% horticultural grit; a raised bed, trough or pot is strongly recommended on Irish clay.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants.

Fertiliser: None required — a genuine drought-tolerant succulent adapted to poor soil.

Companions: Sempervivum, saxifrage and other sharply-drained rockery succulents.

West of Ireland: A South African succulent groundcover with fleshy, bristly, cucumber-like leaves and bright yellow daisy flowers in summer. Borderline hardy (RHS H3, roughly to -5°C) — reliable outdoors only in a very sheltered, sharply drained west of Ireland spot, or best grown in a pot that can be moved under cover for winter given the region's wet conditions.

G7. Prickly Heath (*Gaultheria mucronata*)

Irish / Russian: *Fraoch deilgneach* · Гаультерия остроконечная

Light: 🌞 Full sun to 🌂 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, acid soil; pH 4.5–6.0. Dislikes lime.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30–40% ericaceous compost and grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants; ♂+♀ for berries

Fertiliser: Ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Annual mulch with ericaceous compost or bark.

Companions: Heather, blueberry, lingonberry — classic acid-soil groundcover planting; good with dwarf conifers.

West of Ireland: Dioecious — plant a male near females for the females' showy, long-lasting white, pink or magenta berries in autumn/winter. Compact evergreen groundcover, tolerant of coastal exposure once established.

G8. Reindeer Lichen (*Cladonia rangiferina*)

Russian: Кладония оленья

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌂 partial shade.

Soil needs: Very poor, free-draining, acid soil or bare mineral ground/rock; pH 4.0–5.5. Will not survive in rich garden soil or where it is shaded out by faster-growing plants.

Soil prep: None — this is a slow-growing lichen, not a rooted vascular plant. Best established on an existing patch of poor, undisturbed acid ground, sand, or a rockery, not planted into amended clay.

Planting depth: Laid on the surface, not buried.

Spacing: Establishes slowly; avoid disturbance

Fertiliser: None — feeding kills lichens, which take all their nutrients from air and rain.

Companions: Heather, sempervivum and other poor-soil, sun-loving plants of open heath or rockery.

West of Ireland: Genuinely difficult to establish deliberately — reindeer lichen grows extremely slowly (a few mm per year) and needs open, undisturbed, nutrient-poor ground, most realistically an established rockery or heath-style planting rather than a conventional border. Best treated as a feature to preserve if already present, rather than one to plant and expect quick results from.

G20. Rockcress (*Arabis* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Variegated Rock Cress 'Old Gold'	<i>A. ferdinandi-coburgi</i> 'Old Gold'	10–15cm	Spring	At pot level	Grey-green leaves edged in creamy gold; small white flowers; the most ornamental foliage of the three
Rose/Coast Rock Cress	<i>A. blepharophylla</i>	15–20cm	Late winter–late spring (February–May)	At pot level	Fragrant, deep purplish-pink flowers; mat-forming to mounding; native to coastal California
Mountain/Caucasian Rock Cress	<i>A. caucasica</i>	25–30cm	Late spring–summer	At pot level	Fragrant white (occasionally pink-tinted) flowers; the most vigorous and cold-hardy of the three; RHS AGM cultivars available

Light: ☀ Full sun for all three — best variegation and flowering.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil, tolerant of poor ground; pH 6.0–7.5. All dislike sitting wet over winter.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 25–30% horticultural grit; a raised bed, wall top or rockery suits all three best.

Planting depth: At pot level for all three.

Spacing: 'Old Gold': 30–40cm. Rose/Coast Rock Cress: 20–25cm. Mountain/Caucasian Rock Cress: 30–45cm, given its more vigorous spread.

Fertiliser: Little needed for any of them — over-feeding produces lax growth and less flowering.

Companions: Aubretia, alyssum and other classic wall-top/rockery trailing perennials; spring bulbs planted through the mat.

West of Ireland: All three are low, spreading, easy evergreen perennials given sharp drainage — trim lightly after flowering to keep them neat and encourage fresh growth. 'Old Gold' is grown chiefly for its variegated foliage; Rose/Coast Rock Cress brings a stronger pink-purple flower colour than most rockcress; Mountain/Caucasian Rock Cress is the toughest and most vigorous of the three, an excellent reliable groundcover for a wall top or the edge of a raised bed.

G9. Saxifrage (*Saxifraga* spp., alpine/rockery types)

Irish / Russian: Mórán · Камнеломка

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌂 partial shade, depending on species.

Soil needs: Free-draining, gritty soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Most alpine saxifrages rot in wet, heavy clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 30–40% grit; best in a rockery, trough, or raised bed.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required. Light balanced feed in spring for container-grown plants.

Companions: Sempervivum, campanula saxifraga, wall pennywort, dwarf bulbs (species crocus, dwarf iris).

West of Ireland: A large genus with many hardy mat- and cushion-forming evergreen species suited to rockeries, troughs and wall crevices; excellent drainage is the single most important factor for success on west of Ireland clay.

G23. Siskiyou Lewisia (*Lewisia cotyledon*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

Soil needs: Very free-draining, gritty soil; pH 6.0–7.0. The rosette is highly prone to rot if water sits on or around it, especially in winter.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 40–50% horticultural grit; plant on a slight mound or slope so water runs away from the crown, or grow in a raised trough.

Planting depth: Plant with the rosette base slightly proud of the soil surface, angled if on a slope, so water cannot collect around the crown; surround with a collar of grit.

Spacing: 20–25cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring; avoid rich feeding.

Companions: Sempervivum, saxifrage, houseleek — classic sharp-drainage rockery companions.

West of Ireland: An evergreen alpine rosette plant with vivid, multi-coloured (pink, orange, yellow, magenta or striped) flowers in late spring and early summer. The single biggest challenge in the wet west of Ireland climate is keeping the crown dry over winter — plant on a slope, in a raised trough or between rocks where water drains away instantly, or grow in a pot under a cold frame's cover through the wettest months.

G13. Thyme (Creeping) (*Thymus* spp.)

Irish / Russian: *Tím* · ТИМЬЯН ОБЫКНОВЕННЫЙ

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Mother of Thyme (Creeping Thyme)	<i>T. serpyllum</i>	5–10cm, mat-forming	Summer	At pot level	Well-drained to dry, poor soil; the more commonly grown culinary/ornamental mat thyme
Wild Thyme	<i>T. polytrichus</i>	2–5cm, mat-forming	Summer	At pot level	Native Irish wildflower of dry grassland, heaths, dunes and stone walls; needs the sharpest drainage of the two

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for both — requires maximum sunshine and warmth.

Soil needs: Mother of Thyme: well-drained to dry, poor soil, pH 6.0–8.0 — dislikes wet clay, a raised bed or pot is essential. Wild Thyme: free-draining, alkaline to neutral soil, tolerant of poor/shallow ground, pH 6.5–7.5 — genuinely native to Ireland on dry grassland, heaths, dunes and stone walls; in the cooler, wetter north and west it also tolerates some acidic soils better than in drier parts of Britain.

Soil prep: Mother of Thyme: 40–50% grit mixed with compost, with small pebbles as a surface mulch. Wild Thyme: improve clay generously with 30–40% horticultural grit — this is one of the least clay-tolerant plants in the guide and needs sharp drainage above all else; a raised bed, gravel garden or wall-top setting suits it far better than flat ground.

Planting depth: At pot level for both.

Spacing: Mother of Thyme: 20–30cm between plants. Wild Thyme: 20–30cm between plants; spreads by runners to form a dense, low mat.

Fertiliser: Mother of Thyme: very low nutrient requirements — evolved on lean soil; a very light dressing of balanced fertiliser in spring is the maximum needed, and do not feed in summer or autumn, since a grit mulch is more beneficial than fertiliser. Wild Thyme: none required — a genuine stress-tolerator adapted to poor, lean soil; feeding produces weak, less aromatic growth.

Companions: Mother of Thyme: rosemary, oregano, lavender, creeping juniper; grows beautifully between paving stones or on dry walls, and alongside pasqueflower in a raised sunny bed. Wild Thyme: sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort — classic dry rockery/gravel garden companions.

West of Ireland: Mother of Thyme needs a raised bed or pot to perform reliably on west of Ireland clay. Wild Thyme is a true native Irish wildflower, common on dry grassland, coastal heath and old stone walls, and the larval food plant of the large blue butterfly in Britain — distinct from Mother of Thyme, it is less commonly used in cooking and better suited to a dry wildflower bank, rockery or scented lawn than a kitchen bed.

GII. Wall Pennywort (*Umbilicus rupestris*)

Irish / Russian: *Lus na pingine* · Умбиликус

Light: 🌤️ Partial to full shade; tolerates some sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining, near-neutral, gritty soil, often rooting in very little soil at all; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Minimal — this native succulent naturally colonises old stone walls, rock crevices and dry-stone boundaries. In a border, improve clay with grit; it is otherwise best established directly into a wall crevice or dry-stone gap with a little compost.

Planting depth: At pot level, or tucked into a wall crevice.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Ivy, ferns and other wall/shade plants at the base of old walls; sempervivum and saxifrage on drier wall tops.

West of Ireland: Common throughout Ireland on damp, shaded stone walls, banks and tree bases — an easy, attractive native succulent for softening an old wall or boundary; young leaves are edible in salads with a mild, slightly salty-cucumber flavour.

GROUP H: KITCHEN HERBS & VEGETABLES

HI. Catnip (*Nepeta cataria*)

Russian: Котовник кошачий

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required; over-feeding produces floppy, less aromatic growth.

Companions: Brassicas (said to deter flea beetle and cabbage moth), roses (said to deter aphids); popular with cats, which can damage young plants by rolling on them.

West of Ireland: Easy and reliable, though may need protection from cats when young (a cloche or wire cage over new plants prevents damage until established). Trim after flowering to keep compact and encourage fresh growth.

H2. Coriander (*Coriandrum sativum*)

Irish / Russian: *Lus an choir* · Кинза (кориандр посевной)

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade. Shade reduces bolting — useful in the cool west of Ireland.

Soil needs: Light, well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. Annual. Do NOT transplant — sow direct.

Planting depth: Sow direct 5mm deep. Thin to 15–20cm.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Minimal. Light balanced liquid feed once or twice during growing season. Do not overfeed — promotes fast, leafy bolting growth.

Companions: Parsley, brassicas (nearby). Do NOT grow adjacent to fennel or dill (cross-pollination ruins flavour of both if they flower together). Attracts beneficial insects.

H3. Cucumbers (*Cucumis sativus*)

Irish / Russian: Cúcamar · Огурец посевной

Light: ☀ Full sun, sheltered from wind.

Soil needs: Rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Dig in plenty of well-rotted compost/manure. Raise beds or mound slightly on heavy clay for better drainage and warmth.

Planting depth: At pot level, after all risk of frost has passed (outdoor "ridge" types) or under cover for greenhouse types.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) weekly once fruits begin to set.

Companions: Nasturtiums (trap crop for aphids), dill, sweetcorn as a windbreak.

West of Ireland: Outdoor "ridge" cucumbers cope reasonably with the cooler west of Ireland summer, though a sheltered, sunny spot or polytunnel/greenhouse gives more reliable results and a longer season than fully exposed outdoor growing.

H4. Dill (*Anethum graveolens*)

Irish / Russian: Lus mín · Укроп пахучий

Light: ☀ Full sun. Sheltered from wind (tall and floppy).

Soil needs: Moist, medium-to-well-drained, pH 5.5–7.0. Annual. Sow direct.

Planting depth: Sow direct, cover 3–5mm. Thin to 20–30cm.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Minimal. Light balanced fertiliser once during the season. Overfeeding promotes rapid bolting.

Companions: Brassicas, lettuce, cucumbers. Do NOT plant near fennel or coriander (cross-pollination). Attracts hoverflies and beneficial insects.

H17. Garden Cress (*Lepidium sativum*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade; a bright windowsill is enough for indoor sowings.

Soil needs: Any reasonably moist soil or seed compost; pH 6.0–7.5. Undemanding — grows well even in nutrient-poor conditions.

Soil prep: None needed for outdoor sowing beyond raking to a fine tilth; for indoor trays, a shallow layer of seed compost or even damp kitchen paper is enough.

Planting depth: Scatter seed on the surface or sow 1–1.5cm deep; keep evenly moist.

Spacing: Sow thickly in a broad row, tray or pot — cress is grown as a dense mat, not as individual spaced plants.

Fertiliser: None required — the whole crop is harvested within days to a few weeks, well before nutrient demand builds.

Companions: Grows well near radishes and tomatoes; being harvested so quickly, it rarely competes with anything.

West of Ireland: One of the fastest and easiest edible crops there is — ready to cut as soon as 5–7 days after sowing at a favourable temperature (around 20°C), or a little slower in a cool Irish spring or autumn. Sow little and often on a windowsill or in a pot outdoors for a continuous supply of mildly peppery salad leaves; cut with scissors just above the base and do not expect regrowth from the same sowing — resow for the next batch.

H18. Garlic (*Allium sativum*)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential.

Soil needs: Free-draining, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.0. Garlic dislikes acid soil (below pH 6.5 is often cited as a threshold) and is prone to rot in wet, poorly drained ground over winter.

Soil prep: Dig in 2 bucketfuls of well-rotted manure or garden compost per square metre before planting. On heavy clay or where winter waterlogging is likely, improve drainage with grit or start cloves off in modules under cover, planting out in spring instead of autumn.

Planting depth: Split the bulb into individual cloves just before planting, and plant flat end down, pointed tip up, with the tip about 2.5cm below the soil surface (deeper — up to 5cm — in light soil for larger bulbs; not deeper in heavy soil).

Spacing: 15cm between cloves, with rows 30cm apart.

Fertiliser: A general balanced fertiliser worked in before planting; otherwise minimal feeding needed through the season.

Companions: Roses, fruit trees and many vegetables benefit from garlic nearby, which is reputed to help deter aphids and other pests. Avoid planting near peas or beans, which dislike alliums.

West of Ireland: Garlic needs a cold spell (most varieties want 1–2 months at 0–10°C) to form separate cloves properly, so autumn planting (October–November) suits the Irish climate well — though on heavy, wet clay it is often more reliable to start cloves in modules in a cold frame over winter and plant out in early spring instead, avoiding the risk of cloves rotting in saturated ground. Harvest from early summer onwards once the leaves begin to yellow, and dry (cure) bulbs somewhere airy before storing.

H5. Green Onions (*Allium fistulosum*)

Irish / Russian: *Scailliún · Лук-батун*

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Fertile, well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost; light and free-draining is best.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, or plant sets at pot level, spring through summer for successional harvests.

Spacing: 5–8cm between plants; sow successionally

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season.

Companions: Carrots (mutually deters carrot fly and onion fly), rocket, radish — classic salad-bed companions.

West of Ireland: Fast, easy, and can be sown successionally every few weeks from spring to late summer for a continuous harvest of mild, slender salad onions.

H6. Lavender (*Lavandula angustifolia*)

Irish / Russian: *Labhandar · Лаванда узколистная*

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily.

Soil needs: Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile, neutral to alkaline soil; pH 6.5–8.0. Excellent drainage is essential — dislikes sitting in wet clay, especially over winter.

Soil prep: Mix clay generously with 30%+ horticultural grit, or plant on a raised mound/bed. A layer of grit or pebbles as surface mulch keeps the crown dry.

Planting depth: At pot level; do not bury the woody base.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less aromatic growth prone to winter damage.

Companions: Roses (classic underplanting), rosemary, thyme and other Mediterranean herbs with the same sun/drainage needs.

West of Ireland: Along with rosemary, one of the herbs most likely to struggle on wet west of Ireland clay in winter — a raised bed, gritty mound, or large terracotta container in a sheltered, sunny spot gives much better results than open ground. Trim lightly after flowering; avoid cutting into old bare wood.

H7. Lemon Balm (*Melissa officinalis*)

Irish / Russian: *Lus na meala · Мелисса лекарственная*

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants; spreads readily

Fertiliser: Little required; over-feeding produces excess soft growth.

Companions: Brassicas, tomatoes; attractive to bees when in flower.

West of Ireland: Easy, vigorous, and self-seeds/spreads readily — best in a container or a bed where its spread can be controlled, similar to mint. Fresh lemon-scented leaves are excellent for tea.

H22. Lemon Verbena (*Aloysia citrodora*)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential, in a warm, sheltered spot.

Soil needs: Free-draining, moderately fertile soil or peat-free multipurpose compost; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Grow in a container of free-draining compost rather than the open ground, to make winter protection straightforward.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: One plant per pot; if grown in open ground for summer, allow 60–90cm.

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season; stop feeding once brought under cover for winter.

Companions: Best grown alone in its own container, given its need to be moved under cover each winter.

Pot/container: ✅ Essential in this climate. Move outdoors to a warm, sheltered, sunny spot only once frost risk has passed; bring under cover — a bright, frost-free spot such as a porch, conservatory or unheated greenhouse — before the first autumn frosts, keeping it on the dry side over winter, since it is naturally deciduous and drops its leaves.

West of Ireland: A tender, deciduous, intensely lemon-scented shrub from South America, popular for herbal tea and flavouring. Borderline hardy at best (RHS H2–H3) — it will not reliably survive an Irish winter outdoors, even in the mildest coastal areas, so treat it as a container plant that summers outside and overwinters somewhere frost-free and on the dry side, since wet, cold roots are what usually kill it rather than cold air alone.

H19. Lemongrass (*Cymbopogon citratus*)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — a warm, sheltered spot outdoors in summer.

Soil needs: Moderately fertile, moist but well-drained soil or peat-free multipurpose compost; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Grow in a container of peat-free multipurpose compost rather than in the open ground — this makes it far easier to move the plant under cover for winter, which is essential in this climate.

Planting depth: At pot level, in a container slightly wider and deeper than its current pot; pot on as it grows.

Spacing: One plant per pot is typical; if grown in a larger container or bed for summer, allow 40–50cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season while outdoors; stop feeding once brought inside for winter.

Companions: Best grown alone in its own container rather than mixed with other plants, given its need to be moved indoors as a whole unit each autumn.

Pot/container: ✅ Essential, not optional, in this climate. Move outdoors to a warm, sunny, sheltered spot only once nights are reliably frost-free (typically early summer), hardening off gradually. Bring back under cover — a bright, frost-free conservatory, greenhouse or windowsill — before the first autumn frosts, keeping the compost fairly dry over winter.

West of Ireland: A tender tropical grass, native to South and Southeast Asia, that is not hardy anywhere in Ireland and needs temperatures of at least 13°C to grow well — realistically achievable outdoors here only during the warmest summer months. Treat as a container plant that spends summer outside and winter under glass, or simply as a productive annual herb grown fresh each year from a rooted stem bought at a shop or a young plant from a herb nursery. In a typical Irish summer, plants stay considerably more compact than in the tropics, but the thick, pale lower stems still develop the characteristic citrus-lemon flavour prized in South-East Asian cooking.

H8. Mint (*Mentha* spp.)

Irish / Russian: Miontas · Мята

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. More aromatic in sun; more leaves in shade.

Soil needs: Moist, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. ⚠️ **Always grow in a container or with a deep root barrier — invasive spreader.**

Planting depth: At pot level. Root barrier in ground should be 30cm deep. Container minimum 30cm diameter and depth.

Spacing: 60cm if in ground with root barrier

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly during the growing season. Cut back after flowering and feed to encourage fresh growth. Repot yearly into fresh compost.

Companions: Use pots of mint near brassicas, tomatoes, and beans as a pest deterrent (volatile oils without the invasive roots). Peppermint near roses reportedly deters aphids.

H10. Nasturtiums (*Tropaeolum majus*)

Irish / Russian: *Gleorán* · Настурция большая

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

Soil needs: Poor to moderately fertile, well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Rich soil produces excess leaves at the expense of flowers.

Soil prep: Minimal — nasturtiums thrive on poor soil; avoid heavy feeding or over-improving the ground.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1–2cm deep, direct after frost risk has passed.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

Fertiliser: None to very little required.

Companions: Already used throughout this guide as a companion plant for apples, brassicas and cucumbers — nasturtiums act as a "trap crop" drawing aphids and cabbage white butterflies away from vegetables, and the peppery leaves and flowers are edible in salads.

West of Ireland: One of the easiest, most useful companion flowers for the vegetable garden — self-seeds readily and tolerates poor, dry corners well, though it can be checked by heavy Atlantic rain in a very wet summer.

H11. Oregano / Wild Marjoram (*Origanum vulgare*)

Irish / Russian: *Máirtín fiáin* · Душица обыкновенная

Light: ☀ Full sun — open, sunny position for best aroma and flavour.

Soil needs: Well-drained, slightly alkaline preferred, pH 6.5–8.0.

Soil prep: 30–40% grit to clay/compost mix. Raised beds ideal.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Low nutrient requirements. Light balanced fertiliser in spring only. Avoid nitrogen-heavy feeds (reduces aromatic oil content). Container: monthly balanced liquid at half-strength during growing season.

Companions: Thyme, rosemary, sage. Oregano flowers attract pollinators very effectively — excellent companion for fruit trees, raspberries, and other fruiting plants.

H20. Patio Tomatoes (*Solanum lycopersicum*, compact/dwarf cultivars)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6–8 hours daily, in a warm, sheltered spot such as against a south-facing wall.

Soil needs: Fertile, moisture-retentive but free-draining compost; pH 6.0–6.8.

Soil prep: Fill a container at least 30–40cm deep and wide with a good quality peat-free multipurpose or tomato-specific compost, filled to within 2–3cm of the rim.

Planting depth: Plant deeply — bury the stem up to the lowest pair of leaves, which encourages extra roots to form along the buried stem for a stronger plant. Plant out only once nights are reliably frost-free, usually mid-May in most of Ireland.

Spacing: One plant per 30–40cm pot; in a larger trough or growbag, space compact bush varieties 30–45cm apart.

Fertiliser: Feed weekly with a proprietary liquid tomato feed (high in potash) once the first fruits begin to set; water consistently, since irregular watering causes fruit to split or blossom end rot to develop.

Companions: Basil, marigolds and chives are traditional companions, said to help deter aphids and whitefly.

Pot/container: ✅ Bred specifically for pots, hanging baskets and small patios — compact/dwarf bush varieties such as 'Tumbling Tom', 'Patio Princess' and 'Hundreds and Thousands' need no staking or pinching out, unlike tall cordon types. Water at least once daily in warm weather, since containers dry out quickly.

West of Ireland: Compact patio varieties are a far more realistic choice than tall cordon tomatoes for the cooler, shorter Irish summer — they crop reliably in a container on a sheltered, sunny patio without needing the sustained heat that larger vining types want. A warm wall or a spot under the eaves out of the worst rain helps ripen fruit and reduces the risk of blight, which thrives in cool, damp conditions.

H21. Peas (*Pisum sativum*)

Light: ☀ Full sun, though tolerates a little partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained but moisture-retentive, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig in well-rotted compost or manure the previous autumn if possible. On heavy clay, improve drainage with grit, since peas dislike sitting in waterlogged ground.

Planting depth: Sow seed 2–5cm deep, in a flat-bottomed drill about 15cm wide, with two staggered rows about 7cm apart within the drill.

Spacing: 5–7cm between seeds within the row; allow 45–60cm between double rows to allow access for picking. Dwarf varieties (to 45cm) need no support; taller climbing types (to 1.8m) need twiggy sticks or netting.

Fertiliser: Little needed — like other legumes, peas fix their own nitrogen from the air via root nodules. A general fertiliser at sowing is usually sufficient; avoid excess nitrogen, which produces lush leaves at the expense of pods.

Companions: Carrots, radishes, cucumbers and beans grow well alongside peas; avoid planting near onions, garlic or other alliums, which inhibit their growth.

West of Ireland: A reliably easy, cool-season crop well suited to the mild Irish climate — sow small batches every few weeks from early spring into early summer for a continuous harvest, and pick pods regularly to encourage more to form. Good drainage matters more than warmth here; wet, cold clay in spring is the main risk to seed rotting before germination, so consider starting seed in modules under cover if your soil is heavy and slow to warm up.

H23. Peppermint (*Mentha × piperita*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. More aromatic in sun; more leaves in shade.

Soil needs: Moist, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.0. ⚠ **Always grow in a container or with a deep root barrier — invasive spreader, like other mints.**

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost if grown with a root barrier; otherwise a container of multipurpose compost.

Planting depth: At pot level. Root barrier in ground should be 30cm deep. Container minimum 30cm diameter and depth.

Spacing: 45–60cm if grown in ground with a root barrier.

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly during the growing season. Cut back after flowering and feed to encourage fresh growth. Repot yearly into fresh compost.

Companions: Grow in pots near roses, where it is reputed to help deter aphids; near brassicas and tomatoes as a general pest deterrent.

West of Ireland: A specific, naturally occurring hybrid mint (*M. aquatica* × *M. spicata*) prized for its high menthol content and classic "mint" flavour, used for tea, cooking and traditional remedies. Grows and behaves exactly like the generic mints already in this guide — vigorous, hardy and easy in the mild Irish climate, but needs firm containment to prevent it taking over a border.

H12. Radish (*Raphanus sativus*)

Irish / Russian: *Raidis* · Редис

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☀ partial shade.

Soil needs: Light, fertile, well-drained soil, free of stones; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit for a looser, freer-draining bed — stony or heavy clay produces misshapen roots.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, direct, from spring through late summer for successional harvests.

Spacing: 2–3cm between plants; sow successionally

Fertiliser: Little required; rich soil produces excess leaf at the expense of the root.

Companions: Carrots, lettuce, green onions — classic salad-bed companions; also used as a fast "marker crop" sown alongside slower vegetables.

West of Ireland: One of the fastest vegetables to harvest (as little as 3–4 weeks), making it ideal for succession sowing every couple of weeks through the growing season.

H13. Rocket (*Eruca sativa*)

Irish / Russian: Ruachán · Руккола (гусеничник посевной, индау посевной)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade (some shade helps prevent premature bolting in summer heat).

Soil needs: Fertile, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, direct, spring through autumn for successional harvests.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; sow successionally

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed occasionally through the growing season.

Companions: Radish, green onions, lettuce — classic salad-bed companions.

West of Ireland: Fast-growing and easy; keep well watered and pick young leaves regularly to delay bolting (running to flower), which happens quickly in dry or hot spells. Sow successionally every few weeks for a continuous supply.

H14. Rosemary (*Salvia rosmarinus*, syn. *Rosmarinus officinalis*)

Irish / Russian: Marós · Розмарин лекарственный

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily. Poor, leggy growth and reduced flavour in shade.

Soil needs: Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Excellent drainage is essential — rosemary is Mediterranean in origin and will not tolerate sitting in wet clay, especially over winter.

Soil prep: Mix clay generously with 30%+ horticultural grit, or plant on a raised mound/bed. Add a layer of grit or pebbles as surface mulch to keep the crown dry.

Planting depth: At pot level; do not bury the woody base.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less aromatic growth. A light balanced feed in spring is sufficient. Container plants: occasional liquid feed through summer.

Companions: Classic companion for brassicas (deters cabbage moth), carrots and beans in the vegetable garden; also thyme, lavender and other Mediterranean herbs with the same sun/drainage needs.

West of Ireland: One of the herbs most likely to struggle on wet west of Ireland clay in winter — a raised bed, gritty mound, or a large terracotta container that can be given a sheltered spot is strongly recommended over open ground. Trim lightly after flowering to keep compact; avoid cutting into old bare wood.

H15. Scurvy Grass (*Cochlearia officinalis*)

Irish / Russian: Biolar trá · Ложечница лекарственная

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained soil, tolerant of salty/coastal conditions; pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost; naturally grows in fairly poor, gritty or rocky coastal ground, so avoid over-rich soil.

Planting depth: At pot level, or sow seed on the surface.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required.

Companions: Sea kale, other coastal/salt-tolerant edible plants if grown in a coastal garden setting.

West of Ireland: A native coastal plant of saltmarshes, cliffs and rocky shores right around the Irish coast, historically eaten by sailors for its high vitamin C content (hence the name). Leaves have a strong, peppery, mustard-like flavour, best used sparingly in salads; happiest in a sunny spot that isn't far removed from its natural coastal, slightly salty preference.

H16. Zucchini / Courgette (*Cucurbita pepo*)

Irish / Russian: Cúirséad · Кабачок (Цуккини)

Light: ☀ Full sun, sheltered from wind.

Soil needs: Rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Dig in plenty of well-rotted compost/manure into a planting hole or mound — courgettes are hungry, thirsty plants.

Planting depth: At pot level, after all risk of frost has passed.

Spacing: 60–90cm between plants

Fertiliser: High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) weekly once flowering/fruiting begins.

Companions: Nasturtiums (trap crop), sweetcorn, beans — classic "three sisters"-adjacent vegetable bed companions.

West of Ireland: Very productive in a warm, sheltered, sunny spot; keep well watered in dry spells and harvest fruit young and regularly (every 2–3 days once cropping) to keep plants producing through the season.

GROUP P: ORNAMENTAL PERENNIALS

P36. *Alstroemeria* (Peruvian Lily)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Fertile, moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit; tuberous roots dislike sitting in waterlogged ground.

Planting depth: Plant tubers 15–20cm deep, well below the frost line, since the fleshy roots resent disturbance and cold.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in spring; high-potash liquid feed through summer to prolong flowering.

Companions: Roses, geraniums, salvias — classic cottage/mixed-border companions.

West of Ireland: A long-flowering, exotic-looking herbaceous perennial with clusters of trumpet-shaped, often bicoloured flowers from early summer well into autumn if deadheaded regularly (pull rather than cut the flowering stems, to encourage more). Modern hardy hybrids (e.g. the Princess Lily/Inca series) are reliably perennial in the mild west of Ireland climate given reasonable drainage; a deep planting depth and a dry winter mulch help protect the tubers from the worst of the wet.

P37. *Aruncus aethusifolius* (Dwarf Goat's Beard)

Light: 🌤 Partial shade; tolerates full sun if the soil stays consistently moist.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Dislikes drying out.

Soil prep: Mix clay with generous compost; a woodland-edge bed suits it well.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring; annual compost mulch.

Companions: Astilbe, hostas, ferns, primroses — classic moist-shade border companions.

West of Ireland: A neat, compact, clump-forming perennial — a true dwarf relative of the much larger native Goat's Beard — with finely divided, fern-like foliage, creamy-white plumes of tiny flowers in early summer, and attractive russet autumn colour. Fully hardy and easy in the mild, moist Irish climate, and much better suited to a small garden border than its larger relative.

P1. *Astilbe* (*Astilbe* spp.)

Russian: Астильба

Light: 🌤 Partial shade to full sun if soil stays moist. Best in partial shade — avoids leaf scorch. Excellent beside ponds or in moisture-rich borders.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, clay-tolerant. pH 5.5–7.0.

Soil prep: Add generous compost. No heavy grit needed.

Planting depth: At pot level; crown at soil surface.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in spring. Generous compost or bark mulch — the most important care task. Do not let the plant dry out.

Companions: Hostas (perfect pairing), ferns, hellebores, rodgersias. Primulas in spring, astilbe in summer for successive display in the same moist bed.

P2. Auricula (*Primula auricula*)

Irish / Russian: *Lus na mbanríon* · Первоцвет ушковый

Light: 🌞 Partial shade; protect from strong midday sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining, humus-rich soil; neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay generously with grit and compost; best in a raised bed, trough or pot given its need for sharp drainage.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; do not bury.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season, stopping in winter.

Companions: Other alpine/trough plants such as saxifrage and sempervivum; traditionally displayed in individual pots on a shelf ("auricula theatre").

West of Ireland: Alpine primula relative, best grown in pots or a raised trough rather than open clay, since winter wet is the main threat. Divide congested clumps every 2–3 years after flowering.

P5. Bellflowers (Border) (*Campanula* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Clustered Bellflower	<i>C. glomerata</i>	30–60cm	Summer	Crown at soil level	Dense clusters of violet-purple, upward-facing bells; spreads by rhizomes into good-sized clumps
Spreading Bellflower	<i>C. patula</i>	30–60cm	Summer	Crown at soil level, or surface-sown seed	Open, star-shaped violet-blue bells on branching stems; biennial/short-lived native wildflower
Peach-leaved Bellflower	<i>C. persicifolia</i>	60cm–1m	June–July	Crown at soil level	Tall, elegant spires of large cup-shaped lilac-blue or white bells; a classic cottage-garden perennial

Light: 🌞 Full sun to 🌞 partial shade for all three.

Soil needs: *C. glomerata*: most well-drained soils including clay, preferring neutral to alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5. *C. patula*: well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.5. *C. persicifolia*: moist but well-drained, fertile soil.

Soil prep: *C. glomerata*: mix clay 50/50 with compost. *C. patula*: mix clay with compost and grit. *C. persicifolia*: mix clay 50/50 with compost, ensuring reasonable moisture retention alongside drainage.

Planting depth: *C. glomerata* and *C. persicifolia*: crown at soil level. *C. patula*: crown at soil level, or sow seed on the surface in late spring/summer.

Spacing: *C. glomerata*: 30–40cm between plants, divide every 3–4 years. *C. patula*: 20–30cm between plants; biennial/short-lived. *C. persicifolia*: 30–45cm between plants; divide every 2–4 years.

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring for all three; *C. glomerata* also benefits from an annual compost mulch.

Companions: *C. glomerata*: roses, peonies, ornamental grasses — sunny cottage-border companions. *C. patula*: ox-eye daisy, wild grasses, other cottage/meadow-style companions. *C. persicifolia*: delphiniums, roses, lupins — classic tall cottage-border companions; excellent as a cut flower.

West of Ireland: *C. glomerata* spreads by rhizomes to form good-sized clumps — divide every 3–4 years to keep vigorous and control spread in smaller borders. *C. patula* is a biennial or short-lived perennial native British/Irish wildflower, distinct from the more vigorously spreading (and often invasive in gardens) *Campanula rapunculoides* — self-seeds gently; deadhead if self-seeding is not wanted. *C. persicifolia* is a widely grown cottage-garden classic that self-seeds readily in the right conditions and performs well in the cool, moist Irish climate; deadhead to prolong flowering.

P4. Blue Gentian (*Gentiana* spp., e.g. *G. acaulis*, *G. sino-ornata*)

Russian: Горечавка

Light: 🌞 Full sun to 🌞 partial shade, depending on species.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; most garden gentians prefer slightly acid conditions, pH 5.5–6.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost and grit; a raised bed or rockery suits most species well.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced or ericaceous feed in spring. Annual mulch with compost or leaf mould.

Companions: Heather, dwarf conifers, saxifrage — classic rockery/alpine-bed companions.

West of Ireland: Intensely blue, trumpet-shaped autumn or spring flowers (depending on species) make this a rockery highlight. The moist, mild west of Ireland climate suits autumn-flowering Asiatic gentians (*G. sino-ornata* type) particularly well, given reasonably acid soil.

P39. Chilean Avens (*Geum chilense*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost; good drainage matters, but the soil should not dry out either.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Balanced feed in spring; deadhead regularly to prolong flowering.

Companions: Alliums, irises, roses, hardy geraniums — classic sunny border companions.

West of Ireland: A cheerful, clump-forming perennial with semi-evergreen foliage and wiry stems of vivid red, orange or yellow single or double flowers held well above the leaves from late spring through summer. Popular cultivars include 'Mrs J. Bradshaw' (scarlet-red) and 'Lady Stratheden' (golden-yellow). Fully hardy and easy in the mild, moist Irish climate; divide congested clumps every 2–3 years to maintain vigour.

P6. Columbine (*Aquilegia vulgaris* and hybrids)

Irish / Russian: Colaimbín · Водосбор обыкновенный (аквилегия)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of clay if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants; self-seeds freely

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Foxgloves, hardy geraniums, roses — classic cottage-garden border companions; self-seeds readily among other perennials.

West of Ireland: Easy, reliable, and self-seeds freely — often needs thinning rather than encouraging once established. Distinctive spurred flowers in a wide range of colours through late spring/early summer.

P7. Coral Bells (*Heuchera* spp.)

Russian: Гейхера

Light: 🌤 Partial shade preferred; purple/dark-leaved varieties tolerate more sun, green/lime varieties prefer more shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained soil, rich in organic matter; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage — *Heuchera* dislikes waterlogging, especially in winter.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level — do not bury the crown, which can cause rot.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season. Light annual mulch with compost, keeping it away from the crown.

Companions: Hostas, astilbe, ferns, hellebores — classic shade/part-shade border and edging companions; excellent foliage contrast plant.

West of Ireland: Reliable, low-maintenance evergreen/semi-evergreen foliage perennial. Divide congested clumps every 3 years in spring or autumn to keep vigorous.

P8. Cutleaf Coneflower 'Goldball' (*Rudbeckia laciniata* 'Goldball')

Russian: Рудбекия рассечённая

Light: ☀ Full sun preferred. Will flower in light shade, but the shadier the location the less they will flower.

Soil needs: A good choice for improved clay soils — easy to grow if given full sun or partial shade and a moderately fertile soil that is moist but well-drained. pH 5.5–7.0. Moisture-retentive soil is important — dislikes prolonged dry periods in summer.

Soil prep: Add generous compost to clay (50/50). If the soil is very heavy or is not free draining, add lots of well-rotted compost to the area and dig it in well.

Planting depth: At pot level. Plant bare-root crowns with buds 2–3cm below soil.

Spacing: 60–90cm between; divide every 2–3 yrs

Fertiliser: Rudbeckia needs little or no regular applications of fertiliser in most garden soils. Mulching plants in borders with well-rotted manure or garden compost each spring should be sufficient. Certainly do not feed with nitrogen-rich fertilisers — this will only encourage leaf growth at the expense of flowers.

Special note on R. laciniata: *R. laciniata* has vigorous rhizomes (horizontal underground stems) that make it better suited to larger gardens. It might need lifting, dividing and reducing every two to three years to keep it in check. *R. laciniata* can reach 3m (10ft). This tall variety is inclined to flop, so pinch out the shoots in early summer to promote strong and bushy growth, or provide support.

Companions: Helenium, echinacea, late-flowering salvias, ornamental grasses, asters for a dramatic late-summer/autumn border. Excellent with purple-flowered plants (veronicastrum, verbena bonariensis). The tall flowers of 'Goldball' are stunning in naturalistic or prairie-style planting schemes.

Pot size: For containers, use a liquid fertiliser such as Phostrogen or seaweed feed. Minimum 40–50cm diameter; deep container needed given eventual 2–3m height. ⚠ Better in-ground given ultimate vigour.

West of Ireland: Rudbeckia does very well in the moist, cool-summer Irish climate. Does not suffer from drought issues. Excellent for late summer colour when many plants are declining. Divide regularly to prevent uncontrolled spread.

P9. Daylilies (*Hemerocallis* spp.)

Russian: Лилейник

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌂 partial shade.

Soil needs: Most soils including clay, tolerant of a wide pH range 6.0–7.5. One of the easiest, most clay-tolerant border perennials.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost; grit optional, since daylilies are notably tolerant of heavy soil.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level, roots spread out in the hole.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs

Fertiliser: Balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Roses, ornamental grasses, achillea (yarrow) — classic sunny border companions.

West of Ireland: Extremely tough, reliable, and genuinely clay-tolerant — one of the best "no-fuss" flowering perennials for west of Ireland gardens. Each flower lasts only a day, but a well-established clump produces a long succession of blooms through summer. Divide every 3–4 years to rejuvenate.

Pro. Delphiniums (*Delphinium* spp.)

Russian: Живокость (дельфиниум)

Light: ☀ Full sun — 6+ hours. Wind shelter equally essential.

Soil needs: Rich, fertile, well-drained, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig 40–50cm deep; generous compost and 20% grit on heavy clay.

Planting depth: At pot level; bare-root buds 2–5cm below soil.

Spacing: 60–90cm between plants; stake essential

Fertiliser: Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) fortnightly from bud formation through flowering. After first flush: cut stems, apply balanced liquid feed to encourage second flush. Annual well-rotted manure mulch.

Companions: Roses, lupins, peonies, alliums, irises in cottage-garden combination. Staking mandatory. Slug protection critical in the wet west.

P11. Edelweiss (*Leontopodium alpinum*)

Russian: Эдельвейс альпийский

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile, alkaline soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Excellent drainage essential.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 30–40% grit; best in a raised bed, trough or rockery.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less characterful growth.

Companions: Sempervivum, saxifrage, other alpine rockery plants with the same sharp-drainage needs.

West of Ireland: A true alpine, and one of the more challenging plants on wet west of Ireland clay — reliable success generally needs a raised, gritty, free-draining bed or trough rather than open ground. Silvery-white star-shaped flower bracts in summer.

P12. Elephant's Ears (*Bergenia* spp.)

Russian: Бадан

Light: 🌑 Full shade to ☀ full sun. Leaves colour best in open, exposed positions.

Soil needs: Humus-rich, moist but well-drained. Excellent on clay.

Soil prep: Add compost. Unfussy.

Planting depth: At pot level; rhizome just at or slightly below surface.

Spacing: 30–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Low-maintenance. Balanced slow-release in spring, or just annual bark mulch. Do not overfeed.

Companions: Hostas, hellebores, snowdrops, pulmonaria, ferns. Bold evergreen foliage contrasts beautifully with delicate fern texture.

P13. Fern-leaf Peony (*Paeonia tenuifolia*)

Irish / Russian: Píaine · Пион узколистный

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile soil, neutral to slightly alkaline; pH 6.5–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging, more so than common garden peonies.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost and 20–30% grit for extra drainage.

Planting depth: Crown/eyes no more than 2–3cm below soil level — as with all peonies, planting too deep prevents flowering.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in spring; light high-potash feed as buds form.

Companions: Alliums, bearded iris, catmint — classic sunny border companions with similar drainage needs.

West of Ireland: A smaller, earlier-flowering species peony with finely divided, fern-like foliage and deep red single flowers — distinct from the common garden peonies (*Paeonia* spp.) already in this guide. More particular about drainage than common peonies, so a raised or well-drained spot gives the best results on Irish clay.

P14. Foxgloves (*Digitalis purpurea* and perennial species)

Irish / Russian: Lus mór · Наперстянка пурпурная

Light: 🌤 Partial shade to full sun if soil stays moist.

Soil needs: Nutrient-rich, moist, pH 5.5–7.5. Native to Ireland.

Soil prep: Add compost. Very adaptable. Self-seeding.

Planting depth: At pot level; seeds sown on surface (need light to germinate).

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Low-maintenance — rarely needs feeding. Light balanced fertiliser in spring for vigorous second-year plants. Bark mulch to retain moisture.

Companions: Ferns, astilbe, hostas in shaded beds. With roses, alliums, and delphiniums in sunnier borders. Superb companion as they attract bumblebees very effectively.

Pr5. Globeflower (*Trollius europaeus* / *T. x cultorum*)

Russian: Купальница европейская

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌂 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist to wet, humus-rich soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Unusually for a border perennial, thrives in damp ground and tolerates heavy clay very well.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost; no need for extra drainage — this plant prefers consistently moist soil.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch, keeping the crown moist.

Companions: Astilbe, hosta, candelabra primulas — classic damp border or pond-margin companions.

West of Ireland: One of the few showy border perennials genuinely suited to the wetter parts of a west of Ireland garden — round, globe-like yellow or orange flowers on upright stems in late spring. Excellent for a damp border or the margin of a pond garden.

Pr6. Hellebore (*Helleborus* spp.)

Russian: Морозник

Light: 🌂 to 🌑 Partial to full shade. Ideal under deciduous trees or shrubs. Avoid full sun which scorches leaves.

Soil needs: Humus-rich, fertile, moisture-retentive, pH 6.0–8.0. Excellent on clay.

Soil prep: Add generous compost. Annual compost or leaf mould mulch.

Planting depth: At pot level; crown just at or slightly below soil surface.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release in early spring after clearing old foliage. Annual compost mulch after flowering — most effective treatment. Takes 2–3 years to settle after planting; do not disturb once established.

Companions: Snowdrops (January–March together — one of the great winter garden combinations). Cyclamen coum, pulmonaria, early daffodils. Hostas and ferns alongside in summer.

P3. Irises (*Iris* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Bearded Iris (Border Iris)	<i>I. germanica</i>	60–90cm	Early summer (May–June)	Rhizome at/just proud of soil surface, top exposed to sun	Classic sunny-border iris; needs sharp drainage, rots in wet clay
Japanese Water Iris 'Dinner Plate Cupcake'	<i>I. ensata</i> 'Dinner Plate Cupcake'	50–90cm	Early–midsummer (June–July)	Rhizome at soil level; moist to shallow-wet soil	Huge (to 15cm across) white flowers with purple and yellow accents; needs consistently moist to wet, acidic soil — the opposite of Bearded Iris
Siberian Iris	<i>I. sibirica</i>	60–100cm	May–June	Rhizome at soil level or 2–3cm below	Thrives in moist, heavy clay and tolerates boggy ground, unlike Bearded Iris
Yellow Flag Iris	<i>I. pseudacorus</i>	90cm–1.5m	May–July	Crown at soil level; 0–20cm water above	Native pond-margin iris; tolerates standing water; spreads vigorously

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for Bearded Iris — at least 6 hours daily for good flowering. Siberian Iris flowers most freely in full sun but tolerates dappled shade. Yellow Flag Iris and *I. ensata* 'Dinner Plate Cupcake' flower best in full sun but tolerate light/partial shade.

Soil needs: The three species have almost opposite soil preferences, so choose the right one for your site. Bearded Iris: free-draining, neutral to slightly alkaline soil, pH 6.5–7.5 — rhizomes rot in wet, poorly-drained clay, which is the single biggest cause of failure. Siberian Iris: moist, fertile, neutral to slightly acidic soil, pH 5.8–7.0 — the RHS confirms Siberian irises "do well in heavy clay soil" and prefer consistently moist conditions, tolerating slightly boggy ground near ponds or streams. Yellow Flag Iris: moist to wet rich soil; pond margin/ bog zone with 0–20cm of water over the soil surface, or reliably damp ground. *I. ensata* 'Dinner Plate Cupcake': consistently moist to shallow-wet, distinctly acidic soil, pH 5.5–6.5 — unlike the others, it dislikes lime and will not tolerate drying out even briefly; a pond-margin or bog-garden position suits it as well as Yellow Flag Iris.

Soil prep: Bearded Iris: improve clay generously with 30% horticultural grit; raised beds or mounded planting strongly recommended on heavy soil. Siberian Iris: dig in generous compost (50/50 with clay) — no need for heavy grit, since this species actually prefers moisture-retentive conditions; mulch each autumn with bark or compost to retain moisture and protect the rhizome crowns. Yellow Flag Iris: plant in an aquatic basket with aquatic compost at the pond margin, or directly into boggy clay. *I. ensata* 'Dinner Plate Cupcake': dig in generous ericaceous compost or leafmould to acidify and moisture-retain the soil; never lime the ground.

Planting depth: Bearded Iris: rhizome at or just proud of the soil surface, top exposed to sun — do not bury, unlike most other rhizomes. Siberian Iris: at soil level or just 2–3cm below, planted in spring or early autumn. Yellow Flag Iris: crown at soil level, with the basket set so water sits 0–20cm above the soil surface (can grow in up to 25–30cm depth); basket size 19–24cm diameter, or plant directly into boggy clay at pond margins. *I. ensata* 'Dinner Plate Cupcake': rhizome at soil level in consistently moist to shallow-wet ground.

Spacing: Bearded Iris: 30–45cm between rhizomes, divide every 3–4 years. Siberian Iris: 30–45cm between plants; clumps spread slowly outward over years, divide every 3–5 years. Yellow Flag Iris: 30–60cm between plants; very vigorous, divide every 2–3 years. *I. ensata* 'Dinner Plate Cupcake': 30–40cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Bearded Iris: low-nitrogen, high-potash feed (e.g. tomato feed) in spring and again after flowering — avoid manure or high-nitrogen feeds, which encourage rot. Siberian Iris: a single balanced fertiliser (e.g. Growmore) application in early spring is usually sufficient; avoid high-nitrogen feeds, which promote leafy growth at the expense of flowers, and do not feed in late summer or autumn. Yellow Flag Iris: aquatic fertiliser tablets pushed into the basket compost at the start of the growing season. *I. ensata* 'Dinner Plate Cupcake': low-nitrogen, ericaceous or acid-loving plant fertiliser in spring — avoid lime-containing feeds.

Companions: Bearded Iris: roses, peonies, alliums — classic sunny border companions with similar sun and drainage needs. Siberian Iris: excellent at pond edges alongside Yellow Flag Iris, bogbean and meadowsweet; in borders, works beautifully with astilbe, hostas, daylilies, primulas and ornamental grasses, and pairs well with native royal fern for a classic Atlantic garden look; alliums flower slightly earlier and make a good succession companion. Yellow Flag Iris: white water lily, bogbean, bog pimpernel, meadowsweet, royal fern at pond/boggy margins — dense clumps give refuge for amphibians and emergent support for dragonflies.

Pot/container: Siberian Iris: ☒ possible in a 35–40cm diameter / 15–20L container, using multipurpose compost with extra moisture retention (vermiculite rather than grit); keep consistently moist. Bearded and Yellow Flag Iris are not well suited to pots — Bearded needs a wide, shallow container with excellent drainage if attempted; Yellow Flag needs a pond or large water feature.

Warnings: ⚠ Yellow Flag Iris and *I. ensata* sap can cause skin irritation — wear gloves when handling. It also spreads vigorously by rhizomes and seed and can overtake native plants in wet sites — keep it in an aquatic basket to control spread in smaller ponds.

West of Ireland: Between them, these three cover almost every garden situation. Bearded Iris needs a raised, gritty, south-facing bed to do well on west of Ireland clay, and congested clumps should be divided every 3–4 years, discarding the older woody centre and replanting healthy young rhizomes. Siberian Iris, by contrast, is an outstanding choice for the region — unlike Bearded Iris it actively thrives in the moist, heavy soil typical of the Atlantic coast, is fully hardy to -20°C, and flowers May–June in blue, purple, violet or white

depending on cultivar (good choices: 'Caesar's Brother', 'White Swirl', 'Flight of Butterflies'). Yellow Flag Iris is a native Irish plant found wild in fens, marshes and river margins throughout the country, and is one of the most reliable and beautiful marginal pond plants for Irish conditions. *I. ensata* 'Dinner Plate Cupcake' brings enormous, exhibition-quality blooms to a pond margin or bog garden — but only where the soil is reliably acidic and constantly moist; on neutral or alkaline west of Ireland clay it needs a dedicated ericaceous bog bed or large container to thrive.

P18. Lady's Bedstraw (*Galium verum*)

Irish / Russian: *Bolach cnis* · Подмаренник настоящий

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry conditions; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Minimal — this native wildflower thrives on lean soil; excess compost/fertility encourages weak, floppy growth.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: None required — over-feeding is counterproductive for this meadow wildflower.

Companions: Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wild grasses — classic dry meadow/wildflower planting.

West of Ireland: A native wildflower with masses of tiny, honey-scented yellow flowers in summer, traditionally used to stuff mattresses (hence the name) and once used to curdle milk in cheesemaking. Best suited to a wildflower meadow area or dry, sunny bank rather than a fertile border.

P19. Lilyleaf Ladybells (*Adenophora liliifolia*)

Russian: Бубенчик лилиелистный (колокольчик лилиелистный)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌫 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; resents root disturbance once established (like many bellflower relatives, it has a fleshy taproot), so choose the final position with care.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Other cottage-border perennials such as clustered bellflower, delphiniums, phlox.

West of Ireland: A relative of the campanulas, with nodding, pale blue-violet bell flowers on upright stems in summer. Less commonly available than campanulas but similarly easy once settled — best left undisturbed once planted.

P41. Limonium (Sea Lavender)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil, tolerant of poor, sandy or stony ground; pH 6.0–8.0. Naturally a coastal and salt-marsh plant, so genuinely salt-tolerant.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 25–30% horticultural grit; a raised bed or gravel garden suits it well.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; resents root disturbance once established, so choose the final position carefully.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Little needed — thrives on lean, poor soil; over-feeding produces lax growth.

Companions: Ornamental grasses, achillea, sedum — classic gravel-garden and coastal-planting companions; airy sprays are excellent for cutting and drying.

West of Ireland: A tough, drought- and salt-tolerant perennial with sprays of small, papery lavender-blue (occasionally pink or white) flowers held above a rosette of leathery leaves from summer into autumn. Genuinely useful for an exposed coastal west of Ireland garden, where its natural salt tolerance is a real asset — not to be confused with Siberian Statice (*Goniolimon tataricum*), already in this guide, which is a related but distinct genus with a similar airy, dried-flower habit.

P20. Lungworts (*Pulmonaria* spp.)

Russian: Медуница

Light: ☁ Partial to full shade.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Hellebores, ferns, hostas — classic early-spring woodland/shade border planting; one of the earliest nectar sources for bees.

West of Ireland: Reliable, easy, semi-evergreen shade perennial with attractively spotted leaves and pink-to-blue spring flowers (often both colours on the same plant). Spreads gently to form good groundcover under trees and shrubs; divide every 3–4 years.

P21. Lupins (*Lupinus polyphyllus* and hybrids)

Russian: Люпин многолистный

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, slightly acid soil; pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes shallow chalk.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost; avoid excess lime.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; resents root disturbance, so choose the final position with care.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring — like other legumes, lupins fix some of their own nitrogen, so avoid overfeeding.

Companions: Delphiniums, roses, foxgloves — classic tall cottage-border companions.

West of Ireland: Tall, showy flower spikes in early-mid summer in a wide colour range. Slug damage to young shoots is the main challenge on damp Irish clay — protect emerging growth in spring. Cut back after flowering to encourage a possible second, smaller flush.

P22. Monkshood (*Aconitum napellus*)

Russian: Борец клубучковый (аконит)

Light: ☁ Partial shade to full sun; prefers cooler root conditions.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants; ⚠ toxic, wear gloves

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Delphiniums, hostas, astilbe — classic cottage/damp border companions.

West of Ireland: Reliable, long-lived tall spikes of deep blue-purple hooded flowers in late summer.

⚠ All parts are highly toxic if ingested, and sap can irritate skin on contact — wear gloves when handling, and site away from children's play areas and vegetable beds.

P35. Ornamental Grasses (various genera)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Blue Fescue	<i>Festuca glauca</i>	20–30cm	Summer	At pot level	Compact, evergreen, steely-blue needle-like foliage; excellent for rockeries, edging and containers
Dwarf Fountain Grass	<i>Pennisetum alopecuroides</i> 'Hameln'	50–60cm	Late summer–autumn	At pot level	Soft, bottlebrush-like flower spikes; deciduous; a compact form of Chinese fountain grass
Feather Reed Grass	<i>Calamagrostis</i> × <i>acutiflora</i> 'Karl Foerster'	1.2–1.5m	Early–midsummer	At pot level	Strictly upright, non-flopping habit; excellent architectural structure; one of the earliest grasses to flower
Japanese Forest Grass	<i>Hakonechloa macra</i>	30–40cm	Late summer	At pot level	Arching, bright green (or gold in 'Aureola') foliage; one of the few grasses that thrives in part shade
Mexican Feather Grass	<i>Nassella tenuissima</i> (syn. <i>Stipa tenuissima</i>)	40–60cm	Summer	At pot level	Fine, hair-like evergreen foliage in constant motion in the slightest breeze; self-seeds readily
Evergold Sedge	<i>Carex oshimensis</i> 'Evergold'	25–35cm	Insignificant	At pot level	Evergreen, cream-and-green striped foliage; tolerates damper soil and part shade better than the others
Japanese Blood Grass	<i>Imperata cylindrica</i> 'Red Baron'	40–60cm	Insignificant	At pot level	Upright blades, green at the base flushing brilliant blood-red at the tips, deepening through summer into autumn; slowly spreading rather than clump-forming
Pampas Grass	<i>Cortaderia selloana</i>	2–3m	Late summer–autumn	At pot level	Much larger and more architectural than the others in this table — a huge fountain of arching, razor-edged foliage topped by tall, feathery, silvery-white plumes; suits only a large garden with space to spare; ⚠️ sharp, saw-toothed leaf edges, wear gloves

Light: ☀️ Full sun for Blue Fescue, Dwarf Fountain Grass, Feather Reed Grass, Mexican Feather Grass and Japanese Blood Grass — flowering, upright habit and red colouring all suffer in shade. Pampas Grass also needs full sun. Japanese Forest Grass and Evergold Sedge are the exceptions, both doing well in partial shade.

Soil needs: Most prefer light, moist but free-draining, moderately fertile soil, pH 6.0–7.5. Evergold Sedge and Japanese Forest Grass are more tolerant of consistently moist, even slightly heavier soil than the others, which need sharper drainage, especially over winter.

Soil prep: For Blue Fescue, Feather Reed Grass, Mexican Feather Grass and Japanese Blood Grass on clay: improve with 25–30% horticultural grit, since good winter drainage is essential to prevent rot at the crown. For Japanese Forest Grass and Evergold Sedge: mix clay with compost, without the need for heavy grit. Dwarf Fountain Grass sits between the two, appreciating reasonable drainage but not as fussy as the true drought-tolerant grasses.

Planting depth: At pot level for all eight, planted at the same depth as in the nursery pot.

Spacing: Blue Fescue and Evergold Sedge: 25–35cm between plants. Japanese Forest Grass, Mexican Feather Grass and Japanese Blood Grass: 30–45cm. Dwarf Fountain Grass: 45–50cm. Feather Reed Grass: 45–60cm, given its height. Pampas Grass: 2–3m — in a different league entirely, this is a genuinely large, architectural grass, not suited to a small border.

Fertiliser: Very little needed for most — over-feeding produces lax, floppy growth, especially in Blue Fescue and Mexican Feather Grass. A light spring mulch of garden compost is usually sufficient. Feather Reed Grass and Dwarf Fountain Grass benefit from an occasional balanced feed in spring for the best flowering display.

Companions: The seven smaller grasses combine beautifully with late-summer perennials such as sedum, echinacea and rudbeckia, and with spring bulbs planted through the clumps for earlier interest. Evergold Sedge and Japanese Forest Grass pair especially well with hostas, ferns and other shade-loving foliage plants. Japanese Blood Grass looks especially dramatic backlit by low sun, or planted with dark-leaved companions such as Black Mondo Grass. Pampas Grass is best given its own space as a solo specimen rather than crowded by other planting, given its ultimate size.

Pruning: Cut deciduous types (Dwarf Fountain Grass, Feather Reed Grass, Japanese Blood Grass) back hard to a few centimetres above the ground in late winter, before new growth starts. Evergreen types (Blue Fescue, Mexican Feather Grass, Japanese Forest Grass, Evergold Sedge) just need old or damaged foliage combed out or lightly trimmed in spring — do not cut hard back. Pampas Grass: cut back hard in late winter/early spring to remove old foliage before new growth starts — always wear thick gloves and long sleeves, since the leaf edges are sharp enough to cut skin.

West of Ireland: For a small west of Ireland garden, Blue Fescue, Evergold Sedge and Mexican Feather Grass are the best-behaved and most compact choices — all clump-forming rather than running, so they stay well mannered in a small border or container. Japanese Forest Grass is an excellent choice for a shadier corner where few other grasses would thrive, while Feather Reed Grass gives valuable upright structure and winter interest (its dried flower spikes persist attractively) without becoming floppy in the region's wind and rain. The

mild, moist Atlantic climate generally suits ornamental grasses well, though the free-draining species (Blue Fescue, Mexican Feather Grass, Feather Reed Grass) are more prone to winter rot on heavy clay than the moisture-tolerant Evergold Sedge and Japanese Forest Grass. Pampas Grass is reliably hardy and tolerant of coastal wind here too, but its sheer eventual size (2–3m tall and wide) makes it suitable only for a large garden with space to spare — the odd one out in this table, included for comparison rather than as a small-garden recommendation.

P23. Pasqueflower (*Pulsatilla vulgaris*)

Russian: Прострел обыкновенный

Light: ☀ Full sun — essential. Hates shade.

Soil needs: Excellent drainage, pH 6.5–8.0. Hates wet clay. Raised bed or pot essential.

Soil prep: 40–50% grit/compost mix in raised bed or container.

Planting depth: At pot level. Do not disturb once established.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Virtually no feeding needed. Adapted to lean limestone soils. Nitrogen causes floppy, non-flowering growth. Grit mulch on the surface is more beneficial than any fertiliser.

Companions: Eryngium, Dianthus, Scabiosa, Achillea, ornamental grasses in a gravel garden. Thyme and other rock garden plants nearby.

P24. Peonies (*Paeonia* spp.)

Russian: Пион

Light: ☀ to 🌤 Full sun to partial shade. At least 4–6 hours for good flowering.

Spacing: 90cm between plants

Soil needs: Free-draining, fertile, pH 6.5–7.0.

Planting depth (herbaceous): ⚠ Eyes MAX 2.5–5cm below soil. Too deep = no flowers. The most commonly made planting mistake.

Planting depth (tree peony): Graft union 10–15cm below surface.

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in early spring as red shoots emerge. High-potash feed (tomato feed) as buds develop. Annual well-rotted compost mulch, keeping mulch away from crown.

Companions: Alliums (flower as peonies fade — elegant combination). Salvia, irises, delphiniums in mixed border. Roses, foxgloves, geraniums. Avoid planting near taller shade-casting plants.

P25. Perennial Flax (*Linum perenne*)

Russian: Лён многолетний

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry conditions; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes winter wet.

Soil prep: Improve clay with grit for drainage.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring; avoid rich soil, which shortens the plant's lifespan.

Companions: Achillea (yarrow), lavender, other sun-loving, drought-tolerant border perennials.

West of Ireland: Delicate, sky-blue flowers open fresh each morning through summer on airy, wiry stems. Can be short-lived, especially where drainage is poor — a raised or gritty spot extends its life considerably on Irish clay.

P26. Pheasant's Eye (*Adonis vernalis* / *A. amurensis*)

Russian: Адонис весенний

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade (some afternoon shade in summer, when the plant is dormant, is fine).

Soil needs: Well-drained, humus-rich soil; neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit for good drainage.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; ⚠️ toxic

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Snowdrops, hellebores and other very early spring flowers; goes dormant by summer, so pair with later perennials to fill the gap.

West of Ireland: One of the earliest perennials to flower, with bright yellow, buttercup-like blooms often appearing in late winter. Slow to establish and resents disturbance, so choose its position carefully and leave undisturbed once planted.

⚠️ All parts are toxic if ingested.

P27. Pinks & Sweet Williams (*Dianthus* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Sweet William	<i>D. barbatus</i>	30–60cm	Early summer	At pot level; sow June–July (biennial)	Classic biennial cottage-garden pink with dense flat flowerheads; self-sows readily
Carnation (Border Carnation)	<i>D. caryophyllus</i>	45–60cm	Summer (June–August)	At pot level	Clove-scented double flowers on a woody-based perennial; tolerates maritime exposure and salt-laden air
Chinese Pink	<i>D. chinensis</i>	15–30cm	Summer	At pot level, or sow 3mm deep in spring	Usually grown as an annual or short-lived biennial bedding plant rather than a long-term perennial
Maiden Pink	<i>D. deltoides</i>	15–20cm	Late spring–summer	At pot level	Low, mat-forming groundcover species; RHS AGM; good for rockeries and path edges
Garden Pink	<i>D. plumarius</i>	25–35cm	Early–midsummer	At pot level	The classic perennial cottage-garden pink; many named cultivars (e.g. 'Doris', 'Mrs Sinkins')

Light: ☀️ Full sun for all — at least 6 hours daily. Sweet William tolerates partial shade.

Soil needs: All prefer neutral to slightly alkaline, well-drained soil, pH roughly 5.8–7.5 depending on species, and dislike waterlogged clay. Good air circulation helps avoid root rot and fungal disease. Carnation is unusually tolerant of salt-laden coastal air.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and 20–30% horticultural grit for all species — good drainage matters more than exact pH.

Planting depth: All at pot level, planted at the same depth as in the nursery pot. Sweet William: sow June–July as a biennial to flower the following year. Chinese Pink: can also be surface-sown (3mm deep) direct in spring. See table above for spacing guidance per species.

Spacing: Sweet William and Carnation: 30–35cm and 45–60cm between plants respectively. Chinese Pink: 15–20cm. Maiden Pink: low groundcover, plant 20–30cm apart. Garden Pink: 25–35cm.

Fertiliser: Routine feeding is not required for any of them. A well-balanced feed in early spring promotes new growth and flowering; perennial types (Carnation, Garden Pink, Maiden Pink) can also be fed once in late spring with an organic fertiliser such as comfrey or chicken pellets. Container-grown plants of any species benefit from a fortnightly liquid feed while in flower.

Companions: Roses, stocks, alliums, lavender, thyme and campanula in a well-drained sunny border; foxgloves, forget-me-nots, wallflowers and pansies alongside Sweet William in particular. Other annual bedding such as cornflower and love-in-a-mist suit Chinese Pink in a cottage-style summer border. Maiden Pink and Garden Pink both combine well with Phlox subulata, Iberis sempervirens and sempervivum at the front of a rockery.

West of Ireland: The perennial and biennial types (Carnation, Garden Pink, Sweet William) find the region's wet winters the main challenge — a raised bed with gritty soil or a sheltered, south-facing spot gives the best results, and Sweet William in particular benefits from the mild winters, though it is still best treated as a biennial with fresh seed sown each year. Chinese Pink is best treated as an annual, replanted fresh each year for reliable colour. Maiden Pink is the easiest of the five, forming a trouble-free low mat once given sharp drainage.

P28. Siberian Statice (*Goniolimon tataricum*)

Russian: Кермек татарский

Light: ☀️ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes winter wet.

Soil prep: Improve clay with grit for good drainage.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; deep taproot, so choose the final position with care.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring; avoid rich soil.

Companions: Ornamental grasses, achillea, sedum — classic gravel-garden or dried-flower border companions.

West of Ireland: Airy sprays of small white/papery flowers held well above a basal rosette, popular for drying. Best given a raised, gritty, well-drained spot given the west of Ireland's high rainfall, as it is more prone to winter losses on flat wet clay than many border perennials.

P42. Society Garlic (*Tulbaghia violacea*)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential.

Soil needs: Free-draining, moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 25–30% horticultural grit; a raised bed or large container gives the most reliable results on Irish clay.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 25–30cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season.

Companions: Lavender, rosemary and other sun-loving, well-drained border companions; said to help deter aphids nearby, like other alliums.

Pot/container: ✅ Grows very well in a container, which also makes winter protection straightforward.

West of Ireland: An evergreen, clump-forming, garlic-scented perennial from South Africa with grey-green strappy leaves and clusters of star-shaped lilac flowers held on tall stems through summer into autumn. Borderline hardy (RHS H3, roughly to -5°C) — reliable outdoors only in the mildest, most sheltered coastal west of Ireland gardens; elsewhere, best grown in a container that can be moved to a frost-free spot for winter, or given a thick dry mulch if left in the ground.

P30. Stocks (*Matthiola incana* / *M. longipetala*)

Russian: Левкой седой

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Best fragrance in the evening in a sheltered spot.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.5–7.5. Slightly alkaline preferred.

Soil prep: Compost and 20% grit.

Planting depth: At pot level; seeds surface-sown.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser at planting. Liquid tomato feed fortnightly once buds appear. Moderate feeder — do not overfeed with nitrogen.

Companions: Wallflowers, sweet William, pansies. Place near seating areas or windows for exceptional evening fragrance.

P32. Toadflax (*Linaria vulgaris*)

Russian: Лянянка обыкновенная

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☀ partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Minimal — this native wildflower is unfussy; avoid over-rich soil, which encourages excess soft growth and spread.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level, or sow seed on the surface.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; spreads readily

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, other native wildflower meadow companions.

West of Ireland: A native wildflower with snapdragon-like yellow and orange flowers on upright spikes through summer, valuable for bees. Spreads by rhizomes and self-seeds readily, so best suited to a wildflower area or informal bank rather than a tidy border, where it can be to be kept in check.

P33. Vervain (*Verbena officinalis*)

Russian: Вербена жёсткая

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor, dry conditions once established.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required; avoid rich soil, which produces floppy growth.

Companions: Lavender, catmint, ornamental grasses — classic gravel-garden and pollinator-border companions.

West of Ireland: A native wildflower with wiry, airy stems of tiny lilac flowers through summer, valuable for pollinators, and long used in traditional herbal medicine. Self-seeds gently; best in a sunny, well-drained spot rather than heavy wet clay.

P34. Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*)

Irish / Russian: Athair thalún · Тысячелистник обыкновенный

Light: ☀ Full sun — at least 6–8 hours. Tolerates partial shade but flowers less freely and becomes leggy.

Soil needs: Loamy soil is ideal, but yarrow tolerates clay soil if it drains well. Loosen soil 12–15 inches deep and mix in 2–4 inches of compost before planting. Avoid overly rich soil; too much fertility can cause floppy stems. pH 5.5–7.0. Very adaptable — will grow in poor soil.

Soil prep: Loosen soil to 30–40cm depth and mix in compost before planting. Do not add heavy nitrogen; this causes floppy stems. On clay, add 15–20% grit to improve drainage.

Planting depth: At pot level; bare-root crowns with buds 2–3cm below soil surface. Space 30–60cm apart.

Spacing: 30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs

Fertiliser: Apply a thin layer of compost each spring. Additional fertiliser is rarely necessary. Over-feeding produces tall, floppy plants that fall over. Yarrow needs little or no regular applications of fertiliser in most garden soils. Mulching plants in borders with well-rotted manure or garden compost each spring should be sufficient.

Companions: Yarrow helps deter unwanted pests, attracts native insects and predators like those that manage aphids and caterpillars, and works quietly to improve soil quality by replenishing nutrients. Yarrow pairs beautifully with weigela and hydrangea. Also excellent with roses, delphiniums, salvias, ornamental grasses, and echinacea. One of the best pollinator plants — flat-topped flowers are perfect landing platforms for hoverflies, butterflies and bees. ⚠ Can spread aggressively in good garden soil — divide every 2–3 years.

Pot size: 30cm diameter, 25cm deep container; multipurpose compost with 20% grit.

West of Ireland: Native *A. millefolium* grows wild throughout Ireland and is extremely well adapted to Irish conditions. Tolerates the wet, windy west coast. Excellent for naturalistic planting, wildflower meadow schemes, and cottage gardens.

GROUP S: SHADE & WOODLAND PLANTS

S1. Common Dog Violet (*Viola riviniana*)

Irish / Russian: Fanaigse · Фиалка Ривинуса

Light: 🌿 Partial shade; tolerates full sun to full shade.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.0.

Soil prep: Minimal — very adaptable native woodland-floor plant.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Primroses, wood sorrel, ferns — classic native woodland-floor groundcover; the larval food plant for several fritillary butterflies.

West of Ireland: Easy, unfussy native wildflower with violet-blue flowers in spring, valuable groundcover under trees and shrubs, and important for wildlife. Self-seeds gently to form drifts.

S10. Epimedium (Barrenwort) (*Epimedium* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
<i>E. x versicolor</i> 'Sulphureum'	<i>E. x versicolor</i> 'Sulphureum'	30cm	Spring (April–May)	Crown at soil level	Pale sulphur-yellow flowers; semi-evergreen heart-shaped leaves flushed bronze when young; RHS AGM
<i>E. x perralchicum</i> 'Rose Queen'	<i>E. x perralchicum</i> 'Rose Queen'	30–40cm	Spring (April–May)	Crown at soil level	Rose-pink, spurred flowers; vigorous, semi-evergreen groundcover, one of the toughest and most reliable Epimediums
<i>E. x rubrum</i>	<i>E. x rubrum</i>	20–30cm	Spring (April)	Crown at soil level	Crimson-red, white-spurred flowers; young foliage flushed bright red, ageing green with red-tinted margins in autumn

Light: ☀ to 🌑 Partial to full (dry) shade — one of the very best perennials for difficult dry shade under trees and shrubs.

Soil needs: Any reasonably drained soil, including clay; pH 5.5–7.5. Remarkably tolerant of dry shade once established, though it establishes best with reasonable moisture in its first year or two.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost; no special drainage measures needed.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level for all three.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Little needed once established — a light balanced feed in spring for the first couple of seasons helps establishment.

Companions: Ferns, hellebores, hostas, snowdrops and other dry-shade or woodland-edge perennials.

Pruning: Cut old, tatty foliage back hard in late winter, just before the new flower spikes and leaves emerge, to show off the flowers clearly and refresh the display for the coming season.

West of Ireland: All three are tough, spreading (but not invasive) semi-evergreen to evergreen groundcover perennials with delicate, spurred spring flowers held above (or just before) attractive heart-shaped foliage. Genuinely one of the best plant groups for the difficult dry shade under mature trees, where the region's rainfall rarely fully reaches the soil — once established, all three cope with remarkably little summer moisture. A superb, low-maintenance choice for a woodland-edge or shaded border in a west of Ireland garden.

S4. Ferns (Native Irish + Garden Cultivars)

Fern	Latin Name	Light	Height	Notes
Male Fern	<i>Dryopteris filix-mas</i>	☀️— ●	60– 100cm	Most robust native; tolerates exposed positions
Lady Fern	<i>Athyrium filix-femina</i>	☀️	60– 120cm	Prefers sheltered, moist shade
Broad Buckler Fern	<i>Dryopteris dilatata</i>	☀️— ●	60– 100cm	Glossy dark fronds; excellent in deep shade
Hard Shield Fern	<i>Polystichum aculeatum</i>	☀️	45– 60cm	Evergreen; tolerates dry shade & coastal exposure
Polypody	<i>Polypodium vulgare</i>	☀️	15– 40cm	Grows on walls and banks; evergreen
Royal Fern	<i>Osmunda regalis</i>	☀️— ☀️	1–2m	Loves wet clay and boggy spots; spectacular
Deer Fern	<i>Blechnum spicant</i>	☀️— ●	30– 60cm	Evergreen; needs acidic soil (pH 4.5–6.0)
Fortune's Holly Fern (var. <i>clivicola</i>)	<i>Cyrtomium fortunei</i> var. <i>clivicola</i>	☀️— ●	30– 60cm	Evergreen; very cold-hardy; bold, glossy fronds; tolerates dry shade
Koidzumi's Wood Fern	<i>Dryopteris koidzumiana</i>	☀️— ●	60– 90cm	Deciduous/semi-evergreen; warm copper new growth; shade and clay tolerant
Maidenhair Fern (Himalayan)	<i>Adiantum venustum</i>	☀️— ●	15– 25cm	Not native, but genuinely hardy (RHS AGM); delicate black-stemmed fan-shaped fronds; spreads slowly into a mat
Japanese Painted Fern	<i>Athyrium niponicum</i> 'Metallicum'	☀️— ●	30– 45cm	Deciduous; metallic silver-grey fronds flushed purple-red along the midribs; RHS AGM; one of the most colourful shade ferns available

Soil needs: Most: moist, humus-rich, acidic to neutral (pH 5.0–7.0). Deer fern: acidic conditions. *C. fortunei* var. *clivicola*: neutral to slightly alkaline tolerated (pH 6.0–8.0). *D. koidzumiana*: pH 5.5–7.0. *Adiantum venustum*: moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil, pH 5.5–7.0 — reliably moist conditions matter more than exact pH. Japanese Painted Fern: moist, humus-rich, slightly acidic soil, pH 5.5–6.5 — dislikes drying out, which dulls its metallic colouring.

Soil prep: Add generous compost. Extra moisture retention for Royal Fern and Lady Fern.

Planting depth: At pot level. Crowns of *Dryopteris* and *Osmunda* should sit 7–12cm above soil. *Adiantum venustum* has a thin, creeping rhizome planted at pot level.

Spacing: 30cm–1.5m between plants depending on species — see table above.

Fertiliser: Very low feeding requirements. Light balanced fertiliser in spring or annual compost top-dressing is sufficient. Do not overfeed. Bark mulch around base to retain moisture.

Companions: Hostas, astilbe, hellebores, snowdrops, bluebells. Native ferns under deciduous trees is the ideal naturalistic Irish planting. Japanese maple and bamboo make beautiful structural companions. Foxgloves self-seed among ferns magnificently.

West of Ireland: You are in prime fern territory. Royal Fern (*Osmunda regalis*) is spectacular in boggy west of Ireland conditions.

Notes on the two new additions:

Fortune's Holly Fern var. *clivicola* (*Cyrtomium fortunei* var. *clivicola*): A particularly cold-hardy variety of Fortune's holly fern (hardy to -15°C or below), originating in Japan and Korea. Produces bold, glossy, deep green fronds with holly-leaf-shaped pinnae. Fully evergreen. One of the few ferns that genuinely tolerates dry shade — invaluable under trees where moisture competition is fierce, a challenge common in west of Ireland woodland gardens. Grows well in neutral to slightly alkaline soils as well as acidic conditions, giving it wider site flexibility than many ferns. The RHS lists *Cyrtomium fortunei* as suitable for shade in humus-rich, well-drained to moist soil. Plant at pot level; the crown should sit at or just below the soil surface. Slug-resistant (tough, glossy fronds). Height 30–60cm; spread to 60cm. Pot size: 🟩 30–40cm / 15L+.

Koidzumi's Wood Fern (*Dryopteris koidzumiana*): A Japanese species related to the common Male Fern, increasingly grown as a garden fern in the UK and Ireland. Produces upright, broadly lance-shaped fronds with attractive coppery-bronze new growth in spring (resembling *D. erythrosora* in this regard), maturing to dark green. Semi-evergreen to deciduous depending on exposure; in the mild west of Ireland, usually semi-evergreen. Tolerates clay, moist soils, and shade well. Plant at pot level; crown at soil surface or just below; do not bury deeply. pH 5.5–7.0. Height 60–90cm; spread 60cm. Pot size: 🟩 40–50cm / 25–30L.

S1. Hosta / Plantain Lily (*Hosta* spp.)

Russian: Хоста

Variety	Height	Leaf colour	Notes
<i>H. sieboldiana</i> 'Elegans'	60–90cm	Large, rounded, deeply veined blue-grey	RHS AGM; one of the largest and most dramatic hosta leaves; slug-resistant thick substance
<i>H. × tardiana</i> 'Halcyon'	40cm	Frosty, glaucous blue-grey, heart-shaped when mature	RHS AGM; one of the best and most popular blue-leaved hostas; pale lavender bell-shaped flowers in summer
<i>H.</i> 'Undulata Albomarginata'	30–45cm	Wavy, twisted mid-green leaves with a broad creamy-white margin	Vigorous and reliable; one of the most widely grown variegated hostas
<i>H.</i> 'Shadowland Diamond Lake'	40–50cm	Rounded, deep blue leaves	Compact, slug-resistant, holds its blue colour well through summer
<i>H.</i> 'Frances Williams'	60–75cm	Blue-green, heavily puckered, with an irregular gold-yellow margin	RHS AGM; a classic, extremely popular large variegated hosta
<i>H.</i> 'Patriot'	40–50cm	Dark green with a crisp, wide white margin	Fast-growing, reliable, strong colour contrast

Light: ☀️ to 🌑 Partial to full shade. Golden and yellow-leaved types tolerate more sun; blue-leaved varieties need more shade — their glaucous "bloom" fades in strong sun.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, fertile soil; pH 5.5–7.5. Grows well on clay.

Soil prep: Add generous compost.

Planting depth: At pot level; crown just at soil surface.

Spacing: 30–90cm depending on variety — check the ultimate spread, since some (like 'Sieboldiana Elegans') become very large.

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release granular in spring. Balanced liquid feed monthly from April through midsummer. Do not feed after August. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia. Snowdrops and winter aconites bloom in the gaps before hostas emerge in spring.

Warnings ⚠️: Slugs and snails are the main challenge in the moist west of Ireland climate — wool pellets, copper tape (on pots), or nematode treatments are essential companions. Thicker-leaved varieties (e.g. 'Sieboldiana Elegans') show noticeably more slug resistance than thin-leaved types.

West of Ireland: The classic genus for a shaded Irish border, valued above all for handsome, often large and boldly variegated foliage rather than its relatively modest lily-like summer flowers. The mild, consistently moist Atlantic climate suits hostas very well — the main obstacle to a good display is slug and snail damage rather than the weather, so factor in some form of control from the moment new shoots emerge in spring.

S2. Irish Native Mosses

Light: ☀️ Partial to full shade; most native mosses scorch in strong, direct sun.

Spacing: Establish as low patches; allow to spread and knit together naturally over 1–2 growing seasons.

Soil/surface needs: Consistently moist, humid conditions on soil, rock, tree bases, walls or fallen wood; most prefer slightly acid, humus-rich conditions, though some (like common tamarisk-moss) tolerate neutral ground.

Establishing mosses: Unlike flowering plants, mosses are not "planted" in the usual sense — they establish from spores or small transplanted clumps ("moss transplant") pressed onto a clean, consistently damp surface (soil, rock, log, or the shaded base of a wall) and kept moist while they knit in, generally over one growing season.

Care: No feeding — added fertiliser harms moss. Keep the area free of fallen leaf litter, which can smother it, and maintain humidity/shade; mosses generally do not need protection from cold.

Companions: Ferns, wood sorrel, primroses and other shaded, damp woodland-floor plants; mosses are a natural companion groundcover beneath the native ferns already in this guide.

West of Ireland: Ireland's mild, exceptionally damp Atlantic climate is superb for mosses generally, and the west of Ireland (especially Kerry's oceanic woodlands) is internationally important for its bryophyte (moss and liverwort) diversity. A shaded, damp corner, old wall, or fallen log left undisturbed will often colonise naturally with little help. A selection of common native species suited to garden conditions:

Common name	Species	Typical habitat
Fox-tail Feather-moss	<i>Thamnobryum alopecurum</i>	Shaded rocks, streamsides, tree bases in humid woodland
Common Tamarisk-moss	<i>Thuidium tamariscinum</i>	Damp ground and rotting logs in woodland; tolerates neutral soils
Bank Haircap Moss	<i>Polytrichastrum formosum</i>	Shaded banks, ditches, woodland and tree stumps on acidic soils
Common Haircap	<i>Polytrichum commune</i>	Damp, acidic ground, bog margins and woodland
Swan's-neck Thyme-moss	<i>Mnium hornum</i>	Very common on tree bases, rotting wood and acidic woodland floor
Springy Turf-moss	<i>Rhytidiadelphus squarrosus</i>	Damp lawns, banks and open woodland; tolerant of some sun

S3. Lily of the Valley (*Convallaria majalis*)

Russian: Ландыш майский

Light: ☀️ Partial to full shade.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost/leaf mould.

Planting depth: Rhizome ("pip") 2–3cm deep, growing point up, in autumn.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; ⚠️ toxic, spreads

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual leaf mould mulch.

Companions: Ferns, hostas, hellebores — classic shaded woodland-floor groundcover.

West of Ireland: Fragrant white bell flowers in late spring, spreading by rhizomes to form good groundcover under trees and shrubs over time — can be vigorous once established, so give it room or a contained bed if a tidy border is wanted.

⚠️ All parts are toxic if ingested.

S5. Primulas (*Primula* spp.)

Irish / Russian: Sabhaircín · Первоцвет

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Drumstick Primula	<i>P. denticulata</i>	20–45cm	Mid-spring–early summer (April–June)	Crown at soil level	Spherical "drumstick" flowerheads in purple, lilac, pink, blue or white; RHS AGM; native to Himalayan/Chinese alpine meadows
Primroses	<i>P. vulgaris</i>	10–15cm	Late winter–spring	Crown at soil level	Native Irish wildflower; pale yellow flowers; self-seeds gently to form drifts

Light: ☀️ Partial shade for both; Primroses tolerate more sun in the cooler, moister west of Ireland climate than in drier regions.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil for both; pH 5.5–7.0. Both tolerate clay well provided it is not permanently waterlogged. Drumstick Primula in particular wants reliably moist, even boggy-at-the-edges soil — closer to the damp conditions preferred by candelabra primulas than to a normal border.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost/leaf mould for both.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level for both.

Spacing: Drumstick Primula: 20–30cm between plants. Primroses: 20–25cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring for both. Annual leaf mould/compost mulch.

Companions: Bluebells, wood anemones, violets, ferns — classic native woodland-floor and hedge-bank planting for Primroses.

Drumstick Primula combines well with other spring bulbs and moisture-loving woodland-edge perennials.

Warnings ⚠️: Drumstick Primula's leaves and stems can cause mild skin irritation in sensitive individuals — wear gloves if handling a lot of foliage.

West of Ireland: Primroses are one of Ireland's most familiar native spring wildflowers, found throughout hedge banks and woodland, easy and long-lived. Drumstick Primula is not native but thrives in the same cool, consistently moist Atlantic climate that suits its Himalayan origins, self-sowing readily once established to form good-sized colonies — best given reliably moist soil rather than a border that dries out in summer.

S6. Round-Lobed Hepatica (*Hepatica nobilis*)

Russian: Печёночница благородная

Light: 🌤️ Partial to full shade; ideal under deciduous trees.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil, tolerant of neutral to slightly alkaline; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leaf mould/compost and a little grit.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; resents disturbance once established.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual leaf mould mulch.

Companions: Snowdrops, hellebores, wood anemones — classic very-early-spring woodland-floor planting.

West of Ireland: One of the earliest woodland perennials to flower, with delicate blue, pink or white blooms often appearing before the leaves in late winter/early spring, followed by attractive lobed evergreen foliage. Slow-growing but long-lived once settled — best left undisturbed.

S7. St Patrick's Cabbage (*Saxifraga spathularis*)

Irish / Russian: Cabáiste mhadra rua · Камнеломка лопатчатая

Light: 🌤️ Partial shade to full shade; also tolerates exposed, unshaded mountain sites in its native range.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, acid soil among rocks; pH 5.0–6.0.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30–40% ericaceous compost/leaf mould and some grit — best replicating a humid, rocky woodland or streamside setting.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; shallow, stoloniferous rooting.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required. Light ericaceous feed in spring if growth is poor.

Companions: Ferns, mosses, other Irish native rock/woodland plants for an authentic west of Ireland native rockery or shaded bank.

West of Ireland: A true west of Ireland native and local treasure — part of the "Lusitanian flora" found naturally only in Ireland and parts of Portugal/Spain, most abundant in Kerry and west Cork on shaded, humid rocks and hedge banks. An excellent, genuinely native choice for a shaded rockery or damp stone wall in this guide's own region. Evergreen rosettes of fleshy leaves with delicate white, pink-speckled flowers in early summer.

S8. Tasmanian Tree Fern (*Dicksonia antarctica*)

Russian: Диксония антарктическая

Light: 🌤️ Partial to full shade; shelter from direct hot sun and, importantly, from cold drying winds.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, free-draining, slightly acid soil; pH 5.5–6.5. Needs consistent moisture at the crown and root zone but good drainage — dislikes both drought and waterlogging.

Soil prep: Mix clay with generous compost/leaf mould (40%+) and grit. In a container, use a peat-free ericaceous or woodland-type compost mix.

Planting depth: Trunk (caudex) at same depth as previously grown; the fibrous "trunk" is actually a mass of roots and needs to stay moist.

Spacing: 1.5–3m between plants; wrap crown in hard frost

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed watered into the crown monthly through the growing season. Regular watering — including watering directly into the crown in dry spells — is more important than feeding.

Companions: Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops — classic damp, shaded woodland-garden planting.

West of Ireland: RHS hardiness H4–H5 (borderline, roughly to –5°C, less with protection); the mild, humid west of Ireland climate suits it well in a sheltered spot, but in harder winters wrap the crown with fleece or straw. Water the crown regularly in the growing season — this is the single most common cause of failure when it is allowed to dry out.

S9. Wood Sorrel (*Oxalis acetosella*)

Irish / Russian: *Seamsóg* · Кислица обыкновенная

Light: 🌑 Full shade to 🌤️ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, acid to neutral soil; pH 5.0–6.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leaf mould/compost.

Planting depth: Crown/rhizome at soil level.

Spacing: 10–15cm between plants

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Ferns, mosses, primroses — classic deep-woodland-floor groundcover, often found growing directly among tree roots and on old stumps.

West of Ireland: A dainty native woodland groundcover with clover-like leaves that fold down at night and delicate white, purple-veined flowers in spring. Spreads gently by rhizomes to form soft carpets in deep shade where little else will grow — ideal under mature trees or in a native woodland-style corner.

GROUP T: ORNAMENTAL TREES & SHRUBS

T21. Acacia baileyana 'Purpurea' (Purple-leaf Cootamundra Wattle)

Light: 🌞 Full sun essential, in a sheltered spot away from cold winds.

Soil needs: Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates poor, dry soils but hates waterlogging.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 30% horticultural grit; a raised bed or south-facing wall base gives the best chance of success.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 3–4m between plants; fast-growing.

Fertiliser: Little needed once established; a balanced feed in spring for young plants only.

Companions: Rosemary, lavender and other Mediterranean-style plants sharing its need for sun and sharp drainage.

West of Ireland: A fast-growing evergreen with feathery, purple-flushed young foliage (ageing to blue-grey) and masses of fragrant yellow, mimosa-type flowers in late winter. Borderline hardy (RHS H3, roughly to –5°C) — reliably survives only in the mildest, most sheltered coastal west of Ireland gardens; elsewhere, best grown in a large container that can be moved under cover for winter.

T31. Balsam Fir (*Abies balsamea*)

Light: 🌞 Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist, well-drained, acidic to neutral soil; pH 5.0–6.5. Dislikes hot, dry conditions.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with ericaceous or multipurpose compost and grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 4–6m between plants for a full-sized tree; dwarf cultivars much closer.

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release feed in spring while young.

Companions: Underplant with ferns, hostas and other woodland-edge shade plants.

Fragrance : Famously fragrant — the classic "Christmas tree" scent, released strongly when the needles are crushed or the tree is cut; often used in balsam-filled pillows and potpourri.

West of Ireland: A neat, conical North American conifer, the archetypal Christmas tree, with soft, flat, dark green needles and upright purplish cones. Prefers cool, consistently moist conditions and dislikes hot, dry summers, which suits the mild west of Ireland climate reasonably well, though it performs best with some shelter from strong coastal wind. Full-sized specimens are large — a dwarf cultivar is a better fit for most gardens.

T1. Bamboo (clump-forming: *Fargesia* spp., *Chusquea* spp.)

Russian: Бамбук

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. *Fargesia* prefers some afternoon shade.

Soil needs: Most soils including clay; prefers moist, fertile, free-draining. Choose clump-forming species — running bamboo (*Phyllostachys*) requires a 60cm deep root barrier.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix clay 50/50 with compost. Mulch well.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1.5–3m from structures; root barrier for running types

Fertiliser: High-nitrogen fertiliser (lawn feed or balanced granular) each spring. Top-dress with compost each autumn. Container plants: balanced liquid fertiliser monthly during the growing season.

Companions: Ferns, hostas, astilbe, hellebores. Bamboo provides shelter for smaller plants. Root barrier required near structures.

T25. Black Locust (*Robinia pseudoacacia* 'Frisia')

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for the best golden leaf colour.

Soil needs: Any well-drained soil, including poor or dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil (it fixes its own nitrogen) but dislikes waterlogging.

Soil prep: Improve heavy clay with grit for the first few years; established trees are very tolerant.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark. Stake well while young — brittle wood is prone to wind damage.

Spacing: 6–8m between plants; can eventually reach 12–15m, though slower and more compact than the straight species.

Fertiliser: None needed once established — a nitrogen-fixing legume.

Companions: Underplant with shade-tolerant bulbs and perennials once the canopy provides light dappled shade.

Warnings ⚠: Brittle branches can break in strong wind — avoid very exposed sites, and site away from paths/parking. Thorny on some growth.

West of Ireland: A fast-growing deciduous tree grown for its soft, golden-yellow, fern-like foliage that lights up a garden from spring to autumn, with fragrant white pea-flowers in early summer. Tolerant of poor soil and pollution, but its brittle wood is vulnerable to breakage in the region's strong Atlantic winds — a sheltered spot is best.

T2. Border Forsythia (*Forsythia × intermedia*)

Russian: Форзиция средняя

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Flowers better in full sun.

Soil needs: pH 6.0–8.0. Tolerates clay very well.

Soil prep: Standard clay improvement with compost and grit.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1.5m between; 2m from walls

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser (Growmore) in early spring. Annual compost mulch after pruning. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds. ⚠ Prune immediately after flowering — never in autumn/winter (flower buds form on old wood).

Companions: Spring tulips underplanted, Vinca or Pulmonaria as underplanting, holly or yew as evergreen backdrop.

T4. Common Hawthorn (*Crataegus monogyna*)

Irish / Russian: *Sceach Gheal* · Боярышник однопестичный

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Very adaptable — most soils including heavy clay, chalk, and poor ground; pH 5.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Minimal — one of the most tolerant trees of clay and exposure. Improve drainage with grit only on the wettest sites.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: As hedge: 30–45cm; as tree: 4–6m from structures

Fertiliser: None needed once established. Light mulch of compost in early years.

Companions: Classic native hedgerow tree — combines with blackthorn, holly and hazel for a mixed native hedge; underplant with primroses, bluebells and violets.

West of Ireland: Ireland's most familiar native hedgerow and windbreak tree ("whitethorn"), exceptionally tolerant of wind, salt spray and exposure — an excellent, low-cost choice for shelterbelts on Atlantic-facing boundaries. Masses of white May blossom followed by red autumn haws valuable for birds.

T32. Douglas Fir (*Pseudotsuga menziesii*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist, well-drained soil, acidic to neutral; pH 5.0–6.5. Dislikes hot, dry sites.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: This is a genuinely enormous forest tree (naturally reaching well over 60m) — full-sized specimens need a very large garden or estate; dwarf and compact cultivars are a far more realistic choice for most gardens, spaced 2–4m apart.

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release feed in spring while young.

Companions: Best given its own space if grown as a full-sized specimen; dwarf cultivars combine well with other conifers and heathers.

Fragrance : Needles are noticeably fragrant when crushed or bruised, often described as citrusy or resinous.

West of Ireland: A majestic evergreen conifer, introduced to the UK and Ireland from western North America in the 1820s and now naturalised in some large estate woodlands. Tolerates the mild, moist Atlantic climate well and is not a true fir despite the name (it belongs to its own genus, *Pseudotsuga*). Given its ultimate size, this is a tree for a large garden, parkland or woodland planting rather than an average suburban plot — choose one of the many dwarf or compact cultivars available for a smaller space.

T5. Dwarf Lily Magnolia (*Magnolia liliiflora*, e.g. 'Nigra')

Russian: Магнолия лилиецветная

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 part shade, sheltered from cold wind.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; slightly acid to neutral, pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes shallow chalk and waterlogging.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30% compost/ericaceous compost and grit for drainage. Avoid deep planting.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark; shallow, fleshy roots — do not disturb once planted.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants/structures

Fertiliser: Balanced or ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Annual mulch with compost or bark, kept away from the trunk.

Companions: Underplant with hellebores, ferns, snowdrops; pairs well with Japanese maple and star magnolia for a spring border.

West of Ireland: More compact and later-flowering than star magnolia, so its blooms often escape the worst late frosts. Reliably hardy in sheltered west of Ireland gardens; avoid frost pockets and exposed coastal wind.

T6. Dwarf Mountain Pine (*Pinus mugo* var. *mugo*)

Light: ☀ Full sun — needed to keep the habit compact and dense; tolerates part shade but grows looser.

Soil needs: Any reasonably drained soil, pH 5.0–7.5; naturally found on poor, rocky mountain soils, so tolerates poor and thin ground well. Dislikes permanently waterlogged clay.

Soil prep: Dig a hole twice the width of the rootball. Mix the excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost, adding 20–30% horticultural grit to guarantee sharp drainage — this matters more than fertility for a plant adapted to mountain scree. On the wettest clay, plant on a slightly raised mound.

Planting depth: At the same level as in the pot; do not bury the base of the stems.

Spacing: 1.5–2m between plants; ultimate size around 1.5–2m tall and wide, reached slowly.

Fertiliser: None needed at planting — wait 6–8 weeks before feeding to avoid burning new roots. From the following spring, a light dressing of Kieserite (magnesium sulphate) or an organic conifer feed each February–March keeps the needles a good green. Otherwise very low-maintenance.

Companions: Heather, dwarf junipers, sempervivum and other rockery or gravel-garden plants that share its need for sharp drainage.

West of Ireland: A genuinely tough, slow-growing dwarf conifer from the mountains of central and southern Europe — very cold-hardy and, once established, tolerant of salt-laden wind, which makes it a good choice for an exposed coastal west of Ireland garden. Needs almost no pruning beyond removing dead wood.

T26. Elder 'Black Lace' (*Sambucus nigra* 'Black Lace')

Light: ☀ Full sun for the deepest near-black leaf colour; tolerates partial shade but foliage turns more green.

Soil needs: Most soils including clay, moist but well-drained; pH 5.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost; very adaptable and easy.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants; can be kept smaller with annual pruning.

Fertiliser: Balanced feed in spring; annual compost mulch.

Companions: Contrasts beautifully with lime-green or golden foliage (e.g. golden Philadelphus, Choisya 'Sundance') and with pink or white-flowered shrubs and perennials.

Pruning: For the best, largest foliage, cut hard back to a framework in late winter each year (sacrificing some flowers); for flowers and berries as well as foliage, prune more lightly.

West of Ireland: A striking large shrub with finely cut, near-black purple foliage and pink-flushed, lacy flowerheads in early summer, followed by black elderberries (edible when cooked, like the wild native elder). Fully hardy and easy in the mild, moist Irish climate — a dramatic dark foil for pale or pastel-flowered companions.

T33. English Oak (*Quercus robur*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Any soil including clay and chalk; pH 5.0–8.0. Extremely tolerant and lime-tolerant.

Soil prep: Minimal — one of the most adaptable trees to heavy clay in this guide, needing no special amendment.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 8–10m minimum from structures for a young tree, and ideally considerably more given its eventual size (up to 35m) — this is a long-lived, very large forest tree.

Fertiliser: None needed once established.

Companions: Bluebells, wood anemones and other native woodland-floor plants once the canopy provides dappled shade; supports an exceptional range of native Irish insect and bird life.

West of Ireland: A magnificent, iconic native-range tree (present in Ireland since prehistory, though most Irish "native" oak woodland is now largely sessile oak, *Quercus petraea*) valued as much for wildlife as for timber — few other trees support as much insect, lichen and bird life. Extremely long-lived, tolerant of the region's heavy clay and high rainfall, and a genuine multi-generational specimen tree — plant only where there is truly room for a very large, long-lived tree, well away from buildings and drains.

T7. False Spirea (*Sorbaria sorbifolia*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Most moist soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.5. Very adaptable and tolerant of poor drainage better than many shrubs.

Soil prep: Minimal — dig hole twice rootball width, mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants; spreads by suckers

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Good at the back of a mixed border with hydrangea and deutzia; also useful for stabilising damp banks.

West of Ireland: Vigorous, suckering shrub with creamy plume-like flowers in summer — spreads readily by suckers, so best given room to naturalise (e.g. a bank or informal border) rather than a tight border, where it can be kept in check by removing suckers.

T34. Fraser Fir (*Abies fraseri*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 light shade.

Soil needs: Moist, well-drained, acidic soil; pH 5.0–6.0. Dislikes heat and drought.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with ericaceous or multipurpose compost and grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 4–6m between plants for a full-sized tree.

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release feed in spring while young.

Companions: Underplant with ferns, hostas and other acid-loving woodland-edge plants.

Fragrance : Strongly and pleasantly fragrant, often described as resembling turpentine or classic pine-forest scent; the needles are notably long-lasting once cut, which is why this species is the most popular Christmas tree species commercially grown in North America.

West of Ireland: A neat, conical North American fir native to the high Appalachian Mountains, with dark green needles showing silvery-white undersides. Prefers cool, consistently moist conditions similar to its native mountain habitat, which the mild, damp west of Ireland climate can suit well given reasonable shelter; dislikes hot, dry summers, which are rarely an issue here. A good choice where a genuinely fragrant conifer specimen is wanted.

T8. Fuzzy Pride-of-Rochester (*Deutzia scabra*)

Russian: Дейция шершавая

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade. Flowers best and stays more compact in full sun; needs a sheltered spot out of the coldest wind.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Not fussy once drainage is adequate.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1.5–2m between plants; grows 1.8–3m tall

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Lewis mock orange, lilac, weigela — classic spring/early-summer flowering shrub border. Underplant with spring bulbs.

West of Ireland: A larger, more vigorous *Deutzia* than the dwarf *D. gracilis* type, with distinctive peeling cinnamon-coloured bark and fuzzy, sandpaper-textured leaves (hence "scabra," Latin for rough) that give this cultivar its common name. Double white flowers, sometimes tinged pink, in early summer on arching branches. Prune immediately after flowering, removing a proportion of the oldest stems at the base each year to keep it renewing well — it flowers on the previous year's wood, so late pruning sacrifices next year's display. Note: in parts of North America this species can self-seed and naturalise; in an Irish garden setting this is not generally a concern, but deadheading after flowering avoids any risk of unwanted seedlings.

T23. Ginkgo (*Ginkgo biloba*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Any well-drained soil, including clay; pH 5.0–8.0. Extremely tolerant of a wide range of conditions once established.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for the first few years while roots establish; mature trees tolerate clay well.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 6–8m between plants for a full-sized tree; slow-growing, so this size takes many decades to reach.

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in spring for the first few years only; established trees need none.

Companions: Underplant with spring bulbs and shade-tolerant perennials once the canopy matures; in youth, while still small, combines well with ornamental grasses.

West of Ireland: An ancient, exceptionally tough and disease-resistant deciduous conifer relative with distinctive fan-shaped leaves that turn bright butter-yellow in autumn. Male trees are usually chosen for gardens, since female trees produce foul-smelling fruit. Extremely long-lived and virtually pest- and disease-free; tolerates urban pollution, wind and a wide range of soils, making it a genuinely low-maintenance choice, though slow-growing, so buy as large a specimen as you can afford if a quicker impact is wanted.

T9. Holly (*Ilex aquifolium*)

Irish / Russian: *Cuileann* · *Падуб остролистный*

Light: 🌑 Full shade to 🌞 full sun. Extraordinary adaptability. More berries in sunnier positions. ⚠️ Plant at least one male + one female for berries.

Soil needs: pH 4.5–8.0. Tolerates heavy clay, poor soil, coastal exposure.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice rootball size, backfill with clay/compost mix. Grit helpful but not essential.

Planting depth: At pot level; fibrous shallow root mat, do not bury deeply.

Spacing: 1.5–3m between; slow-growing hedge

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring only if plant looks weak or pale. Annual bark mulch more useful than heavy feeding. Container: slow-release granular fertiliser each spring, liquid feed monthly in summer.

Companions: Yew (classic Irish churchyard combination), forsythia (glows against dark foliage), winter-flowering hellebores, snowdrops beneath. Critical: plant at least one male (e.g. 'Silver Queen' — confusingly a male) and one or more berry-bearing females nearby (within 50–100m).

⚠️ All parts except berry flesh toxic to humans and livestock.

T36. Horse Chestnut (*Aesculus hippocastanum*)

Light: 🌞 Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

Soil needs: Most soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.5. Adaptable and tolerant.

Soil prep: Minimal — a tolerant tree once established.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: Needs a genuinely large garden or parkland setting — 10m+ from structures, and considerably more space to reach its full, wide-spreading canopy.

Fertiliser: None needed once established.

Companions: Best given its own space, since it casts dense shade and has a wide root spread once mature.

West of Ireland: A large, familiar deciduous tree (not native to Ireland or Britain, but long naturalised, originally from the Balkans), grown for its impressive upright "candles" of white or pink flowers in May and its glossy conkers in autumn — a childhood favourite. Fully hardy in the mild, moist Irish climate, but its eventual size and dense canopy make it suitable only for a large garden, parkland or avenue planting, not an average suburban plot. Increasingly affected by leaf miner and bleeding canker in parts of the UK/Ireland, which can shorten leaf display but rarely kills an established tree outright.

T10. Irish Yew (*Taxus baccata* 'Fastigiata')

Irish / Russian: *lúr* · *Тис ягодный*

Light: 🌑 Full shade to 🌞 full sun. Narrow column; produces more compact form in full sun. Discovered as natural mutation in Co. Fermanagh in the 18th century — all Irish yews worldwide descend from that one tree.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils, pH 5.0–8.0. Tolerates heavy clay if drainage adequate. Deeply dislikes waterlogged roots.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. On very wet clay, plant on a raised mound.

Planting depth: At pot level. Extensive but not deep root system.

Spacing: Column 1m wide eventually; 1m from structures

Fertiliser: Very little required. Light balanced slow-release fertiliser in spring if plant looks pale. Annual bark mulch more beneficial than chemical feeding. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds.

Companions: Holly, peonies, roses (as a dark backdrop), hellebores, snowdrops. Evergreen column provides structure year-round.

⚠️ All parts except red berry flesh are highly toxic to humans, horses and livestock. Do not plant near paddocks.

T22. Japanese Barberry (*Berberis thunbergii* 'Atropurpurea')

Light: ☀ Full sun for the best deep purple leaf colour; tolerates partial shade but foliage turns greener.

Soil needs: Any reasonably drained soil, including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Very adaptable and tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Minimal — one of the easiest and most tolerant shrubs of clay in this guide. Add compost to very heavy ground.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 60–90cm between plants for a hedge; 1–1.2m as a specimen.

Fertiliser: None needed once established.

Companions: Golden or lime-green shrubs (e.g. *Choisya*, golden *Philadelphus*) for foliage contrast; spring bulbs beneath.

Warnings: ⚠: Sharply spined stems — wear thick gloves when pruning; site away from paths used by children.

West of Ireland: A tough, spiny deciduous shrub with rich reddish-purple foliage all season, small pale yellow spring flowers, red autumn berries and fiery autumn leaf colour. Extremely hardy and low-maintenance, tolerant of wind, pollution and poor soil — an excellent low hedge or barrier planting for an exposed site.

T11. Japanese Camellia (*Camellia japonica*)

Russian: Камелия японская

Light: 🌤 Partial shade preferred, sheltered from early morning sun (which can damage frosted buds) and cold wind.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich, acid soil; pH 5.0–6.5. Will yellow (chlorosis) on alkaline soil.

Soil prep: Mix clay generously with ericaceous compost (40%+) and grit. In a container, use peat-free ericaceous compost.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark; shallow-rooted, do not bury the stem base.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Ericaceous slow-release feed after flowering in spring. Avoid feeding after midsummer, to let wood ripen before winter.

Companions: Japanese skimmia, hydrangea macrophylla, Japanese maple — classic acid-soil shrub border.

West of Ireland: The mild, humid west of Ireland climate suits camellias well, though a sheltered spot out of early morning sun and harsh wind protects the flowers. Excellent in a large container of ericaceous compost if clay soil is not acid enough.

T20. Japanese Cedar (*Cryptomeria japonica*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, fertile, acid to neutral soil; pH 5.5–6.5. Tolerates a wide range of soils including clay, but dislikes drying out and dislikes strong maritime exposure (unlike many other conifers in this guide).

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with multipurpose or ericaceous compost and 20% grit for drainage. Choose a site sheltered from strong winds — this is essential, not optional, for this species.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 4–6m between plants for a full-sized tree; dwarf cultivars (e.g. 'Globosa Nana', 'Vilmoriniana') can go as close as 1–1.5m.

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release feed in early spring. Keep soil evenly moist, especially while young; established trees tolerate short dry spells but perform best without prolonged drought.

Companions: Japanese maple, camellia, rhododendron and other acid-loving woodland-edge shrubs; underplant with ferns and hostas.

Pot/container: ✅ Dwarf cultivars such as 'Globosa Nana' are well suited to a large container of ericaceous or multipurpose compost; full-sized forms need open ground.

West of Ireland: A large, elegant evergreen conifer with soft, awl-shaped needles that take on a bronze tint in winter and attractive, peeling red-brown bark. Full-sized forms need a big, sheltered garden — this is not a tree for an exposed coastal site, since RHS and other growers note it dislikes strong winds and salt-laden maritime exposure, unlike many conifers already in this guide. Dwarf cultivars are a much better fit for a smaller or more exposed west of Ireland garden.

T3. Japanese Flowering Cherry (*Prunus serrulata*)

Russian: Вишня мелкопильчатая

Variety	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
'Kanzan'	Up to 8m	Mid-spring (April)	Graft union at/above soil	Vase-shaped becoming spreading; deep-pink double flowers; the most widely planted flowering cherry
'Shirotae' (syn. 'Mount Fuji')	4–6m	Mid-late spring	Graft union at/above soil	Spreading, flat-topped crown with arching branches; fragrant, semi-double pure white flowers; RHS AGM
'Kiku-shidare' (syn. 'Kiku-shidare-zakura', 'Cheal's Weeping')	2.5–4m	Mid-late spring	Graft union at/above soil	Weeping habit with gracefully arching branches; fully double rich pink "chrysanthemum" flowers; RHS AGM

Light: ☀ Full sun for all three. Avoid frost pockets — late frosts damage the blossom.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. None tolerates permanently wet ground.

Soil prep: Dig a hole at least 60cm wide and 45cm deep. Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. Stake well, especially the weeping 'Kiku-shidare'.

Planting depth: Graft union at or just above soil level for all three.

Spacing: 'Kanzan': 4–5m from structures. 'Shirotae': 4–6m, given its wide spreading crown. 'Kiku-shidare': 2.5–4m — the most compact of the three.

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in early spring. Compost mulch around the base each spring. Do not feed in late summer.

Companions: Daffodils and tulips beneath (spectacularly timed with the blossom). Forget-me-nots as a blue carpet. Hostas and hardy geraniums as underplanting.

Pruning: Prune only in summer, if needed, to reduce the risk of silver leaf disease common to *Prunus* species.

West of Ireland: All three are hardy, reliable flowering cherries for the mild, moist Irish climate. 'Kanzan' is the classic bold pink double-flowered form widely planted in Irish streets and gardens; 'Shirotae' offers a softer, more elegant white display with a wide, flat-topped habit well suited to a lawn specimen; 'Kiku-shidare' brings a graceful weeping form to a smaller garden where the upright vigour of 'Kanzan' or 'Shirotae' would be too much. All three benefit from a sheltered spot away from strong coastal winds, which can damage the blossom and shorten the display.

T12. Japanese Maple (*Acer palmatum*)

Russian: Клён дланевидный

Light: 🌤 Partial shade preferred. Morning sun with afternoon shade is ideal. Variegated and dissectum types especially wind-sensitive. Avoid open exposed positions.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, slightly acidic, pH 5.5–6.5.

Soil prep: Dig 2–3× diameter of rootball. Mix clay with compost, 25% ericaceous compost and 25% grit in backfill. Shallow-rooted — do not dig deeply.

Planting depth: At pot level. Shallow-rooted; do not bury.

Spacing: 2–4m from structures; wind shelter essential

Fertiliser: Slow-release balanced fertiliser (e.g. Osmocote) in spring. Container: liquid feed monthly April–July at balanced rate — do not feed after July. Annual composted bark mulch.

Companions: Hostas (classic combination), ferns, hellebores, snowdrops beneath. Excellent specimen plant. Avoid planting with other thirsty trees nearby.

West of Ireland: Wind shelter is essential. Sheltered courtyard or walled garden position is ideal.

T13. Japanese Skimmia (*Skimmia japonica*)

Russian: СКИММИЯ японская

Light: 🌑 Shade to 🌤 partial shade preferred; tolerates full sun in cooler, moister climates like the west of Ireland.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; prefers slightly acid to neutral, pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes dry or chalky soils.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30–40% ericaceous compost and grit for drainage. Add well-rotted organic matter.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark; shallow-rooted, do not bury the stem base.

Spacing: 60–90cm between plants; ♂+♀ within a few metres for berries

Fertiliser: Ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Mulch annually with ericaceous compost or bark.

Companions: Hellebores, ferns, hostas and other shade/woodland plants; Japanese maple and hydrangea for a shaded border.

West of Ireland: Dioecious — plant at least one male (e.g. 'Rubella') near females (e.g. 'Nymans') for the females' red berries. Compact, reliable evergreen for shaded, sheltered spots; good in containers on the north side of a house.

⚠ Berries are mildly toxic if ingested in quantity.

T35. Korean Fir (*Abies koreana*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade, with some shelter from cold wind.

Soil needs: Deep, moist, slightly acidic to neutral, well-drained soil; pH 5.0–6.5. Grows poorly in heavy clay unless well amended.

Soil prep: Mix clay generously with ericaceous or multipurpose compost and grit for drainage — this species is less clay-tolerant than many other conifers in this guide.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 3–4m between plants for a full-sized specimen; slow-growing, so this takes many years; dwarf cultivars (e.g. 'Silberlocke') can go much closer.

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release feed in spring while young.

Companions: Heather, dwarf conifers and other acid-loving woodland-edge plants.

Fragrance : The needles are noticeably fragrant, particularly when crushed.

West of Ireland: A compact, slow-growing, RHS AGM conifer from the mountains of South Korea, prized for its short, dense, glossy needles (silvery beneath) and striking upright violet-blue cones, produced even on young trees. Prefers cooler conditions and good shelter from wind — well suited to the mild but often breezy west of Ireland climate given a reasonably sheltered spot, though it dislikes being planted in unamended heavy clay.

T14. Lewis Mock Orange (*Philadelphus lewisii*)

Russian: Чубушник Льюиса

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ part shade. Best flowering and fragrance in full sun.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of a wide range once established.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1.5–2m between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds, which favour leaves over flowers.

Companions: Deutzia and Lilac (classic mixed shrub border companions), roses, spring bulbs beneath.

West of Ireland: State flower of Idaho, very hardy and wind-tolerant once established — a good choice for exposed Atlantic gardens. Prune immediately after flowering (flowers on previous year's wood).

T15. Lilac (*Syringa vulgaris*)

Irish / Russian: Craobh liathchorcra · Сирень обыкновенная

Light: ☀ Full sun — needs at least 6 hours to flower well.

Soil needs: Neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–8.0.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–25% grit. Add garden lime if soil is acidic. Slight mound if waterlogging is a risk.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1.5m between; 2m from walls

Fertiliser: Superphosphate or balanced fertiliser in early spring. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds (produces leaves, not flowers). Annual compost mulch around base.

Companions: Roses (May–June combination), alliums, irises, peonies, delphiniums, aquilegia, geraniums. Foxgloves self-seed naturally nearby.

T16. Mophead / Lacecap Hydrangea (*Hydrangea macrophylla*)

Russian: Гортензия крупнолистная

Light: ☀️ Partial shade preferred. Morning sun with afternoon shade is ideal. Bigleaf hydrangea performs best in areas with dappled sunlight, partial shade, or deep shade. Protect it from afternoon sun. The macrophylla cultivars famously tolerate coastal exposure.

Soil needs: They love a fertile, humus-rich, clay soil. pH 5.0–6.0 for blue flowers; 6.0–7.0 for pink flowers. Moist but well-drained. Good salt tolerance. Flower colour changes depending on soil pH — blue in acid soils (high aluminium availability), mauve in lightly acid to neutral soil, pink in alkaline conditions.

Soil prep: Before planting, dig in well-rotted compost or manure to the whole area (not just the planting hole), using a bucketful per square yard/metre. Make the planting hole as deep as the root ball and three times wider. For blue flowers: use ericaceous compost in the planting hole and grow in ericaceous compost in containers.

Planting depth: At pot level; place the top of the rootball at or slightly above surrounding soil level. Shallow-rooted — avoid hoeing around it as roots can be easily damaged.

Spacing: 90cm–2.4m between (check label for variety size)

Fertiliser: Fertilise once in spring with a fertiliser designed to encourage blooms such as one high in phosphorus (e.g. 15-30-15). For blue flowers: feed with a fertiliser low in phosphorus and high in potassium and use ericaceous compost. If you're gardening on alkaline soils and want to retain blue flowers, grow in containers using ericaceous compost. Stop feeding after August.

⚠️ **Pruning note:** Hydrangeas that flower on old wood should not be pruned hard as you will lose this summer's flowers. Prune in mid-spring; only remove the withered flowerheads and dead parts. Traditionally leave old flowers on through winter to protect new growth from cold.

Companions: Astilbe, hostas, ferns (all love similar moist, semi-shaded conditions). Yarrow pairs beautifully with hydrangea. Heucheras, hardy geraniums, and hellebores as underplanting. Behind low-growing perennials such as bergenias at the border front.

Pot size: Standard mophead varieties reach 1–1.5m in containers and need 50–60cm pots at maturity. Compact cultivars like Cityline Paris manage in 30–35cm pots. Use ericaceous compost for blue flowers; standard John Innes No.3 (2 parts) + multipurpose compost (1 part) for pink flowers.

West of Ireland: Hydrangeas are one of the quintessential plants of Irish gardens. Macrophylla hydrangeas tolerate coastal exposure too. The mild, moist Atlantic climate suits them perfectly. The west of Ireland's naturally slightly acidic soils tend to produce beautiful blue-mauve flowers. Choose a sheltered spot away from frost pockets — late frosts can damage new growth.

T17. Mountain Ash / Rowan (*Sorbus aucuparia*)

Irish / Russian: Саорхатанн · Рябина обыкновенная

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

Soil needs: Very adaptable — most soils including clay, acid or neutral; pH 5.0–7.0. Dislikes shallow chalk.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost; grit if drainage is poor.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 3–5m from structures

Fertiliser: Little required once established. Balanced feed in the first two seasons; annual compost mulch.

Companions: A traditional companion to holly and hawthorn in native hedgerows and gardens; underplant with ferns, foxgloves, hellebores.

West of Ireland: One of the hardiest, most wind- and exposure-tolerant native trees, traditionally planted near Irish homes for protection ("the traveller's tree" / rowan folklore). Bright orange-red berries from late summer are an important food source for birds; excellent for exposed sites.

T37. Scots Pine (*Pinus sylvestris*)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential.

Soil needs: Any well-drained soil, including poor, sandy or acidic ground; pH 4.5–7.0. Dislikes heavy waterlogged clay.

Soil prep: Improve heavy clay with 30% grit; this species is naturally adapted to poor, free-draining soils.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 6–10m between plants for a full-sized tree; this is a large forest tree at maturity (up to 30m).

Fertiliser: None needed once established.

Companions: Heather, gorse and other plants of poor, acidic, free-draining ground.

Fragrance : Distinctly resinous and fragrant, especially the sap and crushed needles — the classic "pine forest" scent.

West of Ireland: A native-range evergreen conifer (native to Scotland and once native to Ireland too, where ancient pine woodland has been reintroduced in some conservation projects) with distinctive orange-red upper bark and blue-green needles. Tolerates poor, acidic, free-draining soil and coastal exposure well, but genuinely needs full sun and dislikes the region's heavier, wetter clay unless drainage is properly improved. A large, long-lived specimen tree suited to a big garden rather than a small plot.

T27. Shrubby Cinquefoil (*Potentilla fruticosa*, incl. var. *aurea*)

Light: ☀ Full sun for the most flowers; tolerates partial shade.

Soil needs: Any reasonably drained soil, including clay, chalk and poor ground; pH 5.5–8.0. Very adaptable and undemanding.

Soil prep: Minimal — one of the easiest, most tolerant flowering shrubs of clay in this guide.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 60–90cm between plants for a low hedge; 1m as a specimen.

Fertiliser: Little needed — a light balanced feed in spring for a poor site is usually enough.

Companions: Lavender, catmint, ornamental grasses — classic sunny border and low-hedge companions.

West of Ireland: A compact, twiggy deciduous shrub with small divided leaves and a long succession of saucer-shaped flowers (yellow, gold, white, pink or orange depending on cultivar) from late spring right through to autumn. Extremely hardy, tolerant of wind and coastal exposure, and virtually trouble-free — an excellent low-maintenance choice for a low informal hedge or border edge in an exposed west of Ireland garden.

T24. Smooth Sumac (*Rhus glabra* 'Laciniata')

Light: ☀ Full sun for the best autumn colour.

Soil needs: Any well-drained soil, including poor or dry ground; pH 5.5–7.5. Very adaptable.

Soil prep: Minimal — thrives on poor soil; avoid overly rich ground, which encourages excessive suckering.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants; spreads by suckers, so allow room or control with a root barrier.

Fertiliser: None needed — feeding encourages unwanted vigorous suckering.

Companions: Ornamental grasses and other plants that can compete with its suckering habit; avoid delicate small perennials nearby.

Warnings ⚠: Spreads by suckers and can become a thicket if not controlled — remove unwanted suckers as they appear, or contain the roots.

West of Ireland: A striking architectural shrub with finely cut, fern-like foliage that turns brilliant orange-red in autumn, and conical clusters of crimson fruit persisting into winter. Fully hardy and easy in the mild, moist Irish climate; give it room to spread or be prepared to control suckers regularly.

T18. St John's Wort 'Rowallane' (*Hypericum* 'Rowallane')

Russian: Зверобой

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☀ part shade. Flowers best in full sun.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.5. Prefers shelter from hard frost and cold winds — borderline hardy (RHS H4), so a sheltered spot is important in the west of Ireland.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual compost mulch; avoid feeding late in the season, which can soften growth ahead of winter.

Companions: Heathers, skimmia and other evergreen structure shrubs; also pairs well with roses and late perennials for a long season of interest.

West of Ireland: Large, showy golden-yellow flowers from midsummer into autumn. Semi-evergreen to evergreen in mild areas. Site against a warm wall or in a sheltered border, away from the coldest exposure.

T19. Star Magnolia (*Magnolia stellata*)

Russian: Магнолия звёздчатая

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Morning sun, sheltered position. Blooms in March–April — susceptible to late frost damage.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, pH 5.0–6.5. Tolerates alkaline better than most magnolias (RHS). Shallow, fleshy roots — handle gently.

Soil prep: Wide, shallow hole. Mix clay with compost and 20% grit. Generous bark or leaf mould mulch each spring.

Planting depth: At pot level. Do not plant deeper. Fleshy roots are fragile — do not damage.

Spacing: 2.5m spread; shelter from N/E winds

Fertiliser: Slow-release balanced fertiliser in spring. Annual bark mulch more beneficial than heavy feeding. Ericaceous liquid feed sparingly on acidic soils.

Companions: Snowdrops, species crocus, Iris reticulata (bloom before magnolia leaves up). Hellebores in partial shade beneath. Hardy geraniums as ground cover. White flowers shown off beautifully against evergreen backdrop.

GROUP W: POND & WATER PLANTS

W10. Arrowhead (*Sagittaria sagittifolia*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☀ partial shade.

Soil needs: Deep mud or aquatic compost in a basket; pH 6.0–7.5. Native to Ireland and Britain — the only native *Sagittaria* here (the name "Sagittaria vulgaris" sometimes used for this plant is not a recognised scientific name; *S. sagittifolia*, Common/Old World Arrowhead, is correct).

Soil prep: Use aquatic compost in a planting basket, or plant directly into pond-bottom mud.

Planting depth: Crown at soil surface; grows in up to 20cm of still or slow-moving water over the mud.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants; spreads by bulbils (small bulb-like offsets) which can be collected and replanted.

Fertiliser: Aquatic fertiliser tablets pushed into the basket compost at the start of the growing season.

Companions: Yellow flag iris, bogbean, flowering rush and other native marginal pond plants.

West of Ireland: A true Irish and British native, with distinctive arrow-shaped emergent leaves above water and ribbon-like submerged leaves below. White, three-petalled flowers with purple centres appear June–September. Reverts to a dormant bulb-like tuber each autumn and regrows the following spring — perfect for a naturalistic native pond margin.

W1. Bog Asphodel (*Narthecium ossifragum*)

Irish / Russian: Sciollam na móna · Нартециум костоломный

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Permanently wet, humus-rich, nutrient-poor, acid soil/peat; pH 4.5–6.0.

Soil prep: No amendment with compost or fertiliser — this plant is adapted to nutrient-poor bog conditions and rich soil is counterproductive. Best in a boggy, permanently wet corner or the very shallow, saturated margin of a pond.

Planting depth: Crown/rhizome at soil surface, kept permanently wet.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; needs permanently wet acid soil

Fertiliser: None — bog asphodel is adapted to nutrient-poor conditions.

Companions: Bogbean, bog pimpernel, sphagnum-type damp margin planting.

West of Ireland: Widespread in Irish bogs, heaths and moorland, with spikes of bright yellow, star-shaped flowers in summer turning deep orange in autumn. A specialist for a genuinely boggy, acid, permanently wet spot rather than an ordinary border or standard pond margin.

⚠️ Foliage is toxic to livestock if grazed in quantity; not a concern for typical garden use, but worth knowing if animals have access.

W2. Bog Pimpernel (*Anagallis tenella*)

Irish / Russian: *Falcaire corraigh* · Анагаллис нежный

Light: ☀️ Full sun.

Spacing: 30–40cm apart; spreads as carpet

Soil needs: Grow in the damp margin to level with the water surface. Moderately fertile, moist but not deeply submerged. Damp margins, bog gardens, very shallow water.

Water depth: Surface moisture to very shallow water (0–5cm at most). Primarily a bog and wet-margin plant.

Planting: Remove from aquatic basket/pot and plant directly into damp boggy soil at the water's edge, or at the very margin of a pond.

Fertiliser: Minimal — adapted to low-nutrient bog conditions. No feeding required if in naturally boggy soil. A light liquid balanced feed monthly if in a container situation will maintain good growth.

Companions: Bogbean, yellow flag iris, water mint, native mosses, royal fern at pond margins. This spreading, native plant forms a dense carpet of tiny evergreen leaves, mixed with numerous rosy pink flowers from late spring to early summer.

West of Ireland: A native Irish plant of damp, slightly acidic marshes, flush grasslands, and lake margins. Particularly common in the west of Ireland, where it grows in abundance in the Burren and Connaught margins. Its natural conditions are replicated in any consistently damp, open, sunny spot near water.

W3. Bogbean (*Menyanthes trifoliata*)

Irish / Russian: *Báchrán* · Вахта трёхлистная

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade. Full sun preferred to encourage flowering.

Spacing: 60cm between plants; spreads indefinitely without basket

Soil needs: Shallow water or boggy mud. Grow in baskets in a large pond in water up to 25cm deep, or grow in muddy pool margins.

Water depth: Planting depth: up to 20cm (8 inches) deep in water. Alternatively, in boggy soil at the water's edge with consistent moisture.

Basket size: Recommend a planting basket of at least 19cm across for one plant, or for more impact, plant several of the same variety in a larger basket.

Planting: Place the *Menyanthes* in a container or directly in the soil, making sure that the roots plus about 2 inches of the plant's stem is in the soil and at least an inch of water.

Fertiliser: Very low-maintenance; requires little feeding. Aquatic fertiliser tablet in the basket compost at the start of each growing season is sufficient. The plant is adapted to naturally nutrient-poor bog conditions.

Companions: White water lily, yellow flag iris, bog pimpernel. Bogbean will spread indefinitely by its thick pink rhizomes if not planted in an aquatic basket. Keep in a basket in smaller ponds. Bogbean provides excellent habitat for dragonfly adults and larvae as well as a host of other semi-aquatic invertebrates. Flowers attract bumblebees.

West of Ireland: A native Irish plant of bogs, fens, and lake margins. In nature, bogbean only occurs in bogs and fens, making it a diagnostic species of these important habitats. Completely at home in the west of Ireland — may self-establish naturally in or beside garden ponds.

W11. Common Butterwort (*Pinguicula vulgaris*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Permanently wet, acidic, nutrient-poor bog or fen conditions; pH 4.5–6.0. Native to Irish and British bogs, fens, wet heaths and moors.

Soil prep: A boggy container or dedicated bog garden bed with acidic, nutrient-poor substrate (a mix of sphagnum moss, peat-free ericaceous compost and sharp sand works well) — do not add fertiliser, which harms carnivorous plants.

Planting depth: Crown at soil surface, kept permanently moist to wet.

Spacing: 10–15cm between plants.

Fertiliser: None — this is a carnivorous plant that obtains nutrients from trapped insects via sticky glandular leaves; added fertiliser damages it.

Companions: Round-leaved sundew, bog asphodel and other native bog-garden plants with the same acidic, nutrient-poor requirements.

West of Ireland: A charming native carnivorous plant with ground-hugging, star-shaped, yellow-green sticky leaf rosettes that trap and digest small insects, and single purple, funnel-shaped flowers on short stems in late spring/early summer. Overwinters as a dormant resting bud. Best suited to a dedicated boggy or acidic container rather than a conventional pond margin.

W21. Common Water Crowfoot (*Ranunculus aquatilis*)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Muddy pool margins or submerged in still or slow/fast-moving fresh water; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Aquatic compost in a basket, or root directly into pond-bottom mud.

Planting depth: Grows in muddy pool margins or fully submerged in water 15–60cm deep.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants; also suitable for a wildlife stream or slow-moving water feature.

Fertiliser: None required — a good, undemanding native oxygenator.

Companions: Hornwort, water lilies and other oxygenating/floating pond plants.

Warnings ⚠: Sap is a skin irritant and harmful if eaten — wear gloves when handling, like other buttercup-family plants.

West of Ireland: A dainty native oxygenator with two distinct leaf forms — thread-like submerged leaves and rounder floating leaves — and masses of small white, yellow-centred flowers held just above the water in May. Good in both still ponds and slow-moving streams; a valuable, easy native addition to any wildlife pond.

W12. Flowering Rush (*Butomus umbellatus*)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Fertile mud at pond margins; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Aquatic compost in a planting basket, or directly into fertile pond-margin mud.

Planting depth: Crown at soil surface; grows in up to 25cm of water at the margin.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Aquatic fertiliser tablets at the start of the growing season.

Companions: Yellow flag iris, arrowhead, bogbean and other native or near-native marginal plants.

West of Ireland: An elegant marginal with narrow, upright, rush-like leaves and umbels of fragrant, star-shaped pink flowers held on tall stems well above the water in summer. Not a true rush despite the name (it's the only member of its own family, Butomaceae). Reliably hardy and well suited to the mild, moist west of Ireland climate.

W13. Fringed Water Lily (*Nymphoides peltata*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Aquatic compost in a basket; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Aquatic compost in a planting basket.

Planting depth: Crown at basket surface; 15–90cm of water above, tolerant of a wide depth range.

Spacing: 40–60cm between plants; a vigorous spreader.

Fertiliser: Aquatic fertiliser tablets at the start of the growing season.

Companions: Water lilies, hornwort and other floating/deep-water pond plants.

Warnings ⚠️: Despite its dainty appearance, this plant spreads vigorously by surface runners and is listed as an invasive non-native species in Northern Ireland, where it is an offence to plant or cause it to grow in the wild. It is not native to Ireland and has since naturalised and become a nuisance in some waterways here. Keep it strictly contained in a basket, trim regularly, and never allow cuttings or plants to reach open watercourses.

West of Ireland: Small, waterlily-like rounded leaves (much smaller than a true *Nymphaea*) and bright yellow, fringed-petalled flowers held just above the surface in summer — useful for a smaller pond where a full-sized water lily would be too vigorous, provided it is kept firmly contained.

W14. Frogbit (*Hydrocharis morsus-ranae*)

Light: ☀️ Full sun.

Soil needs: None required — a free-floating plant with roots hanging in the water rather than anchored in soil. Prefers still, neutral to alkaline water.

Soil prep: None — simply float on the water surface.

Planting depth: Floats freely on the surface; water must be deep enough that the bottom does not freeze solid in winter, since the plant overwinters as small resting buds (turions) that sink to the bottom.

Spacing: Spreads freely by runners to cover the surface; thin out excess growth as needed.

Fertiliser: None required — takes up nutrients directly from the water.

Companions: Water soldier, native water lilies and other floating-leaved plants; helps shade the water and reduce algae.

West of Ireland: A dainty native-range floating plant with small, glossy, heart-shaped leaves and tiny three-petalled white flowers in summer — a good, well-behaved native-range alternative to non-native floating plants like water hyacinth (see note under that entry). Good for softening the pond surface in a small to medium pond without the vigour of larger floating-leaved plants.

W15. Greater Bladderwort (*Utricularia vulgaris*)

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

Soil needs: None — a rootless, free-floating submerged aquatic. Prefers still or slow-moving, still, nutrient-poor to moderate fresh water.

Soil prep: None required — floats freely just below the surface.

Planting depth: Fully submerged, typically in still, reasonably deep water; rises to the surface to flower.

Spacing: Allow to spread loosely through the water; thin congested growth if it becomes too dense.

Fertiliser: None — this carnivorous plant catches tiny aquatic invertebrates using small bladder-like traps on its feathery, finely divided leaves.

Companions: Native oxygenators and floating plants such as frogbit and hornwort.

West of Ireland: A fascinating native carnivorous aquatic found in ponds, ditches and slow streams throughout Ireland, with attractive spikes of yellow, snapdragon-like flowers held above the water in summer. Entirely rootless and free-floating, it needs no planting at all — simply introduce it to the pond. A great talking-point plant for a wildlife pond.

W16. Hornwort (*Ceratophyllum demersum*)

Light: ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

Soil needs: None required — a rootless, free-floating or loosely anchored submerged oxygenator, suitable for a wide range of water chemistry.

Soil prep: None — simply place in the pond; it takes up nutrients directly from the water rather than through roots.

Planting depth: Fully submerged; suitable for deep water.

Spacing: Introduce a bunch or two per square metre of pond surface; thin out if it becomes congested.

Fertiliser: None required — a very effective oxygenator that actually helps remove excess nutrients from the water, reducing algae.

Companions: Water lilies, frogbit and other pond plants; an excellent shelter plant for fish fry and pond invertebrates.

West of Ireland: One of the best all-round oxygenating plants for an Irish pond — fast-growing, hardy, and easy, with dark green, bristly, whorled foliage. Forms overwintering buds (turions) that sink to the pond floor in autumn and regrow the following spring. A great, low-fuss choice for keeping pond water clear and healthy.

W17. Lotus (*Nelumbo* spp.)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — the more warmth and sun the better.

Soil needs: Heavy clay loam enriched with well-rotted manure or compost, in a large container rather than open pond soil — never use standard potting compost, which floats.

Soil prep: Fill a large container (minimum 60cm across for a proper display) with heavy loam-based aquatic soil. A dedicated container within the pond, rather than open ground, lets the water around the lotus warm up faster — the main limiting factor for lotus in Ireland.

Planting depth: Plant the brittle tuber horizontally just under the soil surface, handling it very carefully at the growing tips. Start in shallow water (around 5–15cm above the soil) and increase gradually to 30–60cm as growth proceeds; smaller/dwarf "bowl lotus" cultivars need only 15–22cm.

Spacing: One tuber per container; the roots can travel widely if planted directly in open pond soil, so containment is strongly recommended.

Fertiliser: Aquatic fertiliser tablets or slow-release pond tabs pushed into the soil every few weeks through the growing season, following the product's application rate.

Companions: Best grown alone in its own container rather than mixed with other marginals, given its vigorous spreading roots if not contained.

Pot/container: ☒ Essential, not optional, in this climate — a large container acts as a self-contained mini-pond that warms faster than the main pond. In cold areas, lower the container to the deepest part of the pond for winter, or move it to a frost-free space, keeping the rhizome just moist.

West of Ireland: Genuinely winter-hardy (the rhizome survives cold, even to RHS H7 for *N. nucifera*), but flowering is unreliable here — the real obstacle is the west of Ireland's lack of sustained summer heat rather than winter cold, since lotus need several months of warm water (around 20°C+) to flower well. *Nelumbo lutea* (American yellow lotus) and compact "bowl lotus" cultivars are the more realistic choices for a cooler climate, and even then, treat flowering as a bonus rather than a certainty — the bold, rounded leaves held above the water are attractive in their own right even without bloom.

W18. Mare's Tail (*Hippuris vulgaris*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Shallow water or permanently wet mud; prefers non-acidic (neutral to alkaline) water, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Aquatic compost in a basket, or plant directly into pond-margin mud.

Planting depth: Crown at soil surface; grows in shallow water or wet mud at the margin, with foliage held upright above the surface.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; spreads by creeping rhizomes and can be vigorous in favourable conditions — contain in a basket in a small pond.

Fertiliser: Aquatic fertiliser tablets at the start of the growing season.

Companions: Water mint, water forget-me-not and other native marginal plants.

West of Ireland: A distinctive native marginal with upright, bottle-brush-like stems of narrow leaves in whorls, resembling a miniature conifer or horsetail (though unrelated to true horsetails). Fully hardy and easy in the mild, moist Irish climate; keep contained in a basket in smaller ponds, as it can spread readily.

W4. Marsh Marigold (*Caltha palustris*)

Irish / Russian: *Lus buí Bealtaine* · Калужница болотная

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Permanently moist to wet soil, or shallow water; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates heavy clay very well.

Soil prep: Little needed — thrives in the wet margins many other plants struggle with.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level, in boggy ground or shallow water 0–10cm deep (in an aquatic basket if planted directly in a pond).

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required in a natural pond margin; balanced aquatic fertiliser tablet if grown in a basket.

Companions: Yellow flag iris, bogbean, ferns — classic pond-margin planting.

West of Ireland: Cheerful, bright yellow, buttercup-like flowers in spring at the water's edge; one of the easiest and most reliable native pond-margin perennials for the consistently damp west of Ireland climate.

W5. Marsh Orchids (*Dactylorhiza* spp.)

Russian: Пальчатокоренник

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌂 partial shade, provided the soil stays consistently moist.

Soil needs: Consistently moist, humus-rich soil; slightly acid to neutral (some species tolerate alkaline), pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leafy compost; avoid manure or very rich feeds, which encourage weeds and disrupt the orchid's root/fungal relationship. Never allow the site to dry out, especially in the growing season.

Planting depth: Tubers 5–8cm deep, or plant nursery-grown pot plants at pot level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; buy nursery stock only

Fertiliser: Little to none required — rich feeding is unhelpful and can encourage competing weeds.

Companions: Damp meadow and pond-margin planting with yellow flag iris, meadowsweet, ragged robin.

West of Ireland: Several marsh orchid species are native to Ireland, found in damp meadows, fens and dune slacks. Always buy nursery-propagated plants (never collected from the wild) and give them a permanently moist, undisturbed spot — a damp meadow area or pond margin suits them far better than a conventional border.

W6. Meadowsweet (*Filipendula ulmaria*)

Irish / Russian: Airgead luachra · Лабазник вязолистный

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌂 partial shade. Does best in a humus-rich moist well-drained soil in semi-shade or in full sun if the soil is kept moist throughout the growing season. It does not tolerate dry or acid soils; however, it does grow well in heavy clay soils.

Soil needs: Moist, fertile soil. Meadowsweet prefers a pH level between 5.0 and 6.5. If your soil is heavy or clay-based, amend it with organic matter to improve drainage. Ideal for boggy areas, pond edges, and consistently damp borders.

Soil prep: For in-ground planting, dig in generous compost. No grit needed — meadowsweet actually prefers moisture-retentive conditions. For very wet areas, plant directly without amendment.

Planting depth: Simply bury the roots up to the crown of the stem in rich soil. Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 60cm between plants; can self-seed

Fertiliser: Feed in spring with a balanced fertiliser to encourage vigorous growth. Deadhead spent flowers to prolong bloom, and cut back the stems to ground level after flowering to keep the plant tidy and encourage fresh foliage. Annual compost mulch. Low-maintenance overall.

Companions: Yellow flag iris, bogbean, royal fern, astilbe, primulas at pond margins or in damp borders. Borders (rear), naturalized areas, wet meadows or moist areas along streams or ponds. Attracts butterflies, bees and beneficial insects very effectively.

West of Ireland: Meadowsweet is native throughout Ireland and wildly abundant in wet western meadows, roadside ditches, and riverside habitats. It is perfectly adapted to the Irish climate and particularly thrives in the wet conditions of the west. One of the most rewarding native plants for a damp or boggy garden.

W19. Ragged Robin (*Lychnis flos-cuculi*, syn. *Silene flos-cuculi*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌂 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist, moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. A damp-meadow and pond-margin native, not for standing water.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost if very heavy; otherwise minimal preparation needed given its native tolerance of damp Irish ground.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level, or surface-sow seed in March/April.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Little required; enrich the planting hole with organic matter at planting.

Companions: Meadowsweet, yellow flag iris and marsh orchids in a damp meadow or pond-margin planting.

West of Ireland: A pretty native perennial wildflower of damp meadows and pond margins, with slender stems bearing star-shaped, deeply fringed rose-pink flowers in late spring and early summer. Easy and reliable in the moist Irish climate; deadhead to prolong flowering and cut back after flowering to keep tidy.

W20. Round-leaved Sundew (*Drosera rotundifolia*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

Soil needs: Permanently wet, acidic, nutrient-poor bog conditions — typically grows directly in living sphagnum moss; pH 4.0–5.5.

Soil prep: A boggy container or bed with a mix of sphagnum moss, peat-free ericaceous compost and sharp sand, kept permanently saturated with rainwater (not tap water, which is too alkaline/mineral-rich for this plant).

Planting depth: Crown at soil surface, kept permanently wet.

Spacing: 10–15cm between plants.

Fertiliser: None — a carnivorous plant that traps small insects on sticky, glandular, reddish, round leaves arranged in a basal rosette; added fertiliser harms it.

Companions: Common butterwort, bog asphodel and other native acid-bog plants.

West of Ireland: One of Ireland's most widespread native carnivorous plants, found almost anywhere sphagnum moss grows on Irish bogs. Small white flowers appear on a thin stem above the leaf rosette in summer. Best suited to a dedicated boggy, acidic container rather than a conventional pond, and an excellent addition to a native bog garden.

W22. Water Forget-me-not (*Myosotis scorpioides*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

Soil needs: Wet soil at pool margins or in shallow water; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Aquatic compost in a basket, or plant directly into wet margin soil.

Planting depth: Crown at soil surface, in wet soil or water no deeper than 10cm.

Spacing: 15–30cm between plants; expands gradually by creeping rhizomes without being invasive.

Fertiliser: Little required — an easy, low-maintenance native/near-native marginal.

Companions: Yellow flag iris, marsh marigold, bogbean and other pond-margin plants; a classic combination for disguising the edge of a pond liner.

West of Ireland: Reliably perennial (unlike border forget-me-nots, which are usually biennial), with sprays of sky-blue, yellow-eyed flowers held above shiny green foliage from May to July. Excellent for wildlife — bees and hoverflies visit the flowers, and newts use the leaves to wrap their eggs. Ideal for softening the pond edge in a naturalistic Irish pond.

W7. Water Lilies (*Nymphaea* spp.)

Species	Latin name	Height	Flowering	Planting depth	Notes
Native White Water Lily	<i>N. alba</i>	Leaves float; flowers just above surface	Summer	Start 20–30cm, lower gradually to 90–150cm	Ireland's only true native water lily; vigorous — large ponds/lakes only, not for small garden ponds
Bohemian/Shining Water Lily	<i>N. candida</i>	Leaves float; flowers just above surface	June–August	20–50cm (RHS: start 15–25cm, lower gradually to 50–60cm)	Small hardy species lily with white, yellow-stamened flowers; ideal for small ponds, tubs and half-barrels
Hardy hybrid water lilies	<i>N. × hybrida</i> and other garden hybrids	Leaves float; flowers just above surface	Summer–early autumn	15–90cm+ depending on cultivar vigour	The many popular garden-bred hardy hybrids (white, pink, yellow, red); choose a cultivar matched to your pond's depth and size

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for all — needs maximum sunshine for flowers to open. Plant in the sunniest spot in the pond.

Soil needs: Aquatic compost in mesh baskets for all. Loamy, clay-based aquatic soil is ideal. Do not use multipurpose/garden compost (too rich — promotes algae). Cover with lime-free pea gravel.

Water depth: *N. alba*: best grown about 1 metre deep, but can grow in up to 3 metres if allowed to adjust very gradually; start shallower (20–30cm) and lower gradually. *N. candida*: much shallower, 20–50cm once established — ideal for small ponds and even large tubs. Hardy hybrids: depth depends entirely on the cultivar's vigour, from compact varieties suited to 15–30cm to vigorous types wanting 60–90cm or more — check the specific cultivar's label.

Basket size: *N. alba*: at least 22cm across initially, potting up to 30–40cm+ as it grows — suitable for large ponds and lakes only. *N. candida*: a small 2L basket is often sufficient given its modest size. Hardy hybrids: size the basket to the cultivar, typically 20–40cm.

Planting: Plant the rhizome level with the top of the aquatic compost for all. Top with lime-free pea gravel. Place the basket in the pond at a shallow depth first, then lower gradually to final depth as leaves grow.

Fertiliser: Feed during the growing season with a proprietary aquatic fertiliser at the manufacturer's recommended rate for all species. Use only aquatic fertiliser tablets pushed into the compost — never loose fertiliser into pond water (causes algae bloom). Feed at the start of each growing season.

Companions: *N. alba* is Ireland's only true native water lily and pairs beautifully with Irish natives: Yellow Flag Iris, Bogbean, Bog Pimpernel and Meadowsweet at the margins. All water lily pads provide vital shade for fish and wildlife and reduce algae. Plant oxygenating plants (Hornwort, Common Water Crowfoot) in the same pond to maintain water quality.

West of Ireland: The moist, mild Atlantic climate is ideal for water lilies generally. Do not plant near a pump or fountain — water lilies require still water and must not have water splashed onto their floating leaves. For a small west of Ireland garden pond, *N. candida* or a compact hardy hybrid is a far more realistic choice than the vigorous native *N. alba*, which really needs a large pond or lake to do itself justice.

W23. Water Mint (*Mentha aquatica*)

Irish / Russian: *Miontas* · Мята

Light: ☀ Full sun to encourage flowering.

Soil needs: Muddy pool margins or shallow water; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Aquatic compost in a basket, or plant directly into pond-margin mud.

Planting depth: Crown at soil surface; grows in baskets in up to 25cm of water, or in wet margin soil.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants.

Fertiliser: Little required — vigorous once established.

Companions: Bog pimpernel, yellow flag iris and other pond-margin plants.

Warnings ⚠: Has the potential to become a nuisance if not kept in check — contain in a basket in smaller ponds and divide/thin regularly.

West of Ireland: A native aromatic marginal with whorls of small lilac-pink flowers in summer, much loved by pollinators, and highly attractive to bees. Fully hardy and thrives in the mild, moist Irish climate — the challenge here is restraining its vigour rather than keeping it alive.

W24. Water Soldier (*Stratiotes aloides*)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: None required — a free-floating submerged/floating perennial.

Soil prep: None — simply introduce to the pond.

Planting depth: Floats just below the surface in summer, rising to flower, then sinks to the bottom to overwinter; needs water deep enough not to freeze solid.

Spacing: Allow to spread; thin out congested rosettes, as it can become a nuisance in a small pool.

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Frogbit, native water lilies and other floating plants.

West of Ireland: A striking native-range plant with rosettes of stiff, sharp-edged, pineapple-like leaves and white, three-petalled summer flowers, historically common in the wet ditches and ponds of East Anglia and still found in similar habitats elsewhere. Provides good shelter and egg-laying sites for pond wildlife such as damselflies. Can spread vigorously in a small pool, so monitor and thin as needed.

W25. Water Violet (*Hottonia palustris*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: None required for the submerged form — a rootless-appearing submerged oxygenator that also produces emergent flower spikes; tolerant of most fresh water.

Soil prep: None — introduce directly to the pond; do not move or replant in summer, as it establishes best when left undisturbed.

Planting depth: Mostly submerged, with feathery foliage below the water and flower spikes emerging above in late spring/summer.

Spacing: Allow to spread loosely through the water.

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Hornwort, common water crowfoot and other native oxygenators.

West of Ireland: Despite the common name it is not a true violet, but a relative of the primrose family, with finely divided, fern-like submerged foliage and pale lilac flower spikes held above the water in late spring and early summer. A good native-range oxygenator for an Irish wildlife pond — plant in spring or autumn and leave undisturbed through summer for best results.

W26. Watershield (*Brasenia schreberi*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Aquatic soil in a basket, similar to a water lily; prefers clear, still fresh water.

Soil prep: Aquatic compost in a planting basket.

Planting depth: Floating leaves on long stalks from a rhizome rooted in mud; suitable for water broadly similar in depth to a small water lily.

Spacing: Allow room to spread; it colonises by rhizomes over time.

Fertiliser: Aquatic fertiliser tablets during the growing season, as for water lilies.

Companions: Water lilies and other floating-leaved plants, which it naturally grows alongside in the wild.

⚠ **A note on this entry:** Unlike the other plants in this guide, Watershield is not commonly available from Irish or UK nurseries and there is little documented experience of growing it in Irish garden ponds specifically. It is included here at your request, but the growing notes above are based on its general biology and North American/Asian wild-pond habitats rather than proven Irish cultivation, so treat them as a starting point rather than a guarantee.

West of Ireland: A curious floating-leaved perennial with small oval leaves resembling miniature water lily pads (but without the characteristic split), reddish-purple beneath, and small, inconspicuous maroon flowers in summer. If you do manage to source it, it is best treated as an experimental addition to a mature, well-established pond alongside true water lilies.

W27. Willow Moss (*Fontinalis antipyretica*)

Light: 🌤 Partial shade to ☀ full sun.

Soil needs: None required — an aquatic moss best attached to a submerged stone or piece of wood rather than planted in soil.

Soil prep: Tie or wedge a clump onto a stone or log and submerge; the moss will attach itself naturally over time.

Planting depth: Fully submerged; also suitable for a stream or moving-water feature.

Spacing: Space attached stones/clumps as desired; spreads slowly to cover the surface it is attached to.

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Hornwort, common water crowfoot and other native oxygenators in a wildlife pond or stream feature.

West of Ireland: A native aquatic moss forming dark green, feathery submerged mats on stones, logs or the sides of streams and ponds. Excellent for a naturalistic wildlife pond or a garden stream feature, providing shelter for invertebrates and helping oxygenate the water. Thrives in the consistently damp, mild Irish climate.

W9. Yellow Loosestrife (*Lysimachia vulgaris*)

Irish / Russian: Breallán léana (Breallán dlúth) · Вербейник обыкновенный

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist to wet soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates heavy clay very well.

Soil prep: Little needed — thrives in damp ground.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 40–50cm between plants; spreads by rhizome

Fertiliser: Little required in reasonably fertile damp ground.

Companions: Meadowsweet, yellow flag iris, marsh marigold — classic pond-margin/damp border companions.

West of Ireland: Tall, upright spikes of bright yellow flowers in summer at the water's edge; spreads by rhizomes to form good-sized clumps in consistently damp ground, so give it room or a contained spot in a smaller pond margin.

W28. Yellow Water Lily (*Nuphar lutea*)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

Soil needs: Aquatic compost in a basket; tolerates still or slow-moving water.

Soil prep: Aquatic compost in a large planting basket — this is a big, vigorous plant, not suited to small garden ponds.

Planting depth: Crown at basket surface; 45–150cm of water above, and can spread into much deeper water (2–5m) over time.

Spacing: 1–2m ultimate spread; large ponds and lakes only.

Fertiliser: Aquatic fertiliser tablets at the start of the growing season.

Companions: Native white water lily, bogbean and other deep-water/marginal natives, though give it plenty of room given its vigour.

West of Ireland: A robust native plant useful where water is too deep, too shaded or too disturbed (e.g. by moving water) for a true water lily to thrive, with rounded floating leaves and rather small, ball-shaped yellow flowers held just above the surface in summer. Not for a small garden pond — this is a plant for a large, naturalistic pond or lake margin.

COMPLETE REFERENCE TABLE

(Sorted alphabetically by English name across all groups; ID prefix shows which group each plant belongs to.)

Light: ☀ = full sun | 🌤 = sun/partial shade | ☁ = partial shade preferred | 🌑 = shade tolerant/full shade In Pot?: ✅ = excellent/recommended | ⚠ = possible with care | ❌ = not suitable Pot size given where relevant

#	English Name	Latin Name	pH	Planting Depth	In Pot?	Light	Key Companions	Spacing
T21	Acacia baileyana 'Purpurea'	<i>Acacia baileyana</i> 'Purpurea'	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠ Large container, borderline hardy	☀	Rosemary, lavender	3–4m between plants
B1	Acidanthera / Abyssinian Gladiolus	<i>Gladiolus murielae</i>	6.0–7.0	10–16cm on bed of sharp sand; spring	✅ 30cm / 15L+	☀	Salvias, gladioli, dahlias, ornamental grasses	15–20cm between corms
P22	Aconitum (Monkshood)	<i>Aconitum napellus</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	⚠ 20–30L container	☁ to ☀	Delphiniums, hostas, astilbe	45–60cm between plants; ⚠ toxic, wear gloves
P26	Adonis	<i>Adonis vernalis</i>	6.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	☀ to ☁	Snowdrops, hellebores	20–30cm between plants; ⚠ toxic
G35	Adriatic Bellflower	<i>Campanula garganica</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀ to ☁	Sempervivum, saxifrage, dianthus pinks	15–20cm between plants
B16	Allium	<i>Allium</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	10–15cm deep (2–3× bulb depth); autumn	✅ 5L+ per bulb cluster	☀	Roses, peonies, irises, ornamental grasses	10–20cm between bulbs depending on variety
B30	Allium 'Nigrum'	<i>Allium multibulbosum</i> 'Nigrum' (<i>A. nigrum</i>)	6.0–7.5	15cm deep (2–3× bulb depth); autumn	✅ Large 5L+ container	☀	Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses	20–25cm between bulbs
F22	Almond	<i>Prunus dulcis</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark; graft above soil	⚠ Large container	☀	Chives, garlic; spring bulbs	4–6m free-standing; 4–5m fan-trained
P47	Alstroemeria	<i>Alstroemeria</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	15–20cm deep (tubers)	✅ 15–20L container	☀ to 🌤	Roses, geraniums, salvias	30–45cm between plants
F1	Apple	<i>Malus domestica</i>	6.0–7.0	Graft union at/above soil	⚠ Half-barrel (50L+) on dwarfing rootstock	☀	Chives, garlic, nasturtiums	Depends on rootstock; cvs. 'Baya Marisa', Cox's Orange Pippin, White Transparent, 'Granny Smith', Antonovka, Grushovka Moskovskaya
P6	Aquilegia (Columbine)	<i>Aquilegia vulgaris</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 15–20L container	☀ to ☁	Foxgloves, hardy geraniums, roses	30–45cm between plants; self-seeds freely
G20	Arabis 'Old Gold'	<i>Arabis ferdinandi-coburgi</i> 'Old Gold'	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀	Aubretia, alyssum, spring bulbs	30–40cm between plants
W10	Arrowhead	<i>Sagittaria sagittifolia</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil surface; up to 20cm water above	✅ Aquatic basket or pond-bottom mud	☀ to 🌤	Yellow flag iris, bogbean, flowering rush	30–45cm between plants
P48	Aruncus aethusifolius	<i>Aruncus aethusifolius</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	☁	Astilbe, hostas, ferns, primroses	30–40cm between plants
P1	Astilbe	<i>Astilbe</i> spp.	5.5–7.0	At pot level; crown at surface	✅ 40–50cm / 30L+	☁	Hostas, ferns, hellebores, primulas	30–45cm between plants
P2	Auricula	<i>Primula auricula</i>	6.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 3–5L pot/trough	☁	Saxifrage, sempervivum, other alpinas	15–20cm between plants
T31	Balsam Fir	<i>Abies balsamea</i>	5.0–6.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠ Large container for dwarf cultivars	☀ to ☁	Ferns, hostas	4–6m; dwarf cultivars much closer
T1	Bamboo (clump-forming)	<i>Fargesia</i> / <i>Chusquea</i> spp.	5.5–7.0	At pot level	⚠ Very large tub (100L+)	🌤	Ferns, hostas, astilbe	1.5–3m from structures; root barrier for running types

#	English Name	Latin Name	pH	Planting Depth	In Pot?	Light	Key Companions	Spacing
P3	Bearded Iris (Border Iris)	<i>Iris germanica</i>	6.5–7.5	Rhizome at/just above soil surface	⚠️ Wide shallow container, 30L+	☀️	Roses, peonies, alliums	30–45cm between rhizomes; divide every 3–4 yrs
G16	Bell Heather	<i>Erica cinerea</i>	4.5–6.5	At pot level	✅ 20–25cm / 5–10L ericaceous compost	☀️	Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses	30–45cm between plants
T25	Black Locust	<i>Robinia pseudoacacia</i> 'Frisia'	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ Large container for young trees	☀️	Shade-tolerant bulbs and perennials	6–8m between plants
G32	Black Mondo Grass	<i>Ophiopogon planiscapus</i> 'Niger'	5.5–7.0	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️ to 🌙	Sedum 'Angelina', golden sedges	20–25cm between plants
F2	Blackberries	<i>Rubus fruticosus</i> agg.	5.5–7.0	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ 40–50L container against support	☀️ to 🌙	Raspberries, other cane fruit	2–3m between plants against wires
F3	Blackcurrant	<i>Ribes nigrum</i>	6.0–7.0	5–7cm deeper than nursery mark	⚠️ 30L+ large pot	☀️	Alliums, garlic, nasturtiums, redcurrant	1.2–1.5m between plants
P42	Blue Fescue	<i>Festuca glauca</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 15–20L container	☀️	Sedum, echinacea, rudbeckia	25–35cm between plants
P4	Blue Gentian	<i>Gentiana</i> spp.	5.5–6.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️ to 🌙	Heather, dwarf conifers, saxifrage	20–30cm between plants
F4	Blueberry	<i>Vaccinium corymbosum</i>	4.0–5.5	At pot level	✅ Essential: 40–60cm / 30–50L+	☀️	Heather, lingonberry (same ericaceous trough)	1 plant per pot; 60cm between pots
W1	Bog Asphodel	<i>Narthecium ossifragum</i>	4.5–6.0	Crown at soil surface, permanently wet	⚠️ Bog garden/boggy pot only	☀️	Bogbean, bog pimpernel	20–30cm between plants; needs permanently wet acid soil
W2	Bog Pimpernel	<i>Anagallis tenella</i>	5.0–6.5	Crown at soil surface; bog margin to waterline	✅ Small shallow container at margin	☀️	Bogbean, yellow flag iris, water mint	30–40cm apart; spreads as carpet
W3	Bogbean / Buckbean	<i>Menyanthes trifoliata</i>	5.0–7.5	Roots + 5cm stem in soil; 5–25cm water above	✅ 19–24cm+ aquatic basket	☀️	White water lily, yellow flag iris, bog pimpernel	60cm between plants; spreads indefinitely without basket
W29	Bohemian Water Lily	<i>Nymphaea candida</i>	6.5–7.5 (water)	Crown just below basket surface; 20–50cm water above	✅ Small 2L basket; ideal for tubs	☀️	Bogbean, yellow flag iris, oxygenating plants	50cm spread; ideal for small ponds
T2	Border Forsythia	<i>Forsythia × intermedia</i>	6.0–8.0	At pot level	❌ Too large	☀️	Spring tulips, Vinca, holly backdrop	1.5m between; 2m from walls
A3	Briza Maxima (Quaking Grass)	<i>Briza maxima</i>	6.0–7.5	5mm deep (seed)	✅ 5L+ container	☀️	Cornflower, poppies, love-in-a-mist	15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds
G10	Campanula saxifraga	<i>Campanula saxifraga</i>	6.5–7.5	At pot level	✅ Trough/rockery, 3–5L	☀️	Sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort	15–20cm between plants
P38	Carnation (Border Carnation)	<i>Dianthus caryophyllus</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 20–25cm / 10L+	☀️	Roses, stocks, alliums, lavender	45–60cm between plants
G12	Carpathian Bellflower	<i>Campanula carpatica</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level	✅ 15–20L container	☀️ to 🌙	Sempervivum, saxifrage, dianthus pinks	25–35cm between plants
H1	Catnip	<i>Nepeta cataria</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 15–20L container	☀️ to 🌙	Brassicas, roses	30–45cm between plants
P50	Chilean Avens	<i>Geum chilense</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️ to 🌙	Alliums, irises, roses, hardy geraniums	30–40cm between plants
P39	Chinese Pink	<i>Dianthus chinensis</i>	6.5–7.5	3mm deep (seed) / at pot level	✅ 5L+ container	☀️	Cornflower, love-in-a-mist	15–20cm between plants; grow as annual/biennial

#	English Name	Latin Name	pH	Planting Depth	In Pot?	Light	Key Companions	Spacing
C2	Clematis (most)	<i>Clematis</i> spp.	6.5–7.5	10–15cm DEEPER than pot	✅ 45cm/40L+ container	☀️ (roots shaded)	Climbing roses, other clematis	60–90cm between; cool roots essential
C3	Climbing Honeysuckle	<i>Lonicera periclymenum</i>	5.5–8.0	At pot level	⚠️ 30L+ (not ideal, deep roots)	☀️	Climbing roses, clematis; near windows	1.5m between plants
C4	Climbing Hydrangea	<i>Hydrangea anomala</i> subsp. <i>petiolaris</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level	⚠️ 50L+ (not ideal)	🌑 to ☀️	Ivy, ferns, hostas, shade-tolerant plants	45cm from wall; 60cm+ between plants
C5	Climbing Roses	<i>Rosa</i> (climbing cvs.)	6.0–7.0	Graft union just below soil	⚠️ 50L+ large container	☀️	Clematis (same wall), lavender, geraniums	45cm from wall; 2–3m between plants
P5	Clustered Bellflower	<i>Campanula glomerata</i>	6.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 15–20L container	☀️ to 🌧️	Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses	30–40cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs
W11	Common Butterwort	<i>Pinguicula vulgaris</i>	4.5–6.0	Crown at soil surface, permanently wet	✅ Boggy container	☀️ to ☀️	Round-leaved sundew, bog asphodel	10–15cm between plants
S1	Common Dog Violet	<i>Viola riviniana</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✅ 5L+ container	🌧️	Primroses, wood sorrel, ferns	15–20cm between plants
T4	Common Hawthorn	<i>Crataegus monogyna</i>	5.5–7.5	At nursery soil mark	❌ Too large for pots	☀️ to ☀️	Blackthorn, holly, hazel; primroses, bluebells beneath	As hedge: 30–45cm; as tree: 4–6m from structures
G3	Common Heather / Ling	<i>Calluna vulgaris</i> (syn. <i>Erica vulgaris</i>)	4.5–6.5 (ideally 5.5)	At pot level	✅ 20–25cm / 5–10L ericaceous compost	☀️	Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses	30–45cm between plants; cv. 'Zilly' available
C16	Common Jasmine	<i>Jasminum officinale</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ Large container against support	☀️ to ☀️	Climbing roses, clematis, honeysuckle	2–3m between plants against wall/pergola
W21	Common Water Crowfoot	<i>Ranunculus aquatilis</i>	6.0–7.5	Muddy margins or submerged, 15–60cm deep	✅ Aquatic basket or pond-bottom mud	☀️	Hornwort, water lilies	30–45cm between plants
S3	Convallaria (Lily of the Valley)	<i>Convallaria majalis</i>	6.0–7.5	2–3cm deep (rhizome)	✅ 15–20L container	🌧️	Ferns, hostas, hellebores	15–20cm between plants; ⚠️ toxic, spreads
P7	Coral Bells	<i>Heuchera</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	Crown at soil level	✅ 20–30L container	🌧️	Hostas, astilbe, ferns, hellebores	30–45cm between plants
H2	Coriander	<i>Coriandrum sativum</i>	6.0–7.0	Sow 5mm deep; do not transplant	✅ 20cm+ deep / 5L+	☀️	Parsley, brassicas; away from dill & fennel	15–20cm between plants
A2	Cornflower	<i>Centaurea cyanus</i>	6.0–7.5	1–2cm deep (seed)	✅ 5L+ container	☀️	Poppies, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima	20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds
F6	Cranberry	<i>Vaccinium macrocarpon</i>	4.0–5.0	At pot level	✅ Essential: 30–45cm / 10–20L	☀️	Heather, lingonberry, blueberry (ericaceous)	30–45cm in acidic bed
G2	Creeping / Moss Phlox	<i>Phlox subulata</i>	5.5–7.7	At pot level; shoots above soil	✅ 20–30cm / 5–10L + grit	☀️	Tulips, daffodils underplanted; thyme, sedum, dianthus	30–45cm for ground cover
G1	Creeping Juniper	<i>Juniperus horizontalis</i>	4.5–8.5	At pot level or slightly raised	✅ 30–40cm/20L+	☀️ (essential)	Heather, sedum, ornamental grasses, thyme	1–1.5m for ground cover
B5	Crocus	<i>Crocus</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	7–12cm deep; autumn	✅ Excellent: 15–20cm / 3L+	☀️ (most) / ☀️	Snowdrops, daffodils, muscari, aconites	8–9cm between corms
B6	Crown Imperial	<i>Fritillaria imperialis</i>	6.5–8.0	20–30cm deep, on its side; autumn	⚠️ 40cm / 30L+ deep pot	☀️	Tulips, alliums, wallflowers, euphorbia	25cm between bulbs

#	English Name	Latin Name	pH	Planting Depth	In Pot?	Light	Key Companions	Spacing
H3	Cucumbers	<i>Cucumis sativus</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level (after frost)	✔ Large 30–40L container with support	☀	Nasturtiums, dill, sweetcorn	45–60cm between plants
B7	Daffodil	<i>Narcissus</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	15cm (3× bulb height); autumn	✔ 20–30cm / 5L+	☀	Snowdrops, tulips, forget-me-nots, Muscari	10–15cm between bulbs
G15	Dalmatian Bellflower	<i>Campanula portenschlagiana</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✔ 15–20L container	☀ to 🌤	Sempervivum, saxifrage, dianthus pinks	30–40cm between plants
P9	Daylilies	<i>Heemerocallis</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✔ 20–30L container	☀ to 🌤	Roses, ornamental grasses, yarrow	45–60cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs
S4c	Deer Fern	<i>Blechnum spicant</i>	4.5–6.0	At pot level	✔ 30cm / 10L+	🌤 to 🌑	Lingonberry, heather, foxgloves	30–45cm between plants
P10	Delphinium	<i>Delphinium</i> spp.	6.5–7.5	At pot level; buds 2–5cm below	⚠ 40–50cm / 40L+	☀	Roses, lupins, peonies, alliums	60–90cm between plants; stake essential
S8	Dicksonia antarctica (Tree Fern)	<i>Dicksonia antarctica</i>	5.5–6.5	Trunk at same depth as grown	✔ Large 50L+ container	🌤 to 🌑	Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops	1.5–3m between plants; wrap crown in hard frost
H4	Dill	<i>Anethum graveolens</i>	5.5–7.0	Sow 3–5mm deep; do not transplant	✔ 30cm+ deep / 8L+	☀	Brassicas, lettuce; away from coriander & fennel	20–30cm between plants
T32	Douglas Fir	<i>Pseudotsuga menziesii</i>	5.0–6.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠ Large container for dwarf cultivars	☀ to 🌤	Best alone (full size); conifers/heathers (dwarf)	Very large tree; use dwarf cultivars in most gardens
S5a	Drumstick Primula	<i>Primula denticulata</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✔ 10–15L container	🌤	Bluebells, wood anemones, spring bulbs	20–30cm between plants
P43	Dwarf Fountain Grass	<i>Pennisetum alopecuroides</i> 'Hameln'	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✔ 15–20L container	☀	Sedum, echinacea, rudbeckia	45–50cm between plants
B8	Dwarf Iris	<i>Iris reticulata</i>	6.0–7.5	8–10cm deep; autumn	✔ 3–5L pot/trough	☀	Snowdrops, crocus, dwarf daffodils	5–8cm between bulbs
T5	Dwarf Lily Magnolia	<i>Magnolia liliiflora</i>	5.5–6.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠ 50–80L container	☀ to ☀	Hellebores, ferns, snowdrops, Japanese maple	2–3m between plants/structures
G24	Dwarf Mondo Grass	<i>Ophiopogon japonicus</i> 'Minor'	5.5–7.0	At pot level	✔ 10–15L container	☀ to 🌤	Ferns, hostas	10–15cm between plants
T6	Dwarf Mountain Pine	<i>Pinus mugo</i> var. <i>mugo</i>	5.0–7.5	At pot level	⚠ Large gritty container	☀	Heather, dwarf junipers, sempervivum	1.5–2m between plants
P11	Edelweiss	<i>Leontopodium alpinum</i>	6.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✔ Trough/rockery, 5L	☀	Sempervivum, saxifrage, other alpine	15–20cm between plants
T26	Elder 'Black Lace'	<i>Sambucus nigra</i> 'Black Lace'	5.5–7.5	At nursery soil mark	✔ 40–50L container	☀	Golden/lime-green foliage plants	2–3m between plants
P12	Elephant's Ears	<i>Bergenia</i> spp.	5.5–8.0	Rhizome at/just below surface	✔ 25–35cm / 10L+	🌑 to ☀	Hostas, hellebores, snowdrops, ferns	30–60cm between plants
T33	English Oak	<i>Quercus robur</i>	5.0–8.0	At nursery soil mark	✗ Too large for pots	☀ to ☀	Bluebells, wood anemones	8–10m+ minimum; very large, long-lived tree
S13	Epimedium × perralchicum 'Rose Queen'	<i>E. × perralchicum</i> 'Rose Queen'	5.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✔ 10–15L container	🌤 to 🌑	Ferns, hellebores, hostas, snowdrops	30–40cm between plants

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S14	Epimedium × rubrum	<i>E. × rubrum</i>	5.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	🌄 to 🌑	Ferns, hellebores, hostas, snowdrops	30–40cm between plants
S10	Epimedium × versicolor 'Sulphureum'	<i>E. × versicolor</i> 'Sulphureum'	5.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	🌄 to 🌑	Ferns, hellebores, hostas, snowdrops	30–40cm between plants
P45	Evergold Sedge	<i>Carex oshimensis</i> 'Evergold'	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	🌄 to 🌞	Hostas, ferns, hellebores	25–35cm between plants
G22	Evergreen Candytuft	<i>Iberis sempervirens</i>	6.5–8.0	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	🌞	Aubretia, arabis, alyssum	30–45cm between plants
P44	Feather Reed Grass	<i>Calamagrostis × acutiflora</i> 'Karl Foerster'	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 20–25L container	🌞	Sedum, echinacea, rudbeckia	45–60cm between plants
F23	Fig	<i>Ficus carica</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark; restrict roots	✅ Large container (35–45cm)	🌞	Best given its own space	3–4m; cvs. 'Brown Turkey', 'Brunswick', 'White Marseilles'
C14	Five-Flavour Berry (Magnolia Vine)	<i>Schisandra chinensis</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	✅ Large 40–50L container	🌄	Climbing hydrangea, ivy	2–3m between plants against support
W12	Flowering Rush	<i>Butomus umbellatus</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil surface; up to 25cm water above	✅ Aquatic basket	🌞	Yellow flag iris, arrowhead, bogbean	30–45cm between plants
S4d	Fortune's Holly Fern (var. clivicola)	<i>Cyrtomium fortunei</i> var. <i>clivicola</i>	6.0–8.0	At pot level; crown at/just below surface	✅ 30–40cm / 15L+	🌄 to 🌑	Hostas, hellebores, snowdrops; tolerates dry shade	45–60cm between plants
B9	Fox's Grape Fritillary	<i>Fritillaria uva-vulpis</i>	6.0–7.5	10cm deep; autumn	✅ Raised bed/trough/pot	🌞 to 🌞	Other species fritillarias, dwarf iris, crocus	8–10cm between bulbs
P14	Foxglove	<i>Digitalis purpurea</i>	5.5–7.5	At pot level; seeds on surface	✅ 30cm / 10L+ deep	🌄	Ferns, hostas, roses, alliums; self-seeds	30–45cm between plants
T34	Fraser Fir	<i>Abies fraseri</i>	5.0–6.0	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ Large container for young plants	🌞 to 🌞	Ferns, hostas	4–6m between plants
B10	Freesia	<i>Freesia</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	5–8cm deep; spring, lift & store	✅ Best in containers (tender)	🌞	Ixia and other tender corms	5–8cm between corms
W13	Fringed Water Lily	<i>Nymphaoides peltata</i>	6.0–7.5 (water)	Crown at basket surface; 15–90cm water above	✅ Aquatic basket essential	🌞 to 🌞	Water lilies, hornwort	40–60cm between plants; ⚠️ vigorous, keep contained
B3	Fritillaria meleagris (Checkered Lily)	<i>Fritillaria meleagris</i>	6.0–7.0	10cm deep; autumn	✅ 5L+ container	🌞	Snowdrops, daffodils, damp border/pond-margin planting	8–10cm between bulbs
B11	Fritillaria michailovskyi	<i>Fritillaria michailovskyi</i>	6.0–7.5	8–10cm deep; autumn	✅ Trough/raised bed/pot	🌞	Dwarf iris, crocus, other alpine bulbs	8–10cm between bulbs
W14	Frogbit	<i>Hydrocharis morsus-ranae</i>	7.0–8.0 (water)	Floats freely on surface	✅ No planting needed; free-floating	🌞	Water soldier, native water lilies	Spreads freely by runners; thin as needed
T8	Fuzzy Pride-of-Rochester	<i>Deutzia scabra</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ Large 80–100L container	🌞 to 🌞	Mock orange, lilac, weigela, spring bulbs	1.5–2m between plants; grows 1.8–3m tall
B26	Gagea (Yellow Star-of-Bethlehem)	<i>Gagea lutea</i>	6.5–7.5	5–8cm deep; autumn	✅ 5L+ container	🌄	Snowdrops, wood anemones	5–8cm between bulbs
H17	Garden Cress	<i>Lepidium sativum</i>	6.0–7.5	Surface-sown or 1–1.5cm deep	✅ Tray/pot/windowsill	🌞 to 🌞	Radishes, tomatoes	Sow thickly in a broad row or tray
P27	Garden Pink	<i>Dianthus plumarius</i> (garden pinks)	5.8–6.5	At pot level	✅ 25–35cm / 10L+	🌞	Roses, stocks, alliums, lavender, Phlox subulata	25–35cm between plants

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F7	Garden Plum	<i>Prunus domestica</i>	6.0–7.0	Graft union at/above soil	⚠️ Half-barrel (50L+)	☀️	Chives, garlic, comfrey, nasturtiums	3–5m between trees depending on rootstock; permanent stake
H18	Garlic	<i>Allium sativum</i>	6.0–7.0	Tip 2.5cm below soil; autumn (or spring in modules)	✅ 20–30cm / 10L+ container	☀️	Roses, fruit trees; avoid near peas/beans	15cm between cloves; 30cm between rows
B27	Giant Onion	<i>Allium giganteum</i>	6.0–7.5	20cm deep (2–3× bulb depth); autumn	✅ Large 5L+ container	☀️	Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses	25–30cm between bulbs
T23	Ginkgo	<i>Ginkgo biloba</i>	5.0–8.0	At nursery soil mark	✅ Large container for young trees	☀️ to 🌤️	Spring bulbs, shade-tolerant perennials	6–8m between plants
B28	Golden Garlic	<i>Allium moly</i>	6.0–7.5	8–10cm deep; autumn	✅ 3–5L container	☀️	Dwarf iris, crocus, other rockery bulbs	10–15cm between bulbs
F8	Gooseberry	<i>Ribes uva-crispa</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery mark; roots 5cm	⚠️ 30L+ large pot	🌤️	Redcurrant, whitecurrant, tansy	1.5m between plants
W15	Greater Bladderwort	<i>Utricularia vulgaris</i>	6.0–7.5 (water)	Fully submerged, free-floating	✅ No planting needed; free-floating	☀️ to 🌤️	Frogbit, hornwort	Allow to spread loosely; thin if congested
H5	Green Onions (Scallions)	<i>Allium fistulosum</i>	6.0–7.0	1cm deep (seed) / at pot level	✅ 5L+ container	🌤️ to 🌤️	Carrots, rocket, radish	5–8cm between plants; sow successionally
C6	Hardy Grapes	<i>Vitis vinifera</i>	6.0–6.5	At pot depth; graft above soil	⚠️ 40L+ container	☀️ (essential)	Lavender, rosemary, garlic, hyssop	1.2–1.5m between vines; 20cm from wall
W30	Hardy Hybrid Water Lily	<i>Nymphaea × hybrida</i>	6.5–7.5 (water)	Crown at basket surface; 15–90cm+ water above depending on cultivar	✅ Basket sized to cultivar, 20–40cm	☀️	Bogbean, yellow flag iris, oxygenating plants	Spread depends on cultivar; check label
F24	Hazelnut	<i>Corylus avellana</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	❌ Too large for pots	☀️ to 🌤️	Blackthorn, hawthorn, primroses, bluebells	4–5m; 2m if coppiced hedge
P16	Hellebore / Lenten Rose	<i>Helleborus</i> spp.	6.0–8.0	At pot level; crown at/just below	✅ 25–35cm / 10L+	🌤️ to 🌑	Snowdrops, cyclamen, pulmonaria, hostas	45–60cm between plants
G25	Himalayan Bistort	<i>Persicaria affinis</i> 'Superba'	5.5–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️ to 🌤️	Ornamental grasses, sedum	30–40cm between plants
T9	Holly	<i>Ilex aquifolium</i>	4.5–8.0	At pot level (shallow roots)	⚠️ 50L+ container	🌑 to ☀️	Yew, forsythia, hellebores; plant ♂ + ♀ for berries	1.5–3m between; slow-growing hedge
F9	Honeyberry (Kamchatka)	<i>Lonicera caerulea</i> var. <i>kamtschatica</i>	4.5–7.5	At pot level	⚠️ 50–75L (15–20 gal.)	🌤️	Blueberry, lingonberry; needs 2+ varieties	1–1.5m between plants
C7	Hops	<i>Humulus lupulus</i>	6.0–8.0	Rhizome 5–8cm / pot level	✅ 50L+ large container	🌤️	Climbing roses, clematis, ornamental grasses	1–1.5m between plants
W16	Hornwort	<i>Ceratophyllum demersum</i>	6.0–8.0 (water)	Fully submerged, free-floating	✅ No planting needed; free-floating	☀️ to 🌤️	Water lilies, frogbit	Introduce 1–2 bunches per m² of pond surface
T36	Horse Chestnut	<i>Aesculus hippocastanum</i>	5.5–7.5	At nursery soil mark	❌ Too large for pots	☀️ to 🌤️	Best given its own space	10m+ minimum; very large tree
S18	Hosta 'Frances Williams'	<i>H.</i> 'Frances Williams'	5.5–7.5	At pot level; crown at surface	✅ 30–60cm / 20–50L+	🌤️ to 🌑	Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia	60–75cm between plants
S27	Hosta 'Halcyon'	<i>H.</i> × <i>tardiana</i> 'Halcyon'	5.5–7.5	At pot level; crown at surface	✅ 30–40cm / 15–20L	🌤️ to 🌑	Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia	40–50cm between plants
S19	Hosta 'Patriot'	<i>H.</i> 'Patriot'	5.5–7.5	At pot level; crown at surface	✅ 30–60cm / 20–50L+	🌤️ to 🌑	Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia	40–50cm between plants

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S17	Hosta 'Shadowland Diamond Lake'	<i>H. 'Shadowland Diamond Lake'</i>	5.5–7.5	At pot level; crown at surface	✅ 30–60cm / 20–50L+	☀️ to 🌑	Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia	40–50cm between plants
S11	Hosta 'Sieboldiana Elegans'	<i>H. sieboldiana</i> 'Elegans'	5.5–7.5	At pot level; crown at surface	✅ 30–60cm / 20–50L+	☀️ to 🌑	Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia	60–90cm between plants
S16	Hosta 'Undulata Albomarginata'	<i>H. 'Undulata Albomarginata'</i>	5.5–7.5	At pot level; crown at surface	✅ 30–60cm / 20–50L+	☀️ to 🌑	Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia	30–45cm between plants
P17	Hosta / Plantain Lily	<i>Hosta</i> spp.	6.0–8.0	At pot level; crown at surface	✅ 30–60cm / 20–50L+	☀️ to 🌑	Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia	30–90cm (variety-dependent)
T18	Hypericum 'Rowallane'	<i>Hypericum</i> 'Rowallane'	5.5–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ 40–50L container	☀️ to ☀️	Heather, skimmia, roses, late perennials	1–1.5m between plants
G18	Irish Heath	<i>Erica erigena</i>	5.5–7.5	At pot level	✅ 20–25cm / 5–10L ericaceous or multipurpose compost	☀️	Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses	45–60cm between plants
S2	Irish Native Mosses	<i>various</i> spp.	5.0–6.5 (most)	Surface transplant, not buried	✅ Shallow tray/log/pot	☀️ to 🌑	Ferns, wood sorrel, primroses	Establish as patches; keep consistently moist
T10	Irish Yew	<i>Taxus baccata</i> 'Fastigiata'	5.0–8.0	At pot level	⚠️ 50L+ container	🌑 to ☀️	Holly, peonies, roses (backdrop), hellebores	Column 1m wide eventually; 1m from structures
B12	Iron Cross (Oxalis)	<i>Oxalis tetraphylla</i> 'Iron Cross'	6.0–7.0	5cm deep; spring, lift & store	✅ 3–5L container	☀️ to ☀️	Ixia, dwarf dahlias, other summer bulbs	10–15cm between tubers; lift over winter
C8	Ivy	<i>Hedera helix</i> / <i>H. hibernica</i>	5.0–8.0	At pot level	✅ 20L+ (25–35cm pot)	🌑 to ☀️	Virginia creeper, ferns, snowdrops, bluebells	30–50cm between plants
B4	Ixia	<i>Ixia</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	8–10cm deep; spring, lift & store	✅ Best in containers (borderline hardy)	☀️	Freesia and other tender corms	5–8cm between corms
B2b	Japanese / Autumn Anemone	<i>Anemone × hybrida</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level; spring	✅ 40–50cm / 30L+	☁️	Hostas, astilbe, hellebores	45–60cm between plants; can spread
T22	Japanese Barberry	<i>Berberis thunbergii</i> 'Atropurpurea'	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	✅ 40–50L container	☀️	Golden/lime-green shrubs, spring bulbs	60–90cm hedge; 1–1.2m specimen
P54	Japanese Blood Grass	<i>Imperata cylindrica</i> 'Red Baron'	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️	Sedum, echinacea, rudbeckia	30–45cm between plants
T11	Japanese Camellia	<i>Camellia japonica</i>	5.0–6.5	At nursery soil mark	✅ 40–50L ericaceous compost	☀️	Skimmia, hydrangea macrophylla, Japanese maple	1–1.5m between plants
T20	Japanese Cedar	<i>Cryptomeria japonica</i>	5.5–6.5	At nursery soil mark	✅ Large container for dwarf cultivars	☀️ to ☁️	Japanese maple, camellia, rhododendron, ferns	4–6m between plants; dwarf cultivars 1–1.5m
T3	Japanese Flowering Cherry	<i>Prunus serrulata</i>	6.0–7.5	Graft union at/above soil	⚠️ 80–100L container	☀️	Daffodils, forget-me-nots, hostas	2.5–6m from trees/structures depending on variety; cvs. 'Kanzan', 'Shirotae', 'Kiku-shidare'
P46	Japanese Forest Grass	<i>Hakonechloa macra</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☁️	Hostas, ferns, hellebores	30–45cm between plants
T12	Japanese Maple	<i>Acer palmatum</i>	5.5–6.5	At pot level (shallow)	✅ 50–80L terracotta/stone	☀️	Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops	2–4m from structures; wind shelter essential

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S20	Japanese Painted Fern	<i>Athyrium niponicum</i> 'Metallicum'	5.5–6.5	At pot level; crown at/just below surface	✅ 30–40cm / 15L+	☁️ to 🌑	Hostas, hellebores, astilbe	30–45cm between plants
T13	Japanese Skimmia	<i>Skimmia japonica</i>	5.5–6.5	At nursery soil mark	✅ 30–40L container	🌑 to 🌞	Hellebores, ferns, hostas, Japanese maple	60–90cm between plants; ♂+♀ within a few metres for berries
P55	Japanese Water Iris 'Dinner Plate Cupcake'	<i>Iris ensata</i> 'Dinner Plate Cupcake'	5.5–6.5	Rhizome at soil level; moist to wet soil	✅ Large container, kept constantly moist	🌞 to 🌤️	Bogbean, yellow flag iris	30–40cm between plants
G26	Jenny's Stonecrop	<i>Petrosedum rupestre</i> 'Angelina'	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	🌞	Sempervivum, other sedums, ornamental grasses	20–30cm between plants
G5	Juniper 'Repanda'	<i>Juniperus communis</i> 'Repanda'	4.5–7.5	At pot level, ~15cm deep	⚠️ Large shallow container	🌞	Heather, sempervivum, saxifrage	1–1.5m for ground cover
C9	Kiwi 'Jenny'	<i>Actinidia deliciosa</i> 'Jenny'	6.0–7.0	At pot level; do not bury crown	⚠️ Min. 60–80L (better in ground)	🌞	Climbing roses, wisteria, lavender, garlic	3–5m between plants; needs permanent support
S4e	Koidzumi's Wood Fern	<i>Dryopteris koidzumiana</i>	5.5–7.0	At pot level; crown at/just below surface	✅ 40–50cm / 25–30L	☁️ to 🌑	Hostas, astilbe, hellebores, bamboo	60cm between plants
T35	Korean Fir	<i>Abies koreana</i>	5.0–6.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ Large container for young plants	🌞 to ☁️	Heather, dwarf conifers	3–4m; dwarf cvs. much closer
P18	Lady's Bedstraw	<i>Galium verum</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 5L+ container	🌞	Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wild grasses	20–30cm between plants
H6	Lavender	<i>Lavandula angustifolia</i>	6.5–8.0	At pot level	✅ Terracotta 20–30L, with grit	🌞	Roses, rosemary, thyme	30–45cm between plants
H22	Lemon Verbena	<i>Aloysia citrodora</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ Essential; move under cover for winter	🌞	Best grown alone in own container	One plant per pot; 60–90cm if grown in a bed
H19	Lemongrass	<i>Cymbopogon citratus</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ Essential; move under cover for winter	🌞	Best grown alone in own container	One plant per pot; 40–50cm if grown in a bed
T14	Lewis Mock Orange	<i>Philadelphus lewisii</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ 50L+ container	🌞 to 🌤️	Deutzia, lilac, roses, spring bulbs	1.5–2m between plants
T15	Lilac	<i>Syringa vulgaris</i>	6.5–8.0	At nursery soil mark	❌ Too large	🌞	Roses, alliums, peonies, irises	1.5m between; 2m from walls
B13	Lily	<i>Lilium</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	15cm (3× bulb height) on grit; autumn/spring	✅ 30–40cm / 15–25L	🌤️	Hostas, geraniums, roses, alliums	15–30cm between bulbs
P19	Lilyleaf Ladybells	<i>Adenophora liliifolia</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	⚠️ 20L+ container (dislikes disturbance)	🌞 to ☁️	Bellflowers, delphiniums, phlox	30–40cm between plants
P52	Limonium (Sea Lavender)	<i>Limonium</i> spp.	6.0–8.0	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	🌞	Ornamental grasses, achillea, sedum	30–45cm between plants
F10	Lingonberry	<i>Vaccinium vitis-idaea</i>	4.2–5.5	At pot level	✅ 25–30cm / 10–15L	☁️	Blueberry, heather, cranberry, deer fern	30cm between plants
P25	Linum (Perennial Flax)	<i>Linum perenne</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	🌞	Yarrow, lavender, drought-tolerant perennials	20–30cm between plants
W17	Lotus	<i>Nelumbo</i> spp.	6.0–7.0 (water)	Tuber horizontal, just under soil; 5–60cm water above	✅ Essential: large container acting as mini-pond	🌞	Best grown alone in own container	One tuber per large container

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A5	Love-in-a-Mist	<i>Nigella damascena</i>	6.0–7.5	1cm deep (seed)	✅ 5L+ container	☀️ to 🌤️	Cornflower, poppies, briza maxima	20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely
P20	Lungworts	<i>Pulmonaria</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 15–20L container	🌤️	Hellebores, ferns, hostas	30–40cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs
P21	Lupins	<i>Lupinus polyphyllus</i>	5.5–6.5	Crown at soil level	⚠️ 20L+ container (dislikes disturbance)	☀️ to 🌤️	Delphiniums, roses, foxgloves	45–60cm between plants
P40	Maiden Pink	<i>Dianthus deltoides</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 15–20cm / 5L+	☀️	Phlox subulata, sempervivum, saxifrage	20–30cm between plants
S4f	Maidenhair Fern (Himalayan)	<i>Adiantum venustum</i>	5.5–7.0	At pot level	✅ 25–30cm / 10–15L	🌤️ to 🌑	Hostas, hellebores, primroses, other woodland ferns	20–30cm between plants
S4a	Male Fern	<i>Dryopteris filix-mas</i>	5.0–7.0	Crown 7–12cm above soil	✅ 40–50cm / 30L+	🌤️ to 🌑	Hostas, astilbe, bamboo, snowdrops	60–90cm between plants
W18	Mare's Tail	<i>Hippuris vulgaris</i>	6.5–7.5	Crown at soil surface; shallow water/ wet mud	✅ Aquatic basket	☀️ to 🌤️	Water mint, water forget-me-not	20–30cm between plants
W4	Marsh Marigold	<i>Caltha palustris</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level / shallow water	✅ Aquatic basket, 3–5L	☀️ to 🌤️	Yellow flag iris, bogbean, ferns	30–40cm between plants
W5	Marsh Orchids	<i>Dactylorhiza</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	5–8cm deep (tuber) / at pot level	⚠️ Large container, kept constantly moist	☀️ to 🌤️	Yellow flag iris, meadowsweet, ragged robin	15–20cm between plants; buy nursery stock only
B14	Martagon Lily	<i>Lilium martagon</i>	6.0–7.5	15cm deep (3× bulb height); autumn/ spring	✅ Large 20L+ container	🌤️	Hostas, ferns, hellebores; light woodland edge	20–30cm between bulbs
W6	Meadowsweet	<i>Filipendula ulmaria</i>	5.0–6.5	Crown at soil level	⚠️ Large 40–50cm / 30L+	☀️ to 🌤️	Yellow flag iris, bogbean, royal fern, astilbe	60cm between plants; can self-seed
H7	Melissa (Lemon Balm)	<i>Melissa officinalis</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 15–20L container (to contain spread)	☀️ to 🌤️	Brassicas, tomatoes	30–45cm between plants; spreads readily
P41	Mexican Feather Grass	<i>Nassella tenuissima</i> (syn. <i>Stipa tenuissima</i>)	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️	Sedum, echinacea, rudbeckia	30–45cm between plants
H8	Mint	<i>Mentha</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	At pot level	✅ Essential (contains spread): 30cm / 10L+	☀️	Near brassicas/tomatoes as repellent (in pots)	60cm if in ground with root barrier
T16	Mophead / Lacecap Hydrangea	<i>Hydrangea macrophylla</i>	5.0–7.0 (blue 5.0–6.0; pink 6.0–7.0)	At pot level; rootball top slightly raised	✅ Excellent: 40cm compact / 50–60cm standard	🌤️	Astilbe, hostas, ferns, yarrow, heucheras	90cm–2.4m between (check label for variety size)
G13	Mother of Thyme	<i>Thymus serpyllum</i>	6.0–8.0	At pot level	✅ Terracotta 20cm / 5L+ with grit	☀️	Rosemary, oregano, lavender, creeping juniper	20–30cm between plants
T17	Mountain Ash (Rowan)	<i>Sorbus aucuparia</i>	5.0–7.0	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ 80–100L container	☀️ to 🌤️	Holly, hawthorn, ferns, foxgloves, hellebores	3–5m from structures
G41	Mountain/Caucasian Rock Cress	<i>Arabis caucasica</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️	Aubretia, alyssum, spring bulbs	30–45cm between plants
B29	Naples Garlic	<i>Allium cowanii</i> (syn. <i>A. neapolitanum</i>)	6.0–7.5	8–10cm deep; autumn	✅ 3–5L container	☀️	Crocus, dwarf iris, other small spring bulbs	10–15cm between bulbs

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H10	Nasturtiums	<i>Tropaeolum majus</i>	6.0–7.5	1–2cm deep (seed)	✅ 5L+ container	☀️ to 🌤️	Apples, brassicas, cucumbers (trap crop)	20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds
B15	Native Bluebells	<i>Hyacinthoides non-scripta</i>	6.0–6.8	8cm deep; autumn	✅ 5L+ container	🌧️	Ferns, hostas, primroses, wood anemones	8–10cm between bulbs
W7	Native White Water Lily	<i>Nymphaea alba</i>	6.5–7.5 (water)	Crown at soil surface in basket; start 20–30cm below water surface, lower to 90–150cm	✅ (pond basket essential): 30–40cm+ basket	☀️	Yellow flag iris, bogbean, oxygenating plants	1.5–2m between plants; large ponds only
C17	Necklace Vine (Maidenhair Vine)	<i>Muehlenbeckia complexa</i>	5.5–7.5	At nursery soil mark	✅ Large container or ground	☀️ to 🌤️	Ornamental grasses, topiary frames	1–1.5m between plants
F25	Olive	<i>Olea europaea</i>	6.0–8.5	At nursery soil mark	✅ Strongly recommended	☀️	Lavender, rosemary	2–3m between plants
H11	Oregano / Wild Marjoram	<i>Origanum vulgare</i>	6.5–8.0	At pot level	✅ 25cm / 8L+	☀️	Thyme, rosemary; pollinator attractor for fruit	30–45cm between plants
B32	Ostrowsky's Onion	<i>Allium oreophilum</i>	6.0–7.5	8–10cm deep; autumn	✅ 3–5L container	☀️	Dwarf iris, crocus, other rockery bulbs	8–10cm between bulbs
P13	Paeonia tenuifolia (Fern-leaf Peony)	<i>Paeonia tenuifolia</i>	6.5–7.5	Eyes 2–3cm below soil	⚠️ 30–40L container	☀️	Alliums, bearded iris, catmint	45–60cm between plants
P49	Pampas Grass	<i>Cortaderia selloana</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	❌ Too large for pots	☀️	Best as a solo specimen	2–3m between plants
P23	Pasqueflower	<i>Pulsatilla vulgaris</i>	6.5–8.0	At pot level; do not disturb	✅ Essential on clay: 25–30cm / 10L+	☀️	Dianthus, Eryngium, Achillea, ornamental grasses	20–30cm between plants
C1	Passiflora (Blue Passion Flower)	<i>Passiflora caerulea</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ 40–50L container against support	☀️	Climbing roses, clematis, honeysuckle	2–3m between plants against wall/fence
H20	Patio Tomatoes	<i>Solanum lycopersicum</i> (compact/dwarf cultivars)	6.0–6.8	Deep; bury to lowest leaves	✅ 30–40cm/10L+ pot; essential	☀️	Basil, marigolds, chives	One plant per 30–40cm pot
F20	Peach	<i>Prunus persica</i>	6.0–7.0	At nursery soil mark; graft above soil	✅ Large container (compact cvs.)	☀️	Chives, garlic	2–4m; cvs. 'Peregrine', 'Rochester', 'Melred'
P37	Peach-leaved Bellflower	<i>Campanula persicifolia</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 15–20L container	☀️ to 🌧️	Delphiniums, roses, lupins	30–45cm between plants; divide every 2–4 yrs
F26	Pear	<i>Pyrus communis</i>	6.0–7.5	Graft union at/above soil	✅ Container on Quince C	☀️	Chives, garlic	Depends on rootstock; cvs. 'Conference', 'Concorde', 'Doyenné du Comice'
H21	Peas	<i>Pisum sativum</i>	6.0–7.5	Sow 2–5cm deep	✅ 30–40cm / 10L+ container	☀️	Carrots, radishes, cucumbers, beans	5–7cm between seeds; 45–60cm between rows
P24	Peony (herbaceous) ⚠️	<i>Paeonia</i> spp.	6.5–7.0	Eyes MAX 2.5–5cm below soil	⚠️ 50L+ large tub	☀️ to 🌤️	Alliums, irises, salvia, roses, foxgloves	90cm between plants
H23	Peppermint	<i>Mentha × piperita</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level	✅ 30cm+ container (or root barrier)	🌤️	Roses, brassicas, tomatoes	45–60cm between plants; ⚠️ vigorous
G6	Periwinkle	<i>Vinca minor</i> / <i>V. major</i>	5.5–8.0	At pot level	✅ 25–35cm / 10L+	🌑 to ☀️	Hellebores, snowdrops, ivy; under trees/shrubs	30–45cm between plants; can spread
B17	Persian Fritillary	<i>Fritillaria persica</i>	6.5–8.0	15–20cm deep, on its side; autumn	⚠️ Large gritty container	☀️	Tulips, alliums, euphorbia	20–25cm between bulbs
B18	Persian Ranunculus	<i>Ranunculus asiaticus</i>	6.0–7.0	5–8cm deep; claws down; spring, lift & store	✅ Better in pots: 25–30cm / 10L+	🌤️	Pansies, muscari, spring anemones	15–20cm between tubers

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A4	Phacelia	<i>Phacelia tanacetifolia</i>	6.0–7.5	1cm deep (seed)	✅ 5L+ container	☀️	Vegetable beds, fruit trees (pollinator support)	20–30cm between plants; annual, sow successionally
G21	Pickle Plant	<i>Delosperma echinatum</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️	Sempervivum, saxifrage	20–30cm between plants
B33	Pineapple Lily	<i>Eucomis</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	10–15cm deep; spring	✅ Large container ideal	☀️	Alliums, crocosmia, dahlias	25–30cm between bulbs
F11	Plum Tree 'Aprimira'	<i>Prunus domestica</i> 'Aprimira'	6.0–7.0	Top of rootball just below surface	✅ 25cm+ pot, standard form	☀️	Chives, garlic	1–1.5m from structures; self-fertile
F12	Pomegranate	<i>Punica granatum</i>	5.5–7.0	At nursery soil mark	✅ Large 50L+ container, movable	☀️	Passiflora, grapevine on same warm wall	2–3m against wall; borderline hardy, best in a container
A6	Poppies	<i>Papaver rhoeas</i>	6.0–7.5	Surface-sown (seed)	✅ 5L+ container	☀️	Cornflower, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima	15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely
G7	Prickly Heath	<i>Gaultheria mucronata</i>	4.5–6.0	At nursery soil mark	✅ 20–30L ericaceous compost	☀️ to 🌧️	Heather, blueberry, lingonberry, dwarf conifers	45–60cm between plants; ♂+♀ for berries
S5	Primroses	<i>Primula vulgaris</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	🌧️	Bluebells, wood anemones, violets, ferns	20–25cm between plants
B31	Purple-flowered Onion	<i>Allium atropurpureum</i>	6.0–7.5	20cm deep (2–3× bulb depth); autumn	✅ Large 5L+ container	☀️	Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses	25–30cm between bulbs
H12	Radish	<i>Raphanus sativus</i>	6.0–7.0	1cm deep (seed)	✅ 5L+ container	☀️ to 🌧️	Carrots, lettuce, green onions	2–3cm between plants; sow successionally
W19	Ragged Robin	<i>Lychnis flos-cuculi</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level; damp meadow, not standing water	✅ 10–15L container	☀️ to 🌧️	Meadowsweet, yellow flag iris, marsh orchids	30–45cm between plants
F13	Raspberry	<i>Rubus idaeus</i>	5.8–6.5	Crown 5–7cm below soil	❌	☀️	Garlic, marigolds, tansy; away from potatoes	45–60cm between canes; 1.8m between rows
C15	Red-Flowered Magnolia Vine	<i>Schisandra rubriflora</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	✅ Large 40–50L container	🌧️	Climbing hydrangea, ivy	2–3m between plants against support
F14	Redcurrant	<i>Ribes rubrum</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery mark; roots 5cm	⚠️ 30L+ large pot	🌧️ (north fence ok)	Gooseberry, whitecurrant	1.5m between plants
G8	Reindeer Lichen	<i>Cladonia rangiferina</i>	4.0–5.5	Surface only, not buried	⚠️ Shallow tray/rockery	☀️ to 🌧️	Heather, sempervivum, open heath planting	Establishes slowly; avoid disturbance
F15	Rhubarb	<i>Rheum</i> × <i>hybridum</i>	6.0–7.0	Buds 1–2cm below soil	⚠️ 50cm / 50L+ deep pot	☀️	Beans, peas nearby; away from fennel	90cm between crowns
H13	Rocket	<i>Eruca sativa</i>	6.0–7.0	1cm deep (seed)	✅ 5L+ container	☀️ to 🌧️	Radish, green onions, lettuce	15–20cm between plants; sow successionally
G40	Rose/Coast Rock Cress	<i>Arabis blepharophylla</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️	Aubretia, alyssum, spring bulbs	20–25cm between plants
H14	Rosemary	<i>Salvia rosmarinus</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ Terracotta 20–30L, with grit	☀️	Brassicas, carrots, beans, thyme, lavender	45–60cm between plants
W20	Round-leaved Sundew	<i>Drosera rotundifolia</i>	4.0–5.5	Crown at soil surface, permanently wet	✅ Boggy container	☀️ to 🌧️	Common butterwort, bog asphodel	10–15cm between plants
S6	Round-Lobed Hepatica	<i>Hepatica nobilis</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	🌧️	Snowdrops, hellebores, wood anemones	15–20cm between plants
S4b	Royal Fern	<i>Osmunda regalis</i>	4.5–6.5	Crown slightly above soil	❌ Too large	☀️ to 🌧️	Hostas, iris, marginal aquatics, bamboo	1–1.5m between plants

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P8	Rudbeckia 'Goldball'	<i>Rudbeckia laciniata</i> 'Goldball'	5.5–7.0	At pot level	⚠️ 40–50cm / 40L+ (very tall — better in ground)	☀️	Helenium, echinacea, salvias, ornamental grasses, asters	60–90cm between; divide every 2–3 yrs
G9	Saxifrage	<i>Saxifraga</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ Trough/rockery, 3–5L	☀️ to 🌧️	Sempervivum, campanula saxifraga, dwarf bulbs	15–20cm between plants
T37	Scots Pine	<i>Pinus sylvestris</i>	4.5–7.0	At nursery soil mark	❌ Too large for pots	☀️	Heather, gorse	6–10m between plants
H15	Scurvy Grass	<i>Cochlearia officinalis</i>	6.5–7.5	At pot level / surface-sown seed	✅ 5L+ container	☀️ to 🌧️	Sea kale, coastal edible plants	15–20cm between plants
G4	Sempervivum	<i>Sempervivum</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✅ Shallow pot/trough, 3–5L	☀️	Saxifrage, wall pennywort, thyme, sedum	10–15cm between rosettes
F16	Serviceberry	<i>Amelanchier lamarckii</i>	5.5–7.0	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ 50–80L container	☀️ to 🌧️	Hellebores, snowdrops, ferns, Japanese maple	2–4m between plants/structures
T27	Shrubby Cinquefoil	<i>Potentilla fruticosa</i> (incl. var. <i>aurea</i>)	5.5–8.0	At nursery soil mark	✅ 20–30L container	☀️	Lavender, catmint, ornamental grasses	60–90cm hedge; 1m specimen
P35	Siberian Iris	<i>Iris sibirica</i>	5.8–7.0	Rhizome at/just below surface (2–3cm max)	✅ 35–40cm / 15–20L	☀️ to 🌧️	Astilbe, hostas, yellow flag iris, daylilies, royal fern	30–45cm between plants; divide every 3–5 yrs
P28	Siberian Statice	<i>Goniolimon tataricum</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 15–20L container	☀️	Ornamental grasses, achillea, sedum	30–40cm between plants
G23	Siskiyow Lewisia	<i>Lewisia cotyledon</i>	6.0–7.0	Rosette proud of soil, grit collar	✅ Trough/rockery, 3–5L	☀️ to 🌧️	Sempervivum, saxifrage, houseleek	20–25cm between plants
T24	Smooth Sumac	<i>Rhus glabra</i> 'Laciniata'	5.5–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ Large container, controls suckering	☀️	Ornamental grasses	2–3m between plants
B19	Snowdrop	<i>Galanthus nivalis</i>	5.5–7.0	10cm dry (autumn) / at growing depth in the green (spring)	✅ 20–25cm / 5L+	🌧️ to 🌑	Hellebores, aconites, early narcissus, cyclamen coum	8–10cm between bulbs
B20	Snowflake (Summer)	<i>Leucojum aestivum</i>	5.5–7.0	8–10cm deep; autumn	✅ 30–40cm / 15L+	☀️	Daffodils, snowdrops, hellebores; pond edges	8–10cm between bulbs
P53	Society Garlic	<i>Tulbaghia violacea</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️	Lavender, rosemary	25–30cm between plants
T7	Sorbaria sorbifolia	<i>Sorbaria sorbifolia</i>	5.5–7.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠️ 40–50L container	☀️ to 🌧️	Hydrangea, deutzia; good bank stabiliser	1–1.5m between plants; spreads by suckers
F21	Sour Cherry	<i>Prunus cerasus</i>	5.5–7.5	Graft union at/above soil	✅ Large container	☀️ to 🌧️	Chives, garlic	Up to 4m; cvs. 'Morello', 'Nabella', 'Kentish Red'
P29	Spreading Bellflower	<i>Campanula patula</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level / surface-sown seed	✅ 10–15L container	☀️ to 🌧️	Ox-eye daisy, wild grasses	20–30cm between plants; biennial/short-lived
B2a	Spring Anemone	<i>Anemone blanda</i> / <i>A. nemorosa</i>	5.5–7.0	5–8cm deep; autumn	✅ 20–25cm / 5L+	🌧️	Snowdrops, bluebells, foxgloves	10cm between corms
B21	Spring Sowbread (Cyclamen)	<i>Cyclamen coum</i>	6.0–7.5	2–3cm deep, flat side down; late summer/autumn	✅ 3–5L container	🌧️	Snowdrops, winter aconite, hellebores	10–15cm between tubers
S7	St Patrick's Cabbage	<i>Saxifraga spathularis</i>	5.0–6.0	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container/rockery	🌧️ to 🌑	Ferns, native mosses, shaded rockery plants	15–20cm between plants
T19	Star Magnolia	<i>Magnolia stellata</i>	5.0–6.5	At pot level; no deeper	✅ 80–100L stone/terracotta	☀️	Snowdrops, daffodils, hellebores, hardy geraniums	2.5m spread; shelter from N/E winds

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P30	Stocks	<i>Matthiola incana</i> / <i>M. longipetala</i>	6.5–7.5	At pot level; seeds on surface	✅ 25–30cm / 10L+	☀️	Wallflowers, sweet William, pansies	20–30cm between plants
F17	Strawberry	<i>Fragaria × ananassa</i>	5.5–6.8	Crown exactly at soil level	✅ 30–35cm / 15–20L per plant	☀️	Borage, garlic, chives, marigolds	30–45cm between plants
F5	Sweet Cherry	<i>Prunus avium</i>	5.5–7.5	Graft union at/above soil (own-root cvs. at pot level)	✅ 30–40cm+ container	☀️	Chives, garlic	1–4m depending on rootstock; cvs. 'Athos', 'Stella', 'Sunburst', 'Lapins', 'Sweetheart', 'Sylvia'
A7	Sweet Peas	<i>Lathyrus odoratus</i>	6.0–7.5	2cm deep (seed)	✅ Large 20L+ container with support	☀️	Climbing roses, clematis; vegetable garden	15–20cm between plants against support
P31	Sweet William	<i>Dianthus barbatus</i>	5.8–6.5	At pot level	✅ 25–30cm / 10L+	☀️	Pinks, stocks, foxgloves, wallflowers, roses	30cm between plants
P32	Toadflax	<i>Linaria vulgaris</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level / surface-sown seed	✅ 5L+ container	☀️ to 🌧️	Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wildflower meadow	20–30cm between plants; spreads readily
G19	Tree Heath	<i>Erica arborea</i>	5.0–6.5	At pot level	⚠️ Large 40–50L container	☀️	Blueberry, lingonberry, ornamental grasses	1–1.5m between plants; hardier var. <i>alpina</i> available
P15	Trollius (Globeflower)	<i>Trollius europaeus</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✅ 20–30L container, keep moist	☀️ to 🌧️	Astilbe, hosta, candelabra primulas	30–40cm between plants
B22	Tulip	<i>Tulipa</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	20cm (3× bulb height); autumn	✅ Excellent: 25–30cm / 10L+	☀️	Forget-me-nots, daffodils, alliums, wallflowers	10–15cm between bulbs
B23	Turkestan Tulip	<i>Tulipa turkestanica</i>	6.0–7.5	10cm deep; autumn	✅ Raised bed/pot	☀️	Crocus, dwarf iris, other early species bulbs	8–10cm between bulbs
P33	Vervain	<i>Verbena officinalis</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✅ 10–15L container	☀️ to 🌧️	Lavender, catmint, ornamental grasses	20–30cm between plants
C10	Vicia (Tufted Vetch)	<i>Vicia cracca</i>	6.0–7.5	1–2cm (seed) / at pot level	✅ 5L+ container	☀️ to 🌧️	Grasses, wildflower meadow species, hedgerow shrubs	20–30cm between plants; scrambles via tendrils
C11	Virginia Creeper	<i>Parthenocissus quinquefolia</i>	5.5–7.5	At pot level	✅ 30–40L container	☀️	Ivy (same wall), late clematis	1.5–3m between plants
G11	Wall Pennywort	<i>Umbilicus rupestris</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level / wall crevice	✅ Small pot or wall crevice	🌧️	Ivy, ferns, sempervivum, saxifrage	15–20cm between plants
W22	Water Forget-me-not	<i>Myosotis scorpioides</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil surface; up to 10cm water above	✅ Aquatic basket	☀️ to 🌧️	Yellow flag iris, marsh marigold, bogbean	15–30cm between plants
W23	Water Mint	<i>Mentha aquatica</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil surface; up to 25cm water above	✅ Aquatic basket	☀️	Bog pimpernel, yellow flag iris	30–45cm between plants; ⚠️ vigorous
W24	Water Soldier	<i>Stratiotes aloides</i>	6.0–7.5 (water)	Floats just below surface, sinks in winter	✅ No planting needed; free-floating	☀️	Frogbit, native water lilies	Allow to spread; thin if congested
W25	Water Violet	<i>Hottonia palustris</i>	6.0–7.5 (water)	Mostly submerged; do not disturb in summer	✅ No planting needed; free-floating	☀️ to 🌧️	Hornwort, common water crowfoot	Allow to spread loosely
W26	Watershield	<i>Brasenia schreberi</i>	6.0–7.5 (water, estimated)	Rhizome in mud; floating leaves	⚠️ Aquatic basket; limited Irish availability	☀️ to 🌧️	Water lilies	Allow room to spread
B24	Whittall's Tulip	<i>Tulipa orphanidea</i>	6.0–7.5	10–15cm deep; autumn	✅ Raised bed/pot	☀️	Crocus, grape hyacinth, other species tulips	8–10cm between bulbs

#	English Name	Latin Name	pH	Planting Depth	In Pot?	Light	Key Companions	Spacing
G14	Wild Thyme	<i>Thymus polytrichus</i>	6.5–7.5	At pot level	✔ Trough/rockery, 3–5L	☀	Sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort	20–30cm between plants; spreads by runners
B25	Wild Tulip	<i>Tulipa sylvestris</i>	6.0–7.5	10–15cm deep; autumn	✔ 5L+ container	☀ to ☀	Daffodils, other naturalising bulbs	10–15cm between bulbs
W27	Willow Moss	<i>Fontinalis antipyretica</i>	6.0–7.5 (water)	Attach to submerged stone/wood	✔ No soil needed; attach to stone	☀ to ☀	Hornwort, common water crowfoot	Space stones/clumps as desired
G17	Winter Heath (Winter Heather)	<i>Erica carnea</i>	5.5–7.5	At pot level	✔ 20–25cm / 5–10L ericaceous or multipurpose compost	☀	Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses	30–45cm between plants
C20	Winter-flowering Clematis	<i>Clematis urophylla</i> 'Winter Beauty'	6.5–7.5	At pot level (evergreen type)	✔ Large container against support	☀	Climbing hydrangea, ivy	2–3m between plants against support
C12	Wisteria	<i>Wisteria sinensis</i> / <i>floribunda</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level; graft above soil	⚠ 45cm/60L+ container	☀	Climbing roses (same wall), alliums, irises	45cm from wall; 3m between plants
S9	Wood Sorrel	<i>Oxalis acetosella</i>	5.0–6.5	Crown at soil level	✔ 5L+ container	🌑 to ☀	Ferns, native mosses, primroses	10–15cm between plants
F19	Woodland Strawberry	<i>Fragaria vesca</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✔ 20–30L container	☀ to ☁	Ferns, hostas, primroses	25–30cm between plants; spreads by runners
P34	Yarrow	<i>Achillea millefolium</i>	5.5–7.0	At pot level; bare-root buds 2–3cm below	✔ 30cm / 10L+	☀	Roses, salvia, echinacea, hydrangea, ornamental grasses	30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs
P36	Yellow Flag Iris	<i>Iris pseudacorus</i>	5.5–8.0	Crown at soil level; 0–20cm water above	✔ 19–24cm aquatic basket	☀	White water lily, bogbean, bog pimpernel	30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs
W9	Yellow Loosestrife	<i>Lysimachia vulgaris</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✔ 20L+ container, keep moist	☀ to ☁	Meadowsweet, yellow flag iris, marsh marigold	40–50cm between plants; spreads by rhizome
W28	Yellow Water Lily	<i>Nuphar lutea</i>	6.5–7.5 (water)	Crown at basket surface; 45–150cm+ water above	⚠ Large ponds/lakes only, not for small pots	☀ to ☀	Native white water lily, bogbean	1–2m ultimate spread
H16	Zucchini (Courgette)	<i>Cucurbita pepo</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level (after frost)	✔ Large 30–40L container	☀	Nasturtiums, sweetcorn, beans	60–90cm between plants

KEY GROUPS

Ericaceous plants (acid-lovers — never add lime near these):

Blueberry · Heather (*Calluna vulgaris*) · Heather (*Erica* spp.) · Lingonberry · Cranberry · Japanese Maple (partial) · Deer Fern · Royal Fern · Japanese Skimmia · Dicksonia antarctica (partial) · Japanese Camellia · Prickly Heath · St Patrick's Cabbage

Best clay-tolerant plants on your list:

Virginia Creeper · Ivy · Hops · Bamboo (clump-forming) · Astilbe · Japanese Anemone · Bergenia · Hellebore · Male Fern · Royal Fern · Forsythia · Blackcurrant · Blackberries · Honeyberry · Hostas · Holly · Irish Yew · Climbing Hydrangea · Hydrangea macrophylla · Meadowsweet · Yellow Flag Iris · Snowflake (Leucojum) · Periwinkle · Native Bluebells · Daylilies · Common Hawthorn · Mountain Ash (Rowan) · Sorbaria sorbifolia · Marsh Marigold · Trollius · Yellow Loosestrife

Needs raised bed or exceptional drainage on Irish clay:

Rosemary · Lavender · Pasqueflower · Fritillaria imperialis · Acidanthera · Thyme · Creeping Juniper · Ranunculus · Tulips (or annual pots) · Dianthus pinks · Sweet William · Phlox subulata · Bearded Iris · Dwarf Iris · Allium · Sempervivum · Saxifrage · Campanula saxifraga · Edelweiss · Auricula · Siberian Statice · Linum

Must be in containers on wet Irish clay:

Blueberry · Cranberry · Lingonberry (unless naturally acidic area) · Mint (to contain spread) · Melissa/Lemon Balm (to contain spread) · Pasqueflower (strongly recommended) · Ranunculus (best practice) · Rosemary (or raised bed) · Lavender (or raised bed) · Heather (if clay is not acidic enough) · Freesia (tender) · Ixia (borderline hardy) · Iron Cross Oxalis (lift over winter)

Pond/water plants — water depth guide:

- **Deep water (90–150cm):** Native White Water Lily (*Nymphaea alba*)
- **Shallow water (0–25cm) / pond margin:** Yellow Flag Iris, Bogbean, Bog Pimpernel, Marsh Marigold
- **Bog/damp margin (not submerged but consistently moist):** Meadowsweet, Bog Pimpernel, Royal Fern, Astilbe, Trollius, Yellow Loosestrife, Marsh Orchids
- **Permanently wet, acid bog only:** Bog Asphodel

Toxic plants — site away from children, pets and livestock:

Holly (berries) · Irish Yew (all parts except berry flesh) · Snowdrops · Daffodils · Bluebells (native and Spanish) · Fritillaria · Aconitum/ Monkshood (all parts, sap irritates skin) · Convallaria/Lily of the Valley (all parts) · Adonis (all parts) · Bog Asphodel (foliage, to livestock) · Japanese Skimmia (berries, mildly)

Sources: RHS Growing Guides (rhs.org.uk), gardens4you.ie product listings (P22 rootstock; Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia'), Future Forests Ireland (futureforests.ie), Irish Seed Savers Association (irishseedsavers.ie), NC State Extension Plant Toolbox (plants.ces.ncsu.edu), Plants For A Future (pfaf.org), Missouri Botanical Garden Plant Finder, BBC Gardeners' World Magazine (gardenersworld.com), Garden UK (gardenuk.co.uk), Thompson & Morgan, Farmer Gracy, Wild Your Garden, Wetland Plants UK, Plants for Ponds, Pond Informer (pondinformer.com), White Flower Farm, Hydrangea.com, Plantura (plantura.garden), Gardenia.net, Old Farmer's Almanac, Hardy Plant Society, Sarah Raven, Wilson Bros Gardens, Garden Design (gardendesign.com), Wayside Gardens, GrowItBuildIt.com, Trehane Nursery, Primrose Hall Peonies, Pomona Fruits, Ashridge Trees, Wildflowers of Ireland (wildflowersofireland.net), Flora of Northern Ireland (habitas.org.uk), BSBI (bsbi.org), First Nature (first-nature.com), British Bryological Society (britishbryologicalsociety.org.uk), Woodland Trust (woodlandtrust.org.uk), Irish Peatland Conservation Council (ipcc.ie).